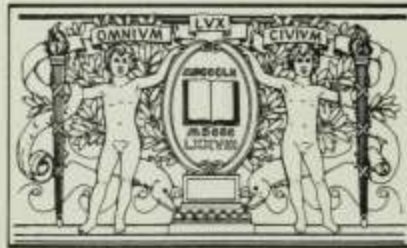


CARIBBEAN BLUES

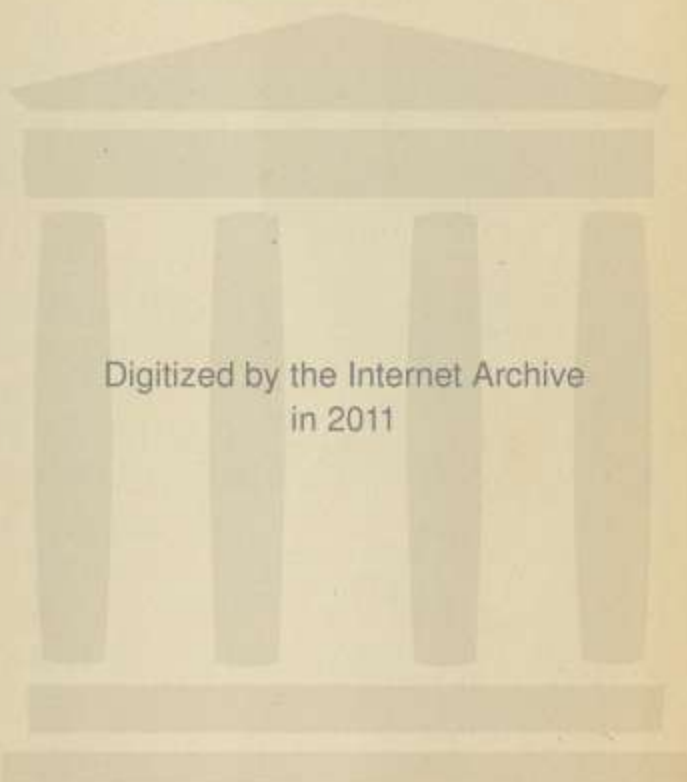
MARY HIGGINS CLARK
MOLLY COCHRAN
MAX ALLAN COLLINS
GREGORY Mc DONALD
RICHARD MEYERS
WARREN MURPHY
AND
ROBERT J. RANDISI





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CARIBBEAN BLUES

Mary Higgins Clark, Molly Cochran,
Max Allan Collins, Gregory McDonald,
Richard Meyers, Warren Murphy, and
Robert J. Randisi

Seven of America's top mystery authors
have joined together to write one unique
novel packed with SUSPENSE,
INTRIGUE, ROMANCE, MAYHEM
and MURDER all of which takes place
on a cruise ship.

Written in the classic
"WHODUNIT" style, the case is
eventually solved by a group of private
eyes.

Caribbean Blues

MARY HIGGINS CLARK

**Molly Cochran, Max Allan Collins,
Gregory McDonald, Richard Meyers,
Warren Murphy and Robert J. Randisi**

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THE PERPETRATORS

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*' CARIBBEAN BLUES

The two of us had just returned from a Bogie's Murderous Mystery Tours weekend at the Parker House, in Boston. In addition to Warren Murphy, Molly Cochran, and Marian Babson, Robert B. Parker was also a guest of honor. Bob had just received an award for his work in helping adults learn to read.

We had become very aware of the shocking statistics of illiteracy, and decided that we would like to do something to make the rest of the country more aware of this terrible condition. Twenty-seven percent of all Americans are functionally illiterate!

There we were, a few weeks later, sitting over a couple of drinks at our restaurant. Bogie's, with Warren Murphy, who was busily scribbling notes on cocktail napkins. Following through on one of his better ideas, Warren suggested that we write a murder mystery scenario to be perpetrated on board

a cruise ship. The authors portraying the characters would each write a couple of chapters for a book to be published; the book would be written as if the murders were actually taking place during the cruise. Paper Jacks publisher Tony Seidl^ who was also sitting with us^ immediately agreed that he "could do that."

A few months later^ the Cunard Line hired us to perpetrate a murder mystery during a Caribbean cruise. From May 16-23 1973 we would be littering "murdered" bodies on the Cunard Countess (British Registry)^ and around the Caribbean Islands! The perfect opportunity to realize our plans!

Each author we invited on the cruise was told about our plan to write this book and to donate the advance to help fight illiteracy. Mary Higgins Clark requested that the donation be made to the New York City branch of the Literacy Volunteers of America. Each of the authors immediately volunteered to write at least two chapters of the book! Max Allan Collins suggested that each author choose a fictional private eye to investigate the crime^ and he or she would interrogate the suspect whom the author was portraying.

As the book progressed it became a true genre crossover. Our basic scenario^ as

enacted on the ship, was written in the classic "whodunit" style, while in the book, the case is eventually solved by a group of private eyes!

Now, we realize that multiple collaborations have appeared before (about fifty years ago in the mystery genre), but they were written in a round robin. That is, the first author wrote the first chapter and then passed it to the second author who then wrote the second chapter, etc. What is truly unique about this novel, however, is that for the first time a book has been written simultaneously by several authors! Never before has a book been written in this manner - by so many authors, on a ship, and all in one week!!!

Upon disembarkation in San Juan, the book was complete.

And how do the authors feel?

Greg McDonald probably best expressed it when he said, "It reminds me of the politician's wife, who, a week after the publication of her book, when asked how she liked it, replied, 'I don't know, I haven't read it yet.

PROLOGUE

It is May 16, 1938. In Europe, war clouds are gathering. But as in every era, the rich are getting richer and a favorite delight of the privileged is a cruise through the Caribbean. Today, that jewel of a luxury liner, the first Cunard Countess, is sailing at eight p.m. Only a few of the passengers who boarded the ship that sunny May afternoon knew that this trip would be different.

On board, there came the usual sprinkling of cafe society folk, the celebrities, who years later would become known as the "jet set." Up the gangplank in stately procession marched the fabulously wealthy, surrounded by their personal entourages, secretaries, maids, companions. The stunning Lady Hannah is clearly the most exotic of these passengers to embark. Besides the usual fawning lackies, her personal psychic also accompanies her. And oblivious of the covetous eyes that follow her, she triumphantly glides aboard wearing the exquisite matched sapphires known throughout the world as the Caribbean Blues.

The socially impeccable^ absorbed in themselves^ the honeymooners absorbed in each other^ the middle-aged travelers^ thrilling to the realized dream of the cruise they'd saved for all these years; the distinguished captain; the charming and efficient officers; the superbly trained staff. It ought to have added up to a week of pampered luxury and relaxation.

But within hours of sailings chaos broke out. Murder most foul destroyed the serene atmosphere of the floating liner. Inexplicably ^ the lights went out. A shriek was heard. The dance floor in the salon^ so accustomed to gliding feet^ experienced the stumblings shuddering steps of a man as he collapsed into the fearful darkness that is death. The climate of murder has been set^ and before it is over it will claim more victims.

Was it simply fortuitous that seven of the most famous and infamous private investigators were aboard this cruise? Was it sheer coincidence that they had decided to hold the first convention to exchange views of methods of detection and then found themselves bonded in an effort both reluctantly cooperative and fiercely competitive to solve the case of the Caribbean Blues?

Lady Hannah^ the flamboyant beauty who

had clawed her way from a tenement walk-up through various lovers until she managed to catch the eye and capture the heart of E^emitrio Finestra^ the hotel builder who was reported to be Conrad Hilton's keenest competitor^ caused great interest. But anyone who knew Demitrio broke into raucous laughter at that fable. Demitrio was a humbler^ dependent on the brains and acumen of his three partners^ and when the stock market

crashed^ he^ like so many of his peers^ threw open the window of his office and tumbled into eternity.

Two of Demitrio's partners are on the cruise at the invitation of Lady Hannah. The third was recently deceased.

What of Hilda Johnson^ the inquisitive^ lady-like journalist? The eccentric clergyman whose verbal attack on Lady Hannah shocks the elegant gathering that first evening in the salon? The mysterious import-export tycoon?

Who are these other people in Lady Hannah's entourage? The personal psychic who did not contact her spirit guides and Tarot cards in time to give warning. The moody secretary who had bailed out Lady Hannah after the insurance company refused to pay Demitrio's multimillion-dollar policy? You see^ it didn't cover suicide. The Oriental

personal maid who believes so avidly in the curse of the sapphires? The bandleader from Cuba who knows so much about Lady Hannah's affairs? The titled big-game hunter without a farthing in his pocket?

Each and every one of them intimately involved with Lady Hannah at some point in their lives. All of them hating her. One of them in that most awful of human predicaments^ loving and hating her with equal and agonizing fervor.

The ship glides through the seas to the fabled islands that are the playgrounds of the rich. The private investigators band together to solve the deaths^ to keep the killer from striking again. The exquisite cerulean blue of the sea and sky darken at night to a velvety blackness ablaze with stars^ stars that almost equal the fire of Lady Hannah's sapphires.

A warning blast of the horn trumpets throughout the ship. Last call for visitors to go ashore. We invite the rest of you to become our fellow passengers^ to join us on our cruise. Come. Let us sail away.

Chapter 1

The giant cruise ship had arrived during the night at the pier on the edge of San Juan's Old City in Puerto Rico.

Throughout the hours of darkness, the ship's crew had cleaned and polished and restocked, and when the brilliant Caribbean sun exploded over the waterfront in the morning, the Cunard Countess sparkled white and trim as she rocked gently in the light Puerto Rican trade breezes, waiting for her passengers to arrive.

It was 1938 and the captain and crew of the Countess expected that this would be their last leisurely vacation run through the Caribbean. Any day now, they expected the teletype to spit out orders that would send them home to England, where the Countess would be refitted as a warship of His Majesty's Navy.

And all because of some silly-looking moustachioed rotter who was jackbooting it around Germany and had them all fired up there with his talk of world domination. Well, Great Britain would simply have to

teach him a lesson^ as it had taught lessons to so many would-be world conquerors before. This one might even be easy. It shouldn't take more than a couple of weeks to give that lunatic little paperhanger what-for.

But that was the future. For the present;, the Cunard Countess was the world's most elegant warm-water cruising ship. And if this was to be its last peaceful voyage^ the officers and crew were determined to make it the best cruise yet.

So let it all be fun and games, the ship's captain thought. Time for death later.

By late afternoon^ all the passengers had come aboard and the giant ship had slipped its moorings and gently rode a rising tide out into the turquoise waters of the Caribbean. As the Countess cruised calmly past the scarred battlements of El Morro Fort on the tip of Old San Juan^ cocktail parties started up all over the ship^ as the 750 passengers prepared to put aside^ for at least a week^ all the worries of the outside world. For the next seven days

this 17,500-ton behemoth would be their universe, and let the rest of the world, with its troubles and problems, keep its distance.

In one of the lounge rooms on a top deck

of the ship:, two separate small parties were under way.

At one end of the room^ near a service bar staffed by a red-faced round man who seemed to have no discernible bones in his body^ six men were sprawled out in heavily cushioned chairs. A young woman^ with Oriental features and long blue-black hair^ stood at an observation window^ looking out over the sea as El Morro Fort slowly disappeared behind them. She was the only one of the seven who did not have a drink in her hand.

"Trace^, come here/" she said. Her voice was soft and musical.

"Yes^ sir/" grumbled a tall, light-haired man who sat about ten feet from her. He got slowly to his feet, holding tightly onto a glass of straight gin on the rocks, and walked to the window alongside her. He leaned there, looking back around the room, as the young woman said, "Isn't it beautiful?"

Devlin Tracy said, "Sure is."

But he was not looking at the ocean outside. His eyes were fixed on the other end of the lounge, where a dozen people were milling about in a private cocktail party of their own. The people seemed to be moving about at random, but a trained eye could see that the locus of their movements was a

petite dark-haired woman. She was wearing a red dress with matching hat and shoes. The hat was gargantuan and seemed designed to display half the annual agricultural output of Puerto Rico. It was fixed to her hair with a hatpin that seemed to be a foot long, and anyone looking at the woman would not have been able to take his eyes off the monstrous hat had it not been for two things: first, the woman was magnificently beautiful; and second, around her neck she wore a very elaborate necklace, created around a centerpiece of three giant blue stones.

The woman's eyes met Devlin Tracy's briefly. Then she turned away with an expression of total disinterest on her face. It was a wonderful face, Tracy thought, and who knew? On a seven-day cruise, he might just be able to change that disinterested look.

"So this is the way it's going to be?" asked the young Oriental woman standing next to him.

"What? Did you say something, Chico, my dear?" Tracy asked.

"Yes, I did."

"Would you mind repeating it? My mind was elsewhere," Tracy said.

"Of course it was, and I know where. Listen. We have barely pulled out of port and already you're giving the eye to other

women? That's what I said. Is this the way it's going to be for seven full days?"

"Chico, listen," Tracy said as he nodded toward one of the loudspeakers mounted high up on the wall of the room, over the main entrance doors.

"They're playing our song. 'I Only Have Eyes for You.'"

"Well, thank you, idiot," she said. "But they're playing 'Take the A Train.'"

Tracy shrugged. "I knew it was something like that. And anyway, don't get upset with me already. We just started our vacation and I couldn't help looking at that woman. You know, it's like scenery. You like to look at old castles and water that's got fish swimming around underneath it. I like to look at women. It's all scenery."

"Just don't try crawling around in the scenery," the young woman said.

"And especially her. Look at her. A blue stone necklace with a red dress. She looks like something out of the chorus line at Minsky's."

"Minsky's should be so lucky," Devlin Tracy said.

Another voice pitched in.

"She could buy and sell Minsky's," the speaker said.

"Yeah. Tell her, Heller," said Tracy. "Tell

her I'm not ogling some refugee from a burlesque show."

Heller, the new speaker, was a tall, sandy-haired man with a vaguely professional look, but there were scars around his eyes and on the backs of his hands that made it clear he had spent at least some of his life hitting something other than books.

"That's Lady Hannah from Havana," Heller said. Chico looked impressed, but Tracy said, "Who exactly is Lady Hannah from Havana?"

Chico said, "Oh, Trace, you don't know anything about anything. Lady Hannah runs a world-famous resort and nightclub in Cuba and is fabulously wealthy."

"I don't hang out in nightclubs," Trace said.

"No," Chico said. "I've noticed. Cheap gin mills and blue-plate-special restaurants are more your speed. What could you be expected to know about money and class?"

"To refresh your memory, my dear Miss Michiko Mangini," Tracy said, "I am not the person who was complaining about her wearing blue stones with a red dress."

"That was before I knew she was real rich," Chico said.

"That necklace," Heller said. "Those stones are the Caribbean Blues."

"I thought the Caribbean Blues was a baseball team," Tracy said. "Three perfectly matched sapphires," Heller said. "Some people say they have a curse on them."

"Yeah," Chico said. "Wear them and you

go color blind. You start wearing any color

L dress. And look at that hat. Will you please

' look at that hat she's wearing? Quick, call

Hollywood. Tell them not to renew Carmen

Miranda's contract."

"Suppose we drop this subject," Tracy said. "I just don't know what your fascination is with that woman anyway, Chico. Listen, Heller, rescue me. Tell me about this organization."

Heller nodded but he continued to watch Lady Hannah at the far end of the room. She was accepting a glass of champagne from a tray held by a ship's officer who wore a sparkling white uniform with three strings of gold braid around the cuffs.

"The reason I've invited you all along," Heller said, "is that I think it's time that we private detectives had an organization of our own."

"If you're starting a union, count me out," Tracy said. "I don't trust unions. They're all Communists."

"He thinks everybody's a Communist,"

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Chico explained. "What's the point of the organization, Heller? Hey, what's your first name? I just can't keep calling you Heller."

"Nate," Heller said. "Anyway, no, not like a labor union. More like a professional association. We could trade techniques; share information. We could help each other in different cities. And maybe we could think about raising our fees."

"I'm for that," Trace said. "This living on twenty-five dollars a day plus expenses isn't for me, especially since Chico seems to want me to start taking her to expensive nightclubs."

"So that's why I got you all here," Heller said. "You two with your agency in New York City and Jack Miles over there. He's in New York, too." Heller pointed to a stocky man with a mashed nose who was sprawled on a sofa, drinking beer from a bottle.

"We don't travel in the same circles," Trace said, looking at Miles. "I go more for tony clients."

"Not quite," Chico said. "We go for anybody who can pay the bill."

"Like the rest of us, I guess," Heller said as he nodded and continued. "And I'm from Chicago, and Andy Baltimore is from Los Angeles. Phil Phlem works out of Boston.

And Leslie Dither pretty much specialHzes in overseas work. I think we've got a pretty good group here to form an organization."

Trace looked around at the other detectives, rating them quickly. Phil Phlem looked dry, humorless, about what Trace would expect from a Boston private eye. The only real crimes committed in Boston were committed by politicians, and nobody ever needed to hire a detective to find out about them. Pubhc corruption in Boston was just that - public, and everybody above the age of five knew all about it. Boston P.I.'s must specialize in divorce cases if they didn't want to starve. Trace thought.

Jack Miles, the other New York private investigator, had the face of the prizefighter he had once been. His clients. Trace knew, were generally people who were down on their luck, the losers of the world, the old pugs and the bimbos and cashiered cops and jockeys who took bribes, the kind who paid one off in thanks and good wishes and by saying a novena at the local church. If they sobered up enough to get there.

The unfortunate truth was that Miles's client list sounded a lot like the one for Trace and Chico's agency. Except Miles seemed to want them as clients.

Trace wanted only multi-millionaires; it was just the luck of the draw that he and Chico also seemed to attract bums into their office.

LesHe Dither looked like no one in the field that Trace had ever met. He was a short man with eyeglasses, not physical-looking. His face was fixed in a constant smile, and his hands kept reaching for a bowl of peanuts next to his lounge seat. But there was something vaguely foreign, almost elegant, about his mannerisms, and Trace could understand how he might do most of his work in Europe.

Andy Baltimore was from Los Angeles, Heller had said. He was another stranger to Trace, but his mannerisms were pure California, in Trace's book. Californians always seemed to be doing one thing while they were actually doing something else. Right now, for instance, Baltimore was busy talking to Phil Phlem, but his eyes were looking past the Boston investigator, fixed on the far end of the room where Lady Hannah was holding court. And he had a beard. Trace thought only degenerates and Vikings wore beards.

About Heller himself. Trace knew little. The man had a pretty good reputation as an operative in Chicago, America's toughest city. And his reputation had gone sky-high in Trace's mind when Heller had called and

offered him and Chico a free Caribbean cruise to discuss the new private detectives' association he wanted to form. Trace thought it was a stupid idea, but for a free cruise he would listen to any kind of stupid idea. Hell, for a free cruise he'd listen to someone who wanted him to invest in radio... with pictures.

But Trace had a suspicion. He had a suspicion that Heller had something more in mind than just talking to them about the United States Private Eye Association. There weren't any free lunches - despite that madman Roosevelt in the White House - and Trace felt pretty certain that Heller was going to ask them to do something for him.

Chapter 2

"You're Tracy, aren't you?"

Jack Miles spoke with an accent that would have been at home only in Hell's Kitchen on New York City's west side.

He had seen Tracy and the beautiful Oriental woman talking to Heller, and now that Hiller had sort of drifted down to the other end of the lounge where that party of

rich folks was boozing it up, Miles thought that this Devlin Tracy might have some answers for him.

Like what were they doing here, for openers? Nobody had ever yet given Miles a free cruise to anywhere, except to the hospital, and he didn't expect that this trip was going to be any exception. He'd wind up paying for it; he'd like to know how and when.

"Right. Devlin Tracy," the tall blond man said. He glanced over his shoulder to look for the pretty Oriental, but she was talking to that guy from Boston. The guy from Boston had moved right in. Miles thought he was pretty smooth, even if he did look like a car thief. "Jack Miles?"

"The one and only," Miles said. "So now you've been talking to Heller. Tell me, what did you find out?"

"About what?"

"About what we're doing here," Miles said.

"He says we're forming a new association of private eyes," Trace said.

And you believe him?" Miles asked. No, I didn't say that," Trace said. No, I didn't think you were that dumb," Miles said. He took a long draft from a fresh bottle of Rheingold beer, which the ship had

stocked especially for him. It was a local New York beer and it was cheap and good and predictable, and Miles didn't like surprises. Which was why he was talking to this Tracy, a guy who was obviously born with a silver spoon in his mouth, never had to worry about where his next meal was

coming from, and probably played private detective to fill up the time between the checks from Daddy's trust account.

"I'd expect you to be an expert," Trace said.

"What? Expert?"

"In dumb," Trace said.

Miles took another long sip of beer before answering. "Tracy," he said finally, "you know, this can be a long trip or a short one. Or, for you, it can be a short one that seems awfully long. I think we'll all have a better time if you keep your snotty remarks to yourself."

"What weight did you fight at?" Trace asked.

"One-forty-seven and a half," Miles said.

"What do you weigh now?"

"One-forty-seven and a half," Miles answered.

"Were you any good?" Trace asked.

"Except for a lousy manager, I coulda been a contender."

"Okay, if you were good and you're still at your fighting weight, let's be friends," Trace said. "What do you think we're here for?"

"Something sleazy," Miles said.

Trace shrugged. "Naturally. Why else would they call us?"

"And somehow, I think it has something to do with that party down at the other end."

"How's that?" Trace said.

"Because Heller knows more about all those people than their relatives do. He's here for something to do with them and he's dragged us along to help out."

"You know the way I look at it?" Trace asked.

"How's that?"

"Nobody's been knocking down my door to hire me. So if somebody's going to give me a free cruise and free booze and a free room, what the hell. Count me in."

I just don't like being used," Miles said, unless I know who's using me and for what."

"Well, maybe we'll find out if we go down there and circulate," Trace said.

Miles rose from the gray chair and started to walk with the taller man toward the other end of the room. But first he tugged at

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Trace's arm. "The little Chinese girl. Aren't you going to bring her?"

"Do yourself a favor, Miles. Japanese, not Chinese. And I would get ten steps before she finds out I'm missing and she's after me.

"Are you two - what does Walter Winchell say? - 'an item?'"

"Partners and items," Tracy said. "Why do you ask?"

"Well, if she's taken, I won't go running around after her."

"Good thinking," Trace said. "She's taken."

Chapter 3

Leslie Dither thought that it was odd. He and the other private detectives had followed Trace and Jack Miles down toward the other end of the room and were mingling with the guests in the other party.

Dither had said, "Why not, old chaps? It looks like they're having more fun than we are."

But what was odd was the ship's officer. Dither had sailed across the Atlantic many

times on ships, and by the three stripes on the man's sleeve, he could tell he was a high-ranking officer. But, instead of being "officerly," he was standing around, holding a tray of drinks, obviously unwilling to take his eyes off Lady Hannah. He stood at her side all the while, and when Dither took a drink of champagne from his tray, the officer kind of glared at him.

Very strange behavior. Dither thought. But his brief puzzlement didn't stop him from tasting the bubbly. It was dry and light. A very good wine, he thought. Lady Hannah, whoever she might be, had good taste in wine, if not in ship's officers. The man looked nothing like a ship's officer. He looked hard and weather-bitten, and while ship's officers might look weather-bitten, they also always seemed to have a veneer of sophistication, poise. This man did nothing but stand and stare.

Maybe that wasn't so unusual. Lady Hannah, Dither thought, was certainly worth staring at. He guessed her age at the mid-thirties, but she could have been anything from twenty-five to forty-five. Her skin was flawless, and although it seemed healthily tan, it was absolutely unwrinkled by either age or sun. Her eyes were dark, a velvety brown, and her lips were full and sensual.

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Her body was trim and shapely^ rather than full and lush^ but the way she moved under her red dress gave the impression of a woman of animal smoothness and strength. She seemed to smile a lot^ but when her gaze turned on some members of her party^ there was no good humor in her glance.

Something was going on here^ Dither thought. But he didn't know what.

There was a shout from the doorway and everyone turned. A short man^ red-faced to the point of apoplexy^ ran into the room. He wore a dark suit and a clerical collar.

Only Dither was sure what the man had shouted. To the others in the room it sounded like a guttural shouts but to Dither it was clear. The man had shouted^ "Ich brauche, ich brauche" -"I need^ I need."

Before anyone could stop him^ he had raced across the floor and had come toward Lady Hannah. The ship's officer^ who was still hanging around^ handed his tray of champagne glasses to someone else and stepped in front of the small woman.

The sudden appearance of the big man in the white uniform in his line of attack seemed to slow down the mysterious minister. He stopped^ seemed to think for a moment^, then pointed an accusing finger at Lady Hannah.

"You must give them back/" he pro-

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claimed in thick German-accented English. He pronounced give as "giff."

Later people would remark on how cool Lady Hannah seemed to be. She merely smiled; she did not flinch from the man's physical assault, and said, "My dear man, give what back?"

"You know. You know. Those jewels. You must repent and return them, before the curse strikes you."

Hannah laughed, a sparkling laugh that seemed at home at a champagne party.

"Curse?" she queried. "The only curse I know is when the bar runs dry."

"Hussy," the clergyman said. "Shameless, sinful woman. I was there, you know. And I read the inscription: 'Death to all who violate this resting

place.' You must return those jewels or your life is forfeit."

"Please remove this man," Hannah said coldly to no one in particular.

Nate Heller stepped forward and said, "I think that's just about enough of that." He looked to the ship's officer. They nodded to each other and then each grabbed an elbow and dragged the clergyman toward the door.

He shouted as they pulled him away. "Death to all who violate this resting place! Death, you hear me! Death!" Then he was gone through the door.

I

"Well," Trace said aloud, "the party's complete now. We have our comic-opera German."

Lady Hannah glanced at him and smiled. Chico moved up closer to Trace's side.

Looking at Trace, the woman with the blue jewels said, "I want to apologize to everyone for this interruption. I hope we'll all just go on with the party." Chico saw her incline her head ever so slightly toward Trace. "I hope I'll be able to make up for it to all of you later. Somehow."

Chico pulled Trace away. "Somehow. I'm sure she could figure out just how without too much trouble."

"I'll bet he was a Nazi," Trace said.

"Nazis?" For five years you've been seeing a Communist under every bed. Is it now going to be Nazis everywhere?"

"There's a lot of it going around," Trace said.

"Forget that," Chico said. "Did you see what happened?"

"Of course I saw what happened. I was right here."

"Did you see Heller?"

"What about Heller?"

"He took charge," Chico said. "He said it was time to get that madman out of here, and it was only after he said it that the ship's

officer made a move. It was like he was taking orders from Heller."

"I think something's afoot around here," Trace said. "And I don't like it. I think it's going to mean more work for us."

The ship's officer in the white uniform and Heller came back into the room. Everyone turned toward them, and the officer cleared his throat nervously, as if he were unaccustomed to speaking to large groups of people.

"Ladies and gentlemen, the man who was just here is Father Peter Blue. Mr. Heller and I have calmed him down and he has apologized for his outburst. He blames it on his long trip from Europe to Puerto Rico to board this ship. He has gone to his room to rest and said he would return in a few minutes and apologize in person. He has promised us that there would be no more such outbursts."

"A Nazi," Trace mumbled. "Nazis are always making promises. I don't trust him."

But, true to his word, the Reverend Peter Blue came back twenty minutes later. He looked abashed by his behavior and went quietly to one of the windows looking out over the darkening Caribbean Sea. As Andy Baltimore, the Los Angeles detective,

watched, Father Blue seemed to be making a herculean effort not to look at Lady Hannah or the jewels around her neck. For her part, if Lady Hannah even knew the man was in the room, she certainly gave no indication of it.

Baltimore saw that the Reverend Blue was concentrating most of his attention on another of the guests in the room. The man he was looking at was tall, with graying sandy hair and an aquiline nose. He wore khaki shorts and a bush jacket. His face was ruddy - the kind of face gotten by a man

who was exposed to the sun a lot but didn't have the kind of skin that tanned well.

"Who is that guy over there?" Baltimore asked an attractive blond woman who was standing next to him. He introduced himself and learned that her name was Willa Wright.

"You mean Lord Hunter."

"A lord?" Baltimore asked.

"Yes. That's Sir L B. Hunter, the world-famous explorer and big-game hunter. Why do you ask?"

Because right now he looks like the hunted. Our little German friend with the holy collar can't seem to take his eyes off him."

"Maybe they're old friends," Willa said casually, then turned and walked away.

Leslie Dither noticed that the ship's officer was back at his usual post, hovering around Lady Hannah's elbow. Every so often the man would glance over his shoulder, as if to reassure himself that Reverend Blue was staying in the corner as he had promised. The minister showed no signs of going anywhere. His face was still red, still apoplectic, but he seemed to be keeping himself under control.

It was dark out now. The party seemed to be winding down. People were taking their last sip of their last glass, when, suddenly, the lights in the lounge went out.

A couple of voices were raised in protest. "Hey! Who turned the lights out? Turn them back on."

"Hey! What's going on?"

Trace was near the door. He fumbled for the light switch, found it, and flicked it back on.

The lights flooded the room again.

There was a scream.

It came from near Lady Hannah, and Trace ran forward. There was a body on the floor at Lady Hannah's feet. The ship's officer in the white uniform lay there on his stomach, his arms sprawled out at his sides. Nate Heller was kneeling alongside him,

searching for a pulse at the man's throat. Trace knelt next to the officer. The man gasped and sputtered a sound. "She..." he seemed to say, then was still.

Heller looked up and his face and voice were anguished. "He's dead," he said.

"Dead?" Chico said. "What? A heart attack? What?"

Lady Hannah shrank back from the dead man at her feet.

Heller said, "There was nothing wrong with his heart. I think he was murdered." He stood up and looked around. "I'd appreciate it if no one left the room."

Chico looked at Phlem, the private detective from Boston. They nodded to each other because each had recognized the significance of something: How had Heller known that the ship's officer did not have a bad heart?

The Cunard Countess docked at Road Town, Tortolia at 11:30 A.M., Sunday, May 17,

1938. The sky was overcast, the weather hot and humid.

Chapter 4

Excerpt from operative's report, case file 714, date May 17, 1938. To the attention of George Donahue, vice-president, Cunard Line. Reporting

operative: Nathan Heller, president, A-1 Detective Agency, Chicago, Illinois. Written en route during Caribbean cruise aboard Cunard Countess.

Okay, George, the first thing we have to get straight is that Fm not going to write you a formal report. We 've been friends too long, and Fm going thoroughly bughouse on this goddamned cruise of yours, thank you very much, and Fm just going to give it to you straight, like it or not. When this affair is behind us, I will, if you insist, write up an overall, formal report that you can share with your superiors. Something clean and tidy and polite.

Which is more than can be said for the first night on your goddamned cruise.

I blame myself, to a degree. I wasn't watching Jonesy, I was watching your precious Lady Hannah and her lousy goddamned Caribbean Blues," and that's exactly what

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/ have right now. But I figured Jonesy could take care of himself^ and why shouldn't I? Fve known - make that I had known - the tough little bastard since our days together on the pickpocket detail of the Chicago P.D. Sure, he took a bribe now and then. But then Fm repeating my self, aren't I? I already said he was a Chicago cop.

Anyway, after the ship's doctor and some stewards gurneyed out what used to be Jonesy, the captain ordered that fancy chrome-and-leather nightclub cleared of all passengers. This was against my advice, as I thought every man jack of 'em (and every woman jack, too, for that matter) ought to be held and questioned. They were witnesses to a probable murder, after all. But grilling the guests, as opposed to the guests' filet mignons, would be a bad show, don't you know. Bloody British.

I asked the various detectives I'd invited aboard for the Private Eye Convention (as the ship's daily programme referred to us) to hang around the club.

It was time to give them the lowdown.

I stood on the shiny dance floor, like an entertainer, and made my speech, while the half dozen in my audience lounged at tables and in booths nearby.

"Maybe you were wondering why a bunch of down-at-the-heels private dicks got a free

ride on a boat like thisy" I said with what I hoped was a tone of wry but good humor.

"That's 'ship/ Heller/" Miles said, screwing up his bulldog's puss. Everything I saidy the ex-pug took wrong. All I had to do was say hello and he got that sniffing-the-base-of-a-tree expression going.

"Is it a coincidence that a killing took place with us on board?" Baltimore asked, his bearded mug a mask of ingenuousness. "Or am I crazy?"

"Does one necessarily rule out the other?" Trace asked from his booth, one hand wrapped around a drink, the other draped over the bare shoulder of the beautiful Oriental dame that I took for his secretary.

"That ship's officer that was killed, " I told them, "was no ship's officer. He was one of

us."

What do you mean, one of 'us'?" Miles demanded, balling his fists, which is one of the better things to do with a fist.

I sighed. "He's an operative, too, " I said. "Or he was. He was working with me. We were partners in the A-1." They exchanged glances that were at once surprised and annoyed - but there was a general tightening around the eyes, too, including the haunting ones of that Oriental dish.

One of our own was down.

'7 got all of us a ^ free passage on this

'pleasure cruise'^'" I told them^ "by agreeing to do a little work on the side. It was nothing Jones and me couldn't handle on our own - that's what I thought^ anyway."

"How shrewd," noted Leslie Dither. Dither was the British representative of our little group. Bloody British.

"It wasn't supposed to involve any of you, " I went on lamely. "A jewel thief's been hitting the Cunard Countess - the last three cruises. It's an embarrassment to the line - they can't do an aboveboard investigation of a thing like that without putting all of their passengers under suspicion. You saw tonight how unwilling they were to do that in a murder case, let alone a theft. So, anyway, I swung this deal with an old friend of mine, name of Donahue, who used to work in Chicago for the transit system but landed a sweet job in New York with this steamship line. When this thief started working the Cunard Countess^, George called me with the job. I happened to be working on putting this association of private investigators together, and, hell, it seemed like an ideal way to get us all under one roof, even if it was a floating one. So I worked a deal with George - kind of under the table, so not a word to anybody else, okay?"

"You did say George was from Chicago,"

said Dither^ "so under-the-counter activities are certainly in character. One might say your mentioning it is a bit redundant."

He left off the "old chap." Thank God. Bloody British.

"So I told George we'd catch his thief and in return he'd give our 'convention' a free ride."

"Looks like your pal Jones did have to pay for his passage^" Phlem pointed out acidly.

The British settled Boston^ you know.

"Jones was my partner^ " I said. "He's not your responsibility - any of you. Finding his killer is up to me. If any of you want to give a hand I wouldn't turn it down. But when the one who did it is brought to bay^ I want him. "

"Revenge^ Mr. Heller?" the pretty Oriental asked. What the hell kind of name was Chico for an Oriental^ anyway? What the hell kind of name was it for any woman. On the other hand if she had a sister named HarpOy I was interested.

"Let me put it this way " I said. "When a man's partner is killed he's supposed to do something about it."

"Oh yeah?" Miles asked with his usual dull-edged sarcasm. "What if you hated his guts?"

"He didn't hate his gutSy" I said. "But it

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doesn't make any difference what I thought of him."

"He's your partner^" Phlem said^ nodding^ "and you're supposed to do something about it."

"Then it happens we're in the detective business^" Chico said.

"I thought you were a secretary^ "I said.

"She's my partner^ okay?" Trace said testily.

"Are we letting women into the association?" Baltimore wondered aloud.

"I don't think that's the issue/" I said. "Putting the bylaws of our association together goes way on the back burner. I've had somebody in my organization murdered^ gentlemen. . . and lady."

And Chico said, "Well, when one of your organization gets killed, it's bad business to let the killer get away with it. "

"It does happen that we're in the detective business," Miles admitted grudgingly.

"Letting the killer get away with it," I said, "is bad all around. Bad for my organization, bad for every detective everywhere. . . ."

"And," Chico said, the smartest of us all, obviously, "this association which we may or may not be organizing - which I may or may not be allowed the honor of joining - is going to

be made to look like a prize boatload of saps should word about this get out."

"Damn!" Miles said. "She's right! A private eye gets bumped off under the noses of a roomful of his fellow eyes. We are going to look stupid!"

"For some of us that comes easier than for otherSy" Trace pointed outy and sipped his drink.

"I got to agree/" Baltimore said ambiguously. "We have to pitch in on this thing. Hellery I'm willing to help you out - and I won't get in your way when the killer shows himself."

' 'Or her selfy" Chico added.

"Mr. Hellery" Dither asked^ "dido you and Mr. Jones know that Lady Hannah would be on board?"

"YeSy " I saidy "we did. That's one of the reasons Jonesy and me thought this thing would fall in place so easy. With those rocks around her necky Lady Hannah was the cheesey and all we had to do was hang around and wait for the rat to make his move. "

Maybe the rat in questiony" Phlem saidy is that eccentric reverend who made that scene earlier - if he is a reverend. "

"I'll have a go at the fathery if you likcy " said Dither.

" Thanksy" I said. God bless the British.

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"Now you're trying to recruit us into this farCy" Trace saidy standings none too sturdily^ but standing. '7 want none of it. A man's gotta do what a man's gotta do right? Welly you're the many Heller. . . do what you gotta do. Mcy I gotta find a men's room. "

"That's 'head' on a shipy "Phlem said.

"It's not for my heady " Trace said.

Chico reached out for his hand and saidy "TracCy we really ought to give Heller a hand."

"I couldn't agree morCy" Trace saidy and put down his drink and began to applaud. "Let's hear it for him! Nate Hellery the con man who got us all on board to do his security work for him."

"That's not truCy DetectivCy" I told them.

"The security job was mine andjonesy's. The

investigators' association is something apart

from all this. It's an idea we need to get back

tOy when I've put this mess behind me. "

"I agree with Hellery" Phlem said. "We need this association so we can link up with each othery and compete with the big boys. Here we all arCy a sorry lot of one- and two-man operationSy each in a different city - welly if we can refer clients to each othery call on each other for out-of-town stuffy then we have a network. We can give the likes of Pinkerton and Hargraves a run for their money. "

"That's zvhat I have in mind. " I said. "It's just that I don't think zce're going to get dozen to business until the guy zcho killed my partner-is brought to

justice. . . justice as I see it, anyzday."

"Where does our jezcel thief fit into this?" Baltimore asked.

"He's the killer. " I said flatly.

"You think he zcas tipped to zvhat you and Jones zcere up to? " Miles asked.

"I don 7 knozi\" I admitted.

"Even if he did/" Trace said, reluctantly drazcn into it, "zchy murder? Xo. it has to be more than that. "

"I think /rV in the best interests of all of us to help Heller out, " Chico said.

"Xo zday in hell," Trace said. He turned 10 her. exasperated. "Look. I let you talk me into taking this crummy cruise just because you say I never rake you anyzchere for fun. U'V//, fine^ zce're here, ^^ur Tm here for fun. not zcork. I got bigger thnigs on my mind!"

She smirked at him. "Like zchat, for instance? "

"Well, this guy Hitler. I think he's a problem. "

She rolled her lovey eyes, shook her head.

'7 don't need any help, " I said. "Let me do some snif'fins around myself. . . . If I find there's

more to this than just my jewel thief, Fll see if any of you still want to lend a hand."

"Look," Chico said. She had great eyes, incidentally. 'Til talk to Lady Hannah tomorrow. . . . The woman's touch might be helpful there. This all started with her - with her jewels."

"The Caribbean Blues/" Phlem said, nodding, as if the rest of us might have forgotten.

"Bloody curse, "Dither said.

"A curse didn't kill Jonesy," I said. "A murderer did." Then I smiled at Chico. "I would appreciate your help with Lady Hannah." Did I mention her eyes?

She smiled back at me. "Glad to. "

Trace rolled his eyes, which weren't lovely unless bloodshot was one's idea of a good time. "I'm finding the John, or head, or whatever the hell, " he said, and shuffled out.

"Do talk to Lady Hannah first thing in the morning, " I said to Chico. "I'm going to spend the next few hours talking to the ship's crew, the staff. . . some of whom were aware of Lady Hannah, her ice, the jewel thief, all of it. It's a place to start poking, anyway. "

"Good luck, " Chico said.

They began to wander out of the showroom, and one by one, each of them to a man (and woman) - despite what they may have thought

about me or the circumstances under which I had got them here - said a word about my partner. Even Miles. And Trace, too - he stopped back in to say it was a damned shame.

And it was and is.

For the rest of this entry, George, I can say only that the evening - what remained of it -was spent by me grilling the various crew members, an effort that produced not a damned thing. Afterward, I drank some rum, which Vm putting on the expense account, and went to my cabin and went to bed, leaving this report till this morning. I dreamed about my dead partner, and then I dreamed about Trace's live one. Both of them made my heart ache.

Chapter 5

Chico woke up^ as she did every morning since she'd made the colossal mistake of agreeing to sleep with DevHn Tracy^ by propping her back against the wall^ drawing her knees in close to her body^ then slamming her legs out in front of her with sufficient force to roll Trace's dead weight onto his own side of the bed.

Trace responded with a snore^ the decibel

level of which set up a vibration in the brass fitting of the bed, creating a high-pitched, tinny hum. Only there was no empty bottle on the nightstand.

Something was very wrong.

She shook Trace awake. "Are you awake?" Chico asked.

"No."

"Are you sober?"

"Hell, no," Trace said. "Leave me alone."

"We're on a ship," Chico said with sudden clarity.

"Give the lady a see-gar."

"And there's been a murder."

Trace sat up, red-eyed and hulking. "There's going to be another one if you don't stop piping. Pipe, pipe, pipe, in that little short person's voice of yours. It drives me crazy."

"Trace, this is important. The ship's officer, remember? The guy named Jones. He wasn't a ship's officer at all. He was a private eye, like us."

"Like me," Trace said. "You're a private pain in the privates."

"I've got a license," Chico said sullenly.

"Gotten through deceit and cajolery. You Orientals are masters of cajolery. You start cajoling and piping, and people end up giving you whatever you want just to keep

you quiet. Pipe, pipe, pipe. Cajole, cajole, cajole."

"Dickhead, dickhead, dickhead," Chico said.

Trace wrapped his pillow around his face. "Why do I put up with this?"

Chico kissed him. "Because you love me."

Trace grunted.

"And because I love you."

She kissed him again. Trace grunted again.

"And because no one else could stand to live with either of us."

In the distance a church bell chimed eight times, then pealed out "A Mighty Fortress Is Our God."

"It's Sunday morning," Chico said, bounding down the length of the bed to look out the porthole. "We're in Tortola. Come look."

"I can't. I'm using all my energy to keep from throwing up while you do gymnastics on my thighs. Look, why don't you go to the dining room and eat a few dozen breakfasts? I'm sure you can cajole the chef into roasting a pig for you."

"Very funny. As a matter of fact, I am leaving. This cabin isn't big enough for me and your breath."

"Remind me to keep breathing."

"And I've got an investigation to conduct

- although breakfast doesn't sound like a bad idea." She leaped, naked, out of bed and slipped into a white sundress.

Chico always wore dresses. She had been a dancer once, and was still vain about her legs. It was one of the things Trace liked about her, along with her waist-length black hair and the fact that it never took Chico more than four minutes to put herself together for any occasion.

What Chico liked about Trace was that he was tall and blond and, on the rare occasions when he wasn't plastered, sensible. Trace was the only sensible American man Chico had ever met. He didn't exercise, believing firmly that a man was born with an allotment of just so many heartbeats and exercise just squandered them. He didn't waste his money on expensive solitary hobbies like fancy cars or small planes, preferring the more sedate joys of speakeasies and gambling dens. And he didn't believe in women's rights, which made it possible for Chico always to get her own way. He was a sensible man, and Chico adored him.

"Tell you what," she said brightly. "I'll go chat up Lady Sadie from Haiti -"

"Lady Hannah from Havana," Trace corrected.

"Whatever. The one with the gorgeous

sapphires." She stuck her thumbs into her belt. "Anyway, sweetheart, I'm going to crack this case and find out what's the poop on this Jones stiff, got it?"

"Pipe, pipe, pipe." Trace sighed. "Humphrey Bogart doesn't pipe. But Hsten, you go do it. Hannah's the killer."

"How do you know that?" Chico asked.

"I heard the dead guy say 'she.' Who else?"

"There are a lot of women on this ship," Chico said.

"All peasants," Trace said. "Trust me. Hannah's the killer. Go get her."

"Okay," she said. "And then I'll meet you in the dining room in one hour. One hour, got it? I'll give you the lowdown then." She swaggered out the door. Before she reached the end of the corridor, she could hear Trace's snoring and the high-pitched hum of the bed fittings. The man was a menace on the open seas.

The aroma from the dining room was almost enough to distract Chico. Food had that effect on her. Food and tall blond men, in that order. She wouldn't have minded three or four Danish pastries, some eggs and ham and sausage, and a few croissants to tide her over until mid-morning brunch. A carafe of orange juice. Maybe some French toast. But she had an investigation to conduct.

Actually, it was Chico's first investigation. She didn't like to admit it, but Trace had been right about cajoling her way into becoming a private detective. She had cajoled Trace into pulling enough strings to ' get her a license. He hadn't had to do it. He could easily have refused her, told her that detectives were well-trained professionals, that a background as a dancer at the Moulin Rouge in Paris and as a blackjack dealer in Monte Carlo were not exactly the proper ; credentials for an investigator in crime. He ; could simply have refused, and grown accustomed to the small discomforts that came from living with a dissatisfied woman, such as a bed covered with broken peanut shells or a liquor cabinet stocked exclusively with near beer.

But no. Trace was a good man. A sensible man. He had come to his senses after only three weeks of near beer and peanut shells. One week after Chico had taken to waking him at six A.M. with a bugle call. Three days after his ex-wife called him demanding more alimony, having received his unlisted phone number anonymously in the mail. Five minutes after Chico had refused to lend him

two hundred dollars for a sure winner at Aqueduct.

What a guy.

She would have to do right by him now and show Trace that his unswerving faith in her detective abilities was not undeserved. Conducting her first investigation, then, was a top priority for Chico, even more important than food.

Prepared to face starvation in order that justice be served, she snatched only one sticky bun from the buffet near the door of the dining room and ate half of it before she reached Lady Hannah's stateroom.

The other- half flew out of her hand and rolled down the corridor when she heard the scream.

It was Susie Tong, Lady Hannah's maid, and .she was standing in Hannah's open doorway, wailing lake a banshee. Chico rushed over, licking caramel syrup off her fingers. "What's the matter," she asked.

Susie pointed a trembling finger toward the floor. There, near the bed, lay the mysterious woman known as Lady Hannah from Havana. Quite dead.

"Cheez-o-man!" Chico said, taking in the scene. Lady Hannah was wearing the same red dress she had worn to the cocktail party

the night before. Her hat lay beside her in a pool of blood.

Aside from the presence of the corpse, though, nothing in the room seemed to be out of kilter. There were no signs of a struggle. The room was immaculate and tidy, except for an envelope and a deck of cards on the bureau. The envelope bore a Boston postmark and was addressed to "Mrs. Hannah Finestra" in Havana.

There was one other thing. The sapphires Lady Hannah had been wearing were not around her neck.

She turned to Susie Tong, and the two pairs of Asian eyes locked. "Where are her jewels?" Chico asked.

Susie stopped shrieking in mid-wail and gasped. "The Caribbean Blues!" she whispered. "The curse is true."

"What curse?" Chico asked.

Susie Tong screamed again. "There... there!" she said, pointing at the deck of cards.

Chico examined them more closely. They were not ordinary cards. It was a Tarot deck, used to tell fortunes.

"The card on top... it is Death," Susie said.

The picture on the card showed a skeleton. Another card, depicting a man and woman

holding hands, had been pulled forward from the deck. "What's this one mean?" Chico asked.

"The Lovers," Susie Tong said, and began to wail again.

Chico grabbed her by both shoulders and shook her. "Get a grip on yourself, Susie," she said. "How about a little Oriental passivity here."

The woman nodded, choking back her tears.

"Now, what was that about a curse?"

"It's the stones," Susie said quietly. "Everyone who has ever owned them has died violently. The last owner was a Cuban millionaire. When his wife was beaten to death on a street in Havana, he gave the jewels to the government. In Cuba, of course, 'the government' means Fulgencio Batista."

"So?" Chico said. "Batista got hold of the Caribbean Blues. How'd Lady Hannah end up with them?"

Susie's gaze lifted upward toward a picture on the nightstand beside the bed. Chico went over to examine it.

It was a photograph of Hannah, taken in some lush tropical nightclub. The well-dressed man beside her, his arm around her shoulders, was General Batista, already

the most powerful force in the history of Cuba.

"Were they lovers?" Chico asked.

"I think that's enough," another woman said from the doorway. She was blond and attractive, despite her prim mode of dress. Chico recognized her from the night before as part of Lady Hannah's entourage. "What's the matter with you, talking about those things with strange -"

She looked past Susie to see the body of her employer on the floor. "Oh, my God!" she whispered, and rushed forward to crouch over the body. "Well, don't just stand there!" she called to Susie. "Get a doctor."

"I think it's too late for that," Chico said as the maid retreated down the hallway.

"Who are you?" the woman asked acidly.

"I'm Michiko Mangini, one of the private detectives on board. Are you a relation of Lady Hannah's?"

"If you are referring to Mrs. Finestra," she corrected primly, "no, I am not a relative. I am - was - her personal secretary. My name is Willa Wright."

Chico took a notebook out of her pocketbook and began to write. "You said Lady Hannah's last name was Finestra? Is her husband on board?"

Miss Wright sighed. "Mrs. Finestra has

been a widow for nine years. Her husband was Demitrio Finestra^ the Boston hotelier."

"Boston? I thought Lady Hannah was from Cuba."

"She was an American/" Miss Wright said wearily^ "of Cuban descent^ hke her husband. We - that is^ Mrs. Finestra^ Susie Tong^ and myself - moved to Cuba after Mr. Finestra's death." She bent over the body. Chico could see the woman's shoulders heaving as she sobbed quietly.

"I'm sorry/' Chico said^ "but the sooner we get the facts^ the more likely we'll be to pick up Lady Hannah's murderer." . "Oh, do stop calling her that/' Miss Wright said viciously. " 'Lady' Hannah!" Her words tumbled from her in a seething rage. "Her title was as much an affectation as her outlandish hats. Lady Hannah, indeed "

Suddenly she looked up at Chico, as if seeing her for the first time. "Oh dear," she said, wiping her nose with a lace handkerchief, "I'm afraid I don't know what I'm saying anymore. It's the shock of it all, I'm

sure."

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I'm sure," Chico said sympathetically. "How did Mr. Finestra die?"

Miss Wright stiffened. "He fell from his office window," Willa said finally.

"Fell?"

"The official report was that Mr. Finestra was depressed about the stock market crash and committed suicide. That was what his partners said, at any rate."

" Who were his partners ?"

"Two of them are on this ship. Hy Court and Rich Ledger," Willa said. "The third, Ernest Friendly, died earlier this year. Heart attack."

■ Chico scribbled furiously. "Didn't you believe them about Mr. Finestra's suicide?"

p Miss Wright shrugged. "The insurance company did. The Finestra Hotel had gone bankrupt earher that year. He was virtually penniless. They refused to pay a dime on his poHcy." She shook her head, remembering. "There were so many suicides of that type in 1929."

Chico looked around the first-class cabin. "I had the impression Lady Hannah was rich," she said.

"Oh, she was, eventually. We made a go of things, despite everything."
There was a gleam of pride in her eyes. "She owned The Perfumed Garden, you know."

"You're kidding," Chico exclaimed. "I've been there!"

"Oh?" Willa visibly warmed toward her.

"It's the best resort in Havana. Great casino^ fabulous food^ fantastic music
"

"Yes, indeed/" Willa said. "When were you a guest there?"

"Well, I wasn't a guest, exactly," Chico said. "I was a dancer in a cabaret
revue

once."

Miss Wright's expression frosted over again. "Oh."

There was a timid knock at the door. Susie Tong had returned. "I'm sorry to have taken so long. Miss Wright," she said diffidently. "I had to track down the doctor. He's on his way now."

"It's about time," Willa said.

The doctor swept in a few moments later. While he was examining the body, Chico took Susie aside.

"I didn't kill her, really I didn't," Susie wailed.

"Settle down," Chico said. "I just want to ask you if you and Miss Wright were the only people traveling with Lady... er... Mrs. Finestra."

The maid smiled with relief. "Oh, no. Lady Hannah always liked a lot of company. Madame Deja Bleu is with us. So is Scats Allegro, the bandleader from The Perfumed Garden."

"You called her Lady Hannah," Chico said. "Doesn't that name bother you?"

"Bother? Why should it? Everyone called her Lady Hannah." She looked over her shoulder at Willa Wright. "Except for that priss," she added in a whisper.

The doctor stood up. "Gunshot wound," he said disgustedly.

A murmur rose up from the corridor. By this time, a number of passengers had gathered around the doorway to gawk and speculate. "Coming through," came an authoritative voice. Two young men in ship's uniform made their way through the crowd. One of them went directly to Lady Hannah's body and began to tape its outline. The other spoke to the passengers, ordering them to disperse.

"You, too, miss," he said to Chico.

"Okay. Just one second, Doc?"

The doctor looked up in annoyance. "There's nothing to be said about this death at the moment," he said. "Go join the rest of the passengers."

"Not this death. The other one, the P.L. named Jones, What did he die of?"

The doctor scratched his head. "Well, I guess that's going to come out sooner or later, anyway. Mr. Jones died of poisoning."

"Poisoning? Like food poisoning?"

"There is absolutely no danger of food poisoning on board this ship," the young officer said. "Now, if you will be so kind as to join the others at breakfast "

"Not food poisoning," the doctor said. "Curare. It's a rare poison, very fast-acting. Curare showed up in his blood work."

"Curare," Chico mused. "That's a South American poison, isn't it?"

"That's enough, miss," the ship's officer said, taking her arm.

"One more question. Doc!" she shouted as the young man dragged her away. "Have you ever examined anyone who died from a curse?"

"A curse?" the doctor asked irritably. "What are you talking about? Nobody dies from curses."

But the last face Chico saw as the officer forcibly extricated her from the room was Susie Tong's, and in those Asian eyes there was no doubt.

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Chapter 6

"Dominus vobiscum. Et cum spiritu tuo. "

The words were Latin, but the voice uttering them had a different accent, more guttural even than the old Church Latin.

He had heard the voice somewhere before, so Leslie Dither stopped in the passageway outside the ship's theater, which doubled as its chapel and listened for a moment longer.

He recognized the voice when it spoke again. It was the Germanic voice of that Reverend Peter Blue who had accosted Lady Hannah the night before in some sort of silly brouhaha about the gems she was wearing.

Nasty turn of events, all that. First that private operative had gotten himself killed, and then Lady Hannah herself had been gifted with a new navel. Thirty-eight caliber. Not a cracking good start to what he had hoped would be a pleasure cruise. Dither thought.

And now all these American detectives were racing around, comparing notes and theories, and blustering about having to solve the crime to avenge their fallen compatriot.

What perfect twiddle. If he knew Americans^ they would just keep on about this until the entire cruise had been ruined. And at the end^ they would have very little to show for it. Americans were just not so very efficient^ after all.

Perhaps the only way he was going to get any peace at all would be to solve the two murders himself^ so Leslie Dither^ latest in the proud line of Dither family detectives who traced their history back to before Sherlock Holmes^ walked into the chapel.

Father Peter Blue was standing at the portable altar^ before the movie screen in the theater. A surprisingly large crowd of three dozen who had attended mass had risen to their feet and^ having received the benedic-tion^ were on their way toward the doors and toward whatever waited for them out there. Dither walked to the front of the temporary chapel and waited there^ soundlessly^ until Father Blue looked up.

"Guten tag," Dither said.

Dither was a small round man^ but Father Blue was even shorter and rounder. He looked at Dither with a pleasant expression and responded^ "Sprechen sie Deutsch?"

"Ja/" Dither said with a nod. Then he switched languages and added^ "But my English is better."

i

"Good. Then we will speak in English." He pronounced his w's as v's, Dither noticed. "I need the practice," Blue said.

He said "der practice," and Dither thought how much his accent sounded like that of Jack Miles, that pugilistic private detective from New York City. Miles also said "da" for "the." Dither pondered it for a split-second, just long enough for the thought to reinforce his long-held opinion that Americans did not speak English at all, but actually some kind of foreign, and therefore lesser, tongue.

"You are a detective?" Father Blue asked.

Dither nodded. "Have you heard this morning's news?" he asked.

Father Blue shook his head. "I have been here all day, at the prayers. Many come late, you know, and I would provide mass for all of them."

"Lady Hannah is dead," Dither said.

"Ach. Gott in Himmel," Blue said. He crossed himself.

"English, remember. We are being civilized. You did not know until now?" Dither asked.

Blue shook his head. "I pray that God will forgive the poor woman," he said.

"Poor woman?" Dither repeated.

"Seemed like a pretty rich woman to me... sporting all that jewelry."

"Not hers," Blue said vehemently. "Not hers at all. Maybe now it goes back to the rightful owner?"

"Somehow I doubt that," Dither said. "It's been stolen."

"Oh, my God." Father Blue sat down heavily in one of the front-row theater seats and stared glumly at the blank movie screen.

"Perhaps you would tell me why the jewels are so important to you?" Dither asked.

Blue hesitated a long time before answering. "Why do you think they are important to me?" he asked finally.

"For one thing, friend cleric, because you made a scene about them last night in the cocktail lounge. For another, because when I just told you they were stolen, you almost fainted."

"Ah, there is no fooling you. You are a detective."

"The only one on this ship, too," Dither said. "Now, why don't you tell me about it?"

"Am I... what do you English say, a suspect?"

"Not yet," Dither said, lying casually as generations of Dither detectives had done.

He sat down next to the corpulent priest. It occurred to him that anybody passing by

and looking in at the two small round men might think they looked like Tweedledum and Tweedledee.

He waited and finally Father Blue released a long sigh. The story followed. It came with a rush, as if Father Blue had been waiting, wanting to tell it to someone.

When he was done, he sighed again and looked over at Dither. "So that is it," he said. "Am I now the prime suspect in these murders?"

Dither shook his head. "Not in my mind," he said.

"But in the eyes of your friends? To them I am maybe the killer?"

"They're not my friends," Dither said. "I'm an Englishman. And heaven only knows what they will think. But I promise that I will try to keep these American cowboys away from you."

"I would appreciate that very much," Blue said. He stood. "Now you will excuse me," he said. "I must say prayers for the dead."

"Even for Hannah?" Dither asked.

"Especially for Hannah," Blue said.

"Why 'especially'?"

"Because she needs them the most," Blue said as he walked heavily away.

The other detectives insisted upon knowing what Dither had learned from Father Blue, and even though the Briton was sure nothing he had learned

would help this rabble solve any crime, and even though he was convinced that Father Blue had nothing to do with any murder, he found himself forced to give them a report on his earlier conversation with the priest.

He told the story quickly, paraphrasing, shortening it, as if trying to get rid of an unpleasant task as rapidly as possible.

Father Blue, he reported, was born fifty-two years ago in Siam, the only child of German missionaries who had been living in Siam for ten years before his birth. He was raised in Siam and grew to love the country as his own, and it was with great reluctance that he returned to Germany at age eighteen to study for the clergy.

"There," Dither reported with a straight face, "he fell in with bad company and became a Roman Catholic."

"Oh, the shame of it all," said the one known as Devlin Tracy, and Dither looked at him for a long second before deciding that the poor, misguided man must be a Catholic too. How odd that people would be Catholics when there were so many acceptable religions to belong to.

He shrugged off the thought and returned to his story. Father Blue, after being ordained to the priesthood, returned to Siam to assist his missionary parents in their work. They were not thrilled with his change of religion but swallowed their pride and worked with him, until they died soon after, Mrs. Blue of cholera, and her husband from having been trampled to death by a rogue elephant.

In 1926, everything changed for Blue. The unopened tomb of an ancient King of Siam, King Chauvalit Pardist, had been discovered by a team of archeologists led by adventurer Jules Finder.

There were reports of great treasures being found, and Father Blue went to the tomb to talk to Finder. He was allowed to enter the tomb and saw, etched in stone over the entrance, the words: 'Death to All Who Violate This Resting Place.'

In the tomb were the intricately carved statues of the three gods who were to convey the long-dead king into the afterlife, and in the center of the forehead of each statue, radiating a soft blue light, was a huge perfect sapphire.

Father Blue begged Finder to donate the treasures to Siam's national museum, but Finder laughed at him and said that

his discovery must be shown to the world.

Jules Finder never left Siam alive. Three days after entering the tomb, he was dead.

"The cause of death," Dither said quickly, "was never determined. But foul play was not ruled out."

The sapphires, though, had gone. Finder had called them the Caribbean Blues because they so closely matched the color of the Caribbean Sea.

"According to Father Blue, they have had a most bloody history," Dither said.

"It looks like they still do," said the one called Andy Baltimore. God, Dither thought, but he hated Americans, and of all Americans, he hated Californians the most. Adventurers, the lot of them. And this Baltimore chap looked like a pervert to boot.

"Yes, yes," Dither said. "At any rate. Father Blue has been tracking down the gems for years after deciding that it was up to him to get them back. He followed them to London, where their most recent owner. Lady Harriet Cartwright, had just fallen off London Bridge while wearing the necklace made of the three gems. Then he heard that the stones had turned up in Amsterdam. He followed them there and everywhere, but was always a step behind, a minute too late."

"Colorfully put," Chico said. At least someone in this group had some taste. Dither thought.

Dither reported that Blue had found out just a few months ago that the stones were in the possession of Lady Hannah Finestra in Cuba, but when he got there, he found she had left for San Juan to take the cruise aboard the Cunard Countess. He arrived in San Juan just in time to catch the ship.

"And there we are, chaps," Dither said. He nodded toward Chico. "And lady."

"That's it?" Heller asked.

Dither shrugged. "More or less," he said.

"Pretty much less," Heller said.

"I look forward to your enlightening me, Yank," Dither said sternly, trying to keep the hard edge out of his voice.

"First of all," Trace interrupted, "did Blue know any of these people traveling with Hannah?"

A lucky guess. Dither thought. "Well, actually, yes. He had seen Sir I. B. Hunter, the explorer. He was at the opening of the tomb when the jewels were found."

"And you didn't think that was important enough to tell us?" Trace asked.

"I didn't want to bog you down with details," Dither said.

Trace shook his head in a manner Dither thought most boorish.

"If the jewels were in statues of three pagan gods^ why the hell did Father Blue care about the curse or getting them back or anything like that?" Jack Miles asked.

God^ his pronunciation was atrocious^ Dither thought. He said^ "It's for his adopted country;, Siam. Not because of the curse. He doesn't believe in such curses^ he told me^, although he did admit that this curse seems to have more teeth in it than most such curses do."

"It ought to put its teeth in your leg/" Miles grumbled.

"Where^ Mr. Dither^ was Father Blue when Lady Hannah was murdered?" the young Oriental woman asked him softly.

"He had returned to the ballroom in time for the murder of Private Investigator Jones," Dither said. "Then he drank a little too much and at midnight he seems to recall he was playing the slot machines up in the casmo."

"Great/" Trace said. "A whisky-swilling, casino-haunting priest. Nothing suspicious there. You don't think he had anything to do with either of the murders?"

"No. I'm sure of it," Dither said.

"Your being sure of it makes him number-

one suspect in my mind," Phil Phlem said. Another savage, Dither thought.

Everybody else around the table nodded. Even the cheeky little Oriental woman.

Dither excused himself. To blazes with all of them. Father blue had killed no one. Dither was sure of that. But how to tell them why he was sure... that he was certain of Father Blue's innocence because Father Blue was German and the Hun was notoriously neat, while both these murders were rather sloppy?

He would not tell them that. He would not tell them anything. Let them look anywhere they wanted. Dither could see he would just have to solve this murder on his own or else watch his free cruise be ruined.

Americans were savages.

When Dither left the small meeting room, the other private detectives remained. Heller said, "Well, at least we know one thing. The jewel thief that Jones and I were looking for is on the ship."

"Maybe," Miles said. "And maybe not. The one you're looking for never killed anybody before, so maybe this is somebody else."

"This is too complicated," Trace said. "Fm going to bed."

"You just got up," Chico said.

"That's right. And all of you have already made me nuts enough for one day. I'm leaving."

He did. Chico stayed.

date: Sunday, May 17, 1938 TIME OF departure: 9:30 p.m. destination: St. Maarten TIME OF arrival: 8:30 a.m. DISTANCE: 94 nautical miles
WEATHER CONDITIONS: Rain, lightning, and thunder.

Chapter 7

Andy Baltimore was not a particularly happy person at the moment. He wasn't happy about the way the ship was lurching through the sea like a Peugeot hitting potholes on La Cienega, he wasn't happy about the nasty little turn this supposed vacation was taking, and he was especially unhappy about this big, ruddy-faced Irishman who had the bad

taste to purloin his partner's name. This bonehead spelled it wrong, though.

"No, you can't wait until we get back to San Juan," Devlin Tracy was bellowing, waving his arms. "Do it now. You've got to do it now."

Who died and made you Aimee McPherson? Andy wondered irritably. Do it now, do it now. He sounded like a Melrose housewife on her fourth day with the milkman.

This was just not Andy's cup of yogurt. What did he know about stolen jewelry and murder? He was a missing-persons expert - co-director of the nation's (make that the world's) best (make that the only) twenty-four-hour rescue service. Abduction Anonymous - more officially known as Lost and Found Incorporated (L.A.F.). That was, Andy and his partner worked only in the first twenty-four hours before the police were able to enter a missing-

persons case. Because they knew that if something... untoward... was going to happen to a kidnapped individual, it would happen in the first twenty-four hours.

Andy longed to see his partner right then and there. Tracey Taler had a way of knowing when to make an entrance. And how! She was, after all, slightly psychic.

"Oh, yeah, Miss Deus Ex Machina of

1938/" Devlin had said. The first of many such endearing occurrences between the obsessive victim-hunter from Los Angeles and the overbearing mick from New York.

"I know what's going to happen/" Devlin was continuing. "We'll get back to the States; then you'll all get sidetracked with your real work and this'll never get done."

Yeah^ right. This Tracy knew himself real well. But as the little yellow bird with the big foot said^ "He don't know me very well^ do he?"

"Just be glad I don't give you that weird reverend:^ Baltimore/" Devlin ranted on in that ingratiating way of his. "No^ I'm a nice guy. Out of the kindness of my hearty and at great personal expense^ I let you pump Lady Hannah's good-looking blond secretary. Ho^ ho, ho."

Pump. Andy bet he thought that was clever. What Andy thought was that the only reason he was going to interrogate Willa Wright was that if Devlin's companion, Chico, found the Irishman within a parsec of the platinum looker. Trace would be chum for the cuttlefish.

"Ah," said Andy. "Mangez la pone. " It was French for "eat the door." Andy knew how to say "eat the door" in seven languages. Even when the persons he was talking to

knew the language, it always took them a second to realize he was speaking nonsense. Devlin Tracy did not know the language.

"You're welcome," Trace said with a big, satisfied smile.

Baltimore wandered the ship in search of Lady Hannah's personal secretary. That he could do. Andy was real good at finding missing women. What he was not good at was finding bodies. In fact, he was fairly staggered by how the rest of his unfraternal companions dealt with the corpse as if it was "just another" dead body. They seemed to look upon it like a chef looked upon a filet mignon. What was this case going to be: rare or well done? That sort of thing chilled Andy to the bone. He was used to warm, misplaced, breathing bodies and sad, mad perverts. To tell the truth, the idea of a person who calmly and deliberately poisoned one person and shot another in the chest, just for person gain, scared him excrementally.

No, it was safe to say this trip was not going well. His partner, Tracey, the real brains of the L.A.F. outfit (at least that was one thing Andy had in common with Devlin), insisted he R.S.V.P. the invite after a solid fortnight of tracking down a half dozen missing prostitutes who were the

intended victims of some nut case with a hacksaw. That, of course, meant that Andy had gone two weeks with almost no sleep and was ready to ceremoniously disembowel anybody who even told a dirty joke.

"G'wan/" his staggeringly attractive half-Irish, half-Spanish partner had said. "Take the cruise. It'll be fun."

Some fun. Complete strangers were being dropped dead, and the cruise had become a cross between church camp and prison. If only Tracey were here, he moaned to himself for the sixteenth time that day. She could tell him how to proceed and he could concentrate on his specialty - how to best launch the alleged perpetrator's nose into his brain.

Andy climbed stairs. The ocean liner was knotting into the wind, through unusually adverse weather for this time of year. He passed old people feeding their faces in the football-field-sized dining room, he passed middle-aged people feeding quarters into equally ancient slot machines, and he passed young people feeding nickels in the penny arcade.

It wasn't until he got to the seventh level of the ship that he saw a feast for the eyes. Various firm members of the staff were leading various flaccid members of the passengers in morning exercises on the deck.

These female crew members, mostly English girls, had none of the steak-and-kidney-pudding look their countrywomen were famous for. As Andy watched the hard bodies bouncing rhythmically up and down in their skimpy outfits, his mind effortlessly glided into overdrive. It would be easy to silently ambush these sweet, fresh-faced, peach-skinned girls one night and secret them in one of the lifeboats or in the ship's bowels until they could be carried ashore inside duffel bags or laundry hampers and prepared for sale in the Caribbean white-slavery market, where the price for Occidentals was still at a premium

Andy smacked himself on the side of the head. He had been a ransom-buster too long. All work and no play made Jack a perverse boy. He had saved so many people from fates worse than death that he saw kidnapping conspiracies everywhere. Maybe a little lesson in interrogation skills would do him some good, after all. So where was Willa Wright?

He found her in the steam room. His heart sank when he looked into the foggy window of the booth that was stuck down next to the whirlpool baths (which were, in turn, next to the puddle-sized, five-foot-deep swimming pool on the upper deck). She sat there,

luxuriating^ legs out^ head back, with only a small bone-colored towel covering her torso, from her upper thighs to her chest.

Andy knew the routine. Cermaic skin the color of alabaster (and, no doubt, the feel of butter). A shape that went to the center of the male hormonal system. A face that made one feel paternal and passionate at the same time - big blue eyes that had that "goUy-gee-who-me?" intensity, a nose so perfect that a caricature artist wouldn't even bother drawing it, and naturally rose lips that got a man thinking about serious, repeated contact. And the hair: naturally blond hair on the head, over the eyes, on the arms, and God knew where else. She was the kind of girl one would snake-walk through ground glass to see straighten a hem.

So much for new experiences. Andy Baltimore was back in his element. Without even considering taking off his L.A.F. jacket (the one with the company's motto, "Saving a Reluctant World," stitched over the front pocket), he pushed open the door and stepped inside.

Bingo. Her eyes moved to his without surprise, shock, or even irritation at the intrusion. She had been expecting someone, and just waiting to see which someone. Andy swallowed a smile. Suddenly he was eager

to see how well she lied... to him and/or herself.

"Pardon me," he said. "I'm Andy Baltimore, one of the detectives on board. Do you want me to come back after you're dressed?"

"No," she replied. "That's all right. I mean, it's a public steam room, right? I mean, I knew one of you would probably like to talk to me, and... well, uh..." She swallowed quickly and smiled, her features relaxing. "Well, I was hoping it would be you," she finished warmly.

Andy was gripped by the sudden desire to break into the first few bars of "Dancing Cheek to Cheek," complete with soft shoe. "Heaven, I'm in heaven. And my heart beats so that I can hardly speak..." Yeah, right. She was Carole Lombard and he was Clark Gable. She was Jean Harlow and he was James Cagney. More like she was Ginger Rogers (what a dancer!) and he was Peter Lorre.

"Well, isn't that nice," he gushed, coming forward and leaning on the slick tile wall opposite her. He nearly slid down to the floor, but his sneakers gripped at the last minute. She didn't even have the sense to titter sweetly behind an upraised hand. She was too busy playing the earnest witness who

had fallen in like at first sight. "What was it?" he wondered aloud. "My thick^ round glasses? My mottled salt-and-pepper hair? My big^ round head? The little tiny hairs on my nose?"

She stared at him in stunned silence for a second^ the wheels of her brain breaking down her mind's viscosity^ until she decided he was hitting on her

funny bone. She giggled^ "I knew you were different from the others/" she said with pseudo relief. "I knew you would understand."

She was making this easy. "Understand what?" he asked vacantly.

"Why^ the stress and pressure I've been under/" she replied. "This has been a terrible ordeal for all of us. And as much as I hate to admit it^ your friends running around acting as if this is some kind of surprise party designed just for them hasn't helped."

Andy pictured the others in his mind. "They're not my friends/" he said^ "although I kind of like the ex-boxer. He's so transparent, anyway^ I can't tell you how sorry I am. I really can't understand why anyone would purposely kill anyone for any reason... outside of self-defense. I mean^ what could be so important?" It was true. Andy knew only of death by perverted

passion. Cold, premeditated murder most foul was an aberration of nature.

Willa Wright was momentarily taken aback by his earnestness. This guy was not pulling her leg. For a moment, her carefully thought-out presentation was disrupted. "It was revenge," she blurted out.

"Revenge?" Andy echoed. "For what?"

Willa was immediately circumspect. She leaned back, clutching the towel to her as if she had suddenly realized she was sans sartorial splendor. "Fm... Fm sorry," she stuttered. "I shouldn't have said that. I shouldn't say anything."

"What do you mean?" Andy retorted, leaning intensely. "What are you talking about? What revenge?"

Willa looked as if she was trying to lean through the wall. "Please, Mr. Baltimore," she pleaded. "Mrs - I mean... Lady Hannah... trusted me."

"Lady Hannah is dead!" Baltimore shot back, outraged. "You tell me what revenge, or..." - Andy's eyes became unfocused as his mind whirled - "... or

FU pull your heart out through your mouth."

The woman suddenly realized that he was not in there alone with her, but she was in there alone with him. Baltimore was not a shy

push-over. He was a repressed actor auditioning for psychosis.

"Please, Mr. Baltimore... Andy... calm down," Willa begged. "I'll tell you the truth."

"I'd appreciate that," he said as if he didn't think she'd actually announce when she was lying. The sweat that was pouring down all over only added to his ambience.

"I became Hannah Finestra's personal secretary nine years ago, after her husband died," she revealed,

"Who was her husband?"

"Demitrio Finestra."

"Who was he?"

"You don't know?"

"Was he a known sex offender?"

"No."

Andy shrugged. "Then I don't know."

"He was the owner of the famous Finestra Hotel in Boston," she sniffed proudly.

"Boston, huh?"

"You know it now?"

"No. We were called in on a copycat Jack the Ripper case on Beacon Hill."

Willa recoiled even farther from her interviewer, edging on the slatted wood seat. Her entire right leg appeared from under the towel, dappled in golden beads of perspiration, like gems set in every ivory

pore. Andy was beginning to enjoy himself - it was fun to enhance his reputation as an extremely dangerous sort. It often prevented him from actually having to do anything.

The woman hurried on, smitten with an overwhelming desire for the sea air. "Mrs. Finestra and I moved to Cuba, where we opened a hotel called The Perfumed Garden."

"We? " Andy interrupted.

"I beg your pardon?"

"You said 'we.' Not her, not she, but we."

"Uh... yes. Mrs. Finestra was virtually penniless, so she borrowed a few thousand from me. I got a percentage of the resort. Ten percent. I quickly made back my investment. The club at The Perfumed Garden was one of the most exclusive Havana night spots."

"Fm sure," Andy said dryly. "Gambling, right?"

Willa's demeanor became equally chilly in this oven. "Mrs. Finestra catered to the needs of her influential clientele."

Andy's face was a sour mask, his glasses completely fogged, his close-cropped beard raining. "Terrific. Go on."

"Mrs. Finestra became friends with people from all over the world. Among them

was Irving Baxter Hunter, the famous African explorer."

"Ah, yes," Andy said. "The schnorer. "

"Excuse me?"

"Hurray for Captain Spaulding the African explorer," he suggested quickly.

She stared at him as if he were a water bug. "Ah. Yes. Amusing." It was obvious she had never heard the Marx Brothers song.

"You don't get out much, do you?"

"I'm very busy." The atmosphere in the sweltering box had changed. She had wrested back control of the conversation. Andy had all but handed it to her. "At any rate, that was Mrs. Finestra's first serious relationship since the death of her husband."

"Is he the guy who was getting revenge?"

"I'm sure I don't know," Willa said coyly. "All I know is that Mrs. Finestra spurned him."

Andy just stood there, dripping. "Let me get this straight. This guy waits a couple of years, then comes on this cruise, poisons a Chicago private eye who happens to be around, then blows her heart out?"

Willa's attitude had sunk from cold to dry ice. "I don't know what you're talking about."

"You ever been shot?" He didn't wait for a reply. "It's a hunk of lead traveling faster

than sound that tears through your skin and rips through your body. Can you imagine what that feels like? Can you imagine your heart, your own heart, being torn apart? Like two hands grabbing your heart, and tearing it in half?" He grabbed an imaginary organ in front of him and rent it, sweat splashing off his hair as if ejected from a shower head.

Willa choked.

Baltimore's glasses slipped off his face and fell to the hard tile with a clatter.

He just stood motionless, his small, haunted brown eyes appearing in and out of the mist. He couldn't see her face. It was just a soft, ethereal blur. But

he could imagine her expression. He wasn't far wrong.

"You didn't like Hunter, did you?" he asked. It was an easy question. What was there to like?

"I didn't like or dislike him." Her tone was hard and flat.

"Your trusted employer is dead," Andy seethed. "Eternity in the darkness. Forever. Nothing. Her body is decomposing -"

"Stop it!"

"You talk to me!" he yelled.

"No! I didn't like him! He was an effete snob. He didn't even treat me like a human being."

"Why don't you try acting like one?"

Andy snapped. Then he continued immediately: "Cheap shot, cheap shot, I know. I'm sorry."

He leaned down and retrieved his glasses. When he put them back on, he saw that she was crying, her beautiful body shaking beneath the towel. "I don't care what the others are doing," he told her. "I'm not doing this for fun. I didn't know these people... and now I never will. And I'll never know whether I would have liked them."

"My God!" Willa sobbed, trying to stop crying. "You care, don't you? You actually

care."

Andy couldn't understand what she was asking. How could a human being not care? What if it was she the murderer had wanted? What if it had been him? How could others not care?

Willa took a few deep breaths, providing Andy with an entertaining balcony scene. She regathered her defenses and prepared to survive the next

onslaught. "Mrs. Finestra started an affair with General Batista of Cuba. Hunter couldn't compete. He went back to Africa."

"Okay," Andy said reasonably. "So?"

Willa looked trapped and helpless, an expression with which Andy was all too

familiar. "Jeez, I don't know," she almost whined, squirming. "These were just two of the affairs I knew about. How many other men did Miss Hannah spurn? Maybe the private eye who was murdered was watching her. Or maybe he was hired to protect her. Or someone who wanted to steal the Caribbean Blues had to kill both of them to get them. Do I have to do all your work?"

He looked down at her, smiling, although his eyes were dead. "Am I going to have to tell you what happens to your guts when you're poisoned?" he said pleasantly.

"What do you want from me?" she cried.

Andy's gaze took on pity. "How was Demitrio Finestra killed?" he asked quietly.

She gasped. "How did you know he was killed? How did you know he didn't just die?"

"I won't be coy," Andy promised, "unlike somebody I could name." His explanation was tinged with bitterness. "Finestra was in business. Businesses are insured. If there wasn't something screwy with his death. Lady Hannah wouldn't have needed your lousy few thousand. Now tell me what the heck is going on, or I'll tell you what the bladder does just before death."

"Please," Willa replied, holding up her lily-white hand in acknowledged defeat.

"Demitrio Finestra died in a fall from his office window."

"Jumped or pushed?"

"I don't really know/" Willa said wearily.

"What happened to his hotel?"

"Bankruptcy. So^ you see^ she needed my 'lousy few thousand.'"

Andy opened his mouth to say something more^ but then his teeth snapped together with an audible cHck. When he spoke again^ his tone was the original^ solicitous one with which he had entered the steam room. "There. All finished. Now^ that wasn't so bad, was it?"

"Do I get a lollipop?" Willa answered with a tired smile.

"Bad for your teeth/" Andy said, smiling back. "Sugar clouds your mind. And I want you to think about something. If you haven't been completely 'up front' with me, or won't keep me 'abreast' of things, I may have to come back and get a few things off your chest."

Andy was richly rewarded for his crudity. Her expression mingled fear, defiance, and a certain competitiveness. She sat up, letting the towel drop to her stomach.

When she spoke, her voice was husky, her eyes smoky.

"I've got nothing to hide," she said.

Andy Baltimore looked at the sad little girl... who was both literally and figuratively at sea. Vamping him was like trying to sell binoculars to a blind man. He walked to the door. But, at the last moment, he stopped, turned, and stared purposefully at her undeniably beautiful breasts.

"Thanks, four eyes," he told her. "My mom had two of those."

When Heller first saw the little man by the rail, he thought he was going to jump. Then the Chicago P.I. realized that Andy Baltimore was simply stiff with tension. The lost finder was scanning the rippling sea as if communing with Neptune.

Initially Heller was going to ignore the strange guy. He couldn't shake a slightly distasteful feeling every time he saw him. Baltimore was the kind of man who not only wore his heart on his sleeve, but his liver, spleen, and intestines as well. Heller had the unmistakable sensation that someday, someone would have to put Baltimore down like a mad dog. He was simply too similar to the people he chased.

"You're wasting your time," he growled, coming up alongside Andy. "You won't find any answers there."

Andy's voice was distant. "I talked to Willa Wright."

"What did she tell you?"

"It's what she didn't tell me. It's what she worked very hard not to say that worries me." He turned to look directly at Heller. "She flashed me."

"Lucky you," Heller said, scowling.

"No. Unlucky me. I look in the mirror. Heller. Nobody sticks their chest out for me. Not unless they're trying to distract me." He told the detective what he had found out.

"Sounds like a lot of air," Heller decided sourly.

"Yeah," Andy agreed. "She chose her words very carefully. She didn't say whether she knew Finestra was murdered or committed suicide. She said she didn't 'really' know."

Heller was incredulous. Baltimore was getting worked up over one word? But before he could walk away from Andy in disgust, the angst-oozing little man continued, staring out to sea.

" 'Bankruptcy.' One second her back was so straight about that luxury Boston hotel you could iron shirts on it. Then, just like that, it's bankrupt."

"What are you getting at?" Heller asked him pointedly, exasperated.

Baltimore looked at the avenging investigator, his expression empty.

"Damned if I know," he said. "Yet."

Chapter 8

"Pull!"

Bang-bang.

Phlem watched the leathery-faced, paunchy man in the safari jacket and bush hat on the fantail of the Cunard Countess reload both barrels of the shotgun before the crockery he had shattered mid-sky hit the water.

"Pull!"

Two more of what Phlem understood to be skeets soared above the horizon aft of the ship.

Bang-bang.

Before they had a chance to enjoy freedom so sweetly tasted, both saucers were blown to shards.

"Pull!"

Philip d'Artagnan Phlem (for such was the spelling of his name his mother had given him; which spelling he had accepted utterly until the age of eighteen, when, about to be

sent overseas^ he received a note from his mother^ the first he'd ever had, which read: 'Thil, dear;, When you are in Phlanders Phield, please do me the phavor of phinding some nice phlowers for the grave of your phather's new phloosie"; since then he had been less certain) had left school in the fourth grade for a package of cigarettes and had never returned, as he was caught smoking them while driving a Ford he had stolen.

Phlem felt akin to shards. He knew how it was to have that initial feeling of soaring toward freedom, shucking the gravity of school, looking down at the horizon for a short moment only to be shot down, shattered, forced to fall back into the sea of humanity.

Drafted out of the reformatory, Phlem served a hard two years in the infantry in France before being dishonorably discharged for permitting a gun caisson to roll over the shiny new boot containing the never-before-broken foot of a shiny new second lieutenant.

Ph. d. Phlem (as he preferred to sign his name on those infrequent occasions when he had any reason to do so; he hoped doing so would indicate, implicitly, of course, an education beyond his own degree), in shards at twenty, decided to enter the profession of private detective.

Good thing his motive was not money. He made little.

Good, too, he felt little urge to serve Justice. If that had been his intention. Justice was as unserved as Oliver Twist asking for seconds.

Philip d'Artagnan Phlem's sole purpose in becoming a private detective at age twenty was to detect and reveal unto the world nasties and naughties about all the people in the world who stood straighter than he, walked with a brisker step, spoke more clearly, were cleaner in limb and dress, more clever of mind, noble of ambition - and that was all the people in the world.

Despite poverty, hard work, long hours, the loneliness of an irregular bachelor's life, Philip d'Artagnan Phlem had had for twenty-two years what he considered a satisfactory career.

He had caused the ruination of a good many nice folks.

"Pull!"

Bang-bang.

Now Sir I. B. Hunter (for such was he smashing crockery off the fantail with a double-barreled shotgun), to Phlem, clearly fit into the category of acceptable nice folks. So nice, in fact, Phlem had heard His Majesty, the King of England (Phlem's

education having gone up in smoke in the fourth grade caused him to think George III was always and therefore still King of England);, had invited

Hunter to his digs for a boilermaker and bopped him on the shoulders with a sword and declared that henceforth everyone was to call him "Sir/" whether one felt like it or not.

Indeed;, to Phlem^ Hunter was a piece of crockery soaring high above the horizon. Hunter looked decent enough to ruin.

By Phlem's county Hunter's score was ten shots^ ten skeetS;, which bested Phlem's own professional tally of twenty-seven shots^ one burglar^ sixteen taxis^ five pedestrians^ one department-store-window mannequin^ one traffic policeman^ and three unknowns.

"Sir I. B.? Sir Hunter? Sir?"

Hunter's bloodshot eyes noted Phlem as might a lion noting a dik-dik when his lioness has been rather slow about returning with a gazelle.

"Pull!"

Bang-bang.

Broken crockery hit the water in so tight a pattern Neptune could dine off it without reaching for the glue.

"One of the snoops^ are you?" Hunter asked. "Thought one of you convening dicks might crawl along choked up with suspicion.

Hardly expected to see you in daylight, though. Don't you chaps generally take to the dark corners?"

"You like to shoot things," Phlem asserted while watching Hunter reload.

"Rather good at it," Hunter said. "Might say I shot my way off the family farm in Scotland and out of Edinburgh University. Found the pursuit of sheep and their skins rather tame sport. Much jollier traipsing about in the bush giving the gift of death to more admirable beasts: the lion, the elephant. Well, one must use what talents one has."

"You like to kill things."

"Only some things, old boy. Some things look better dead than alive."
Again, Hunter surveyed Phlem. "Others are beneath concern. Pull!"

Bang-bang.

Hunter said, "No good questioning me, old sod. Couldn't possibly be the sack you're after. I'm as innocent as the desert's dry."

"I've never seen a desert."

"Not given to introspection, eh?"

"Listen, Sir I. B. -"

"If you don't know how to use a title, old chap, then don't address the card. In fact, you'd save us both a lot of trouble if you'd wait to be properly introduced."

"Someone said you're a big hunter -"

"Wrote the book on it^ I did: Hunter on Hunting. Knight for it. For that:> plus certain jobs I did for zoological groups hither and yon. You'd think such a book would bring me a decent pension^ wouldn't you? Gambling palaces have such a nice ambience. They make you feel so rich^ until you get outside and check your pockets. Sometimes there's hardly enough left over for the full case of gin."

"You're not rich?"

"Good Lord^ man. Knighthoods don't carry stipends. If any things they raise the tailor's bill. If ever offered a knighthood^ I wouldn't accept^ if I were you. The raise in your tailoring bill would be astronomical."

"Are you broke?"

"As light in the pocket as the day I was born. Lighter^ in fact. Sold off the paternal seat in Scotland last year. The Prince of Monaco had put a black check next to my name till I rectified a run of bad luck at the casino that

pays him rent. Some chaps in Cuba were prowling rather glinty-eyed^ too. No way you could lend me a tenner^, I suppose?"

"Me? Lend you money? Ha!"

" 'Ha!' is it? Never mistake you for a gentleman^ I wouldn't. Rather put you down for a doormat."

"Hunter-"

"That's my name; that's my game."

"Where were you Saturday night when Jones earned his wings?"

"Standing right next to him, old chap. Thought he'd gone down to do my boots."

"You were?"

"I was. They could have done with a bit of a brush-up."

"You know who he was?"

"Figured it out. I had just greeted Lady Hannah. Hadn't seen the old thing in years. Arranged to meet later, in quieter circumstances. Noticed she was wearing the blue sapphires. The Caribbean Blues. Sounds like a dance tune, don't it? A slow two-step, I should say. Recognized those stones immediately, of course. Then that Johnny Collar came up to her and began reading her out -"

"What's a Johnny Collar?"

"The cleric chap. The missionary, vicar - whatever he is. The one who looks like unkneaded bread in a black wrapper."

"The priest. Father Peter Blue."

"Um. Blue in black. He recited the litany of the grief the Blues had brought everybody over the years. Don't doubt what he said. Cursed things."

"How did you know what the gems were?"

"In on their discovery^ old boy - 1926^ it was. Twelve years ago. This wallah^ Jules Finder^ came along to me at the Explorers' Club in London. Wanted me to lead an archeological expedition to Siam. Hot to discover the tomb of Chauvalit Pardist^ he was. Taboos against disturbing tombs^ of course. Never believe in going against local taboos^ I don't. T've never drunk gin on the south side of Mount Kenya. At the time^ the West End bookie school was after me for giving them false information on which horses would win which races before the fact...."

"You needed the money."

"I didn't^ old chap. But the bookies said they did^ you see. All insisted they had wives and children to support. That's their bad luck."

"You ran out on your debts."

"You are a nasty piece of package^ aren't you? Always keen to think the worst of one. Doubt you've ever seen a gentleman before. You give no sign of it. I needed to assure the bookies I had gainful employment and they could afford to feed their anticipation."

"To get the sharks off your back you took
a job doin' something you didn't believe was right."

"Accusatory little toad, aren't you?"

"Your being a fancy knight, big famous hunter, cuts no mustard with me, mister."

"I rather feel I've just cut the razor. You know what that means, old chap?"

"You going to tell me?"

"As if I've just stepped in spoor."

"What's spoor?"

"I am, alas - 's poor me. Pull!"

Bang-bang.

"Anyway, this Finder wallah turned up the tomb, 1926 - that was, broke into it, despite the motto over the entrance: 'Death to All Who Violate This Resting Place.' Rather a chilly welcoming mat, wouldn't you say? I mean, hardly a hello, won't you come in and wet your whistle, is it? Finder proceeded to plunder away like a Zulu in a Masai's shamba."

"Were you with this Finder guy in the tomb when he found the jewels?"

"No, no. Would have put my foot down at the plundering, old chap. Great believer in leaving the natural habitat pretty much as I find it. Douse the campfire, feed the cigar butts to the hyenas - all that. Not one to contract a nasty curse, if I can help it. When the Siamese people discovered what was

going on^ of course;, they were fit to be Thai'd. I understand that Father Blue happened on the scene about then/'

"So when did you first see the sapphires?" "Tinder brought them back to the hotel bar to me^ old chap^ where I had just gone to sample the local. Had them in his hand. Showing them off Hke the schoolboy who had just won all the aggies. Three sapphires. Each had been in the forehead of carved statues of three gods assigned to escort old King Chauvalit Pardist to his final campground. Shocked^ I was. Made me switch to doubles. I left the area next day. I had been having poor luck predicting the outcome of the local snake races^ anyway."

"And what happened to this Finder guy?"

"Never laid eyes on him again. Believe he never made it out of the country. Heard something about his skin being slipped off while he still breathed and set to crisp. Too bad^ too. Treated rights his skin would have made a half-decent pair of boots^ size thirteen wide^ I should say. Never heard what happened to the rest of him. Pull!"

Bang-bang.

"And you never saw the sapphires again^ until Saturday night?"

"Right you are. Think of that. There's me

old pal wearing the baubles I'd helped discover twelve years ago in Siam."

^^Where did she get them?"

"Around her neck, old boy."

"I mean, where did she have them from?"

"Don't know. Running with a Cuban politician in recent years, lizard named Batista, and you know those politician types have sticky fingers. They're apt to pull anything out of their knickers. Threw me over for him, in fact. Had to have something in his knickers besides his manly parts."

"You were that intimate with Lady Hannah?"

"Now, now, old sod. Gentlemen don't tickle and squeal. Used to stay at her resort in Cuba, The Perfumed Garden, don't you know. No matter how warm the days, the nights were just as long, if you catch my drift."

"And you were the knight?"

"Not then, old chap. Just working on it."

"You hated Lady Hannah for throwing you over for this Batteryista guy."

"No such thing. One is always wise to mind the local politics. And politicians. A lesson old Jules Finder spent his skin in tuition to learn."

"You wanted to get together with her again."

"Thought crossed my mind. Heard she was taking this cruise. Old boy^ I said to myself:, this may be a good time to renew acquaintance with the Lady Hannah. Time I came in out of the sun, don't you think? Pushing forty-eight in the years department. Time I took to the shade, bottle of rum by the elbow. Eighty proof."

"You're tryin' to tell me you came on this cruise to get together with Lady Hannah again?"

"Something like that. 'Getting together' is a bit of imagery I leave to you Yanks. Sounds a bit like salad-making to me."

"You came on the cruise to steal the sapphires."

"Did I?"

"You know where the Caribbean Blues are now?"

"No idea, old chap. You're on the wrong spoor altogether. I wouldn't purloin the Blues."

"You're broke! You said so yourself!"

"The Caribbean Blues are as cursed as a bookie's kids."

Phlem ticked off on his fingers. "You led the expedition that found the Caribbean Blues in Siam. Maybe that makes you think you have some rights to their ownership. How many times over the last years. Hunter,

have you had the sharks breathing down your neck and you wished you had your share of the Blues?"

"Elephants breathe down the neck^ old man. The odd lion will warm your back collar. I think sharks approach one in an altogether different manner. Catch me^, if I'm wrong."

Ticking a second finger^ Phlem said, "This Hannah dame -"

"Dame Hannah would be closer. I warned you before - don't play in fields if you don't know where the rocks are."

"This phony broad - the departed -chucked you out for some Cuban politico, which you couldn't have liked all that much -"

"Didn't like him at all. Rather reminded me of a pool player I once knew in Nairobi. He knew the velvet was thin."

"I mean, you didn't like being chucked out."

"Old boy, if you were a gentleman, you'd know you have no rights to a lady's affections unless you're willing to guide her down the aisle and agree with what is there said."

Phlem gave up ticking off his fingers. "Where were you Sunday night?"

"In my bunk, after the casino closed.

Trying to raise my fare^, if you understand
me.

"You weren't in Lady Hannah's cabin anytime Sunday nighty, Monday morning?"

"Pull!"

Bang-bang.

Phlem ticked off one of his fingers again. "You knocked off one of the detectives hired to protect the Caribbean Blues."

"Could have easily enough." Hunter's speed in reloading the shotgun was amazing to Phlem. It usually took him three double bourbons to load his Detective Special. "Standing right next to him. Worm probably deserved doing in. Put him out of his bloody misery. All you window peepers convening on this cruise look damaged by life to me. Ought to have a major hunt aboard. Wouldn't half mind putting out a few Hghts on this cruise."

"You saying you killed Jones?"

"His head would not grace my walls. The startHng lack of intelligence in his eyes would lower the impression of intelligence in the whole exhibit.

Surely you can understand that. Oops^ forgive me. Forgot you've already confessed to a lack of introspection."

"He was poisoned by curare. You know about curare?"

"Of course. Some of my best friends in the

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jungles of South America use it every time they dispatch a spear. Works wonders. You nick a jaguar with curare and, believe me, it stays parked."

"And you have access to the substance."

"Naturally. Customs wouldn't notice the odd bit of curare next to my tooth powder."

"There was curare near Lady Hannah's corpse, too."

"Must have been a penny sale on. Amazing, the bargains in some of these free ports. But you're all wrong about me, you know. Shooting for sport requires some respect for what you kill. I shoot lions, not window peepers. Haven't enough respect for your sort to do in P. I. Jones. Not worth putting oneself out for. I wish you'd understand that."

"And Lady Hannah?"

"Why, we were old pals. I was looking for blissful retirement on her veranda. Why would I do her in?"

"For the jewels. You need the money. Probably some shark after you."

"I thought I'd made it quite clear I've always paid my debts, no matter what it has taken."

"Give me one clear piece of evidence sayin' you didn't kill Lady Hannah."

"You've got it."

"What?"

"Notice the weapon used."

"A handgun."

"Right you are. Now tell me:> who uses a handgun?"

"I use a handgun."

"Right again. You go to the head of your class. Toads, weasels^ worms^ window peepers - all use handguns. Not a sporting weapon^ old chap. Not a proper weapon for a gentleman at all. You'd not catch me with a handgun^ dead or alive."

"Says you."

"You can take the word of a gentleman. If I were you^, I'd have a close look at that judge wallah. What's his name? Hy Court?"

"You got any evidence against him?"

"Absolutely. Sneaky eyes. Low brow. If I came across him in the brushy I'd shoot him in a second. Pull!"

Bang-bang.

"You missed! Both of'em!"

"Um/" said Hunter. "My mind was elsewhere."

Late Monday afternoon^ Ph. d. Phlem reported to the convention of other toads^ worms^ weasels^ peepers^ and dik-diks that Sir I. B. Hunter definitely was the murderer of P. I. Jones and Lady Hannah of Havana.

He recommended that an immediate search for the Caribbean Blues be undertaken in Sir I. B. Hunter's stateroom^ because Hunter was also^

obviously the jewel thief.

Jack Miles sneaked into Hunter's cabin later. The jewels were not there^ he reported.

Chapter 9

Jack Miles thought the whole thing was ridiculous.

First a bunch of half-baked P.I.'s - and he included himself in that general description - gets together on a cruise ship to form some sort of United States P.I.'s Association: "The Loyal Order of Dicks^ Shamuses^ and Gumshoes"? All they needed was a handshake.

And then not one. but two murders take place right under their noses. To top the whole thing off^ as badly as Jack wanted to be somewhere else^ it irked him that the killer - or killers - had the gall to think that they were all "blind" eyes as well as "private" eyes.

Jack Miles himself was no prize^ he was the first to admit. He was a busted-up ex-pug

turned gumshoe for lack of training to do anything else^ but some of these others were real pips!

First there was that fast-talking drunk^ Trace^ and his Japanese geisha girl friend, who thought she was a female Sherlock Holmes; then that Andy Baltimore clown who just wanted to bust someone in the chops; PhiHp d. Phlem, who thought wealth was measured by the number of ex-wives one didn't pay alimony to; that Limey twerp, Dither, who thought he was better than everyone else; and, finally, Nate Heller, who called his Chicago Agency Z-1 or A-2 or something as silly.

These were the people - the "colleagues" - that Jack had agreed to spend a week with because someone sent him a free ticket for a Caribbean cruise. That would teach him not to look a gift horse in the mouth. Next time he'd know better.

This time, though, he had some murders to solve because none of the others could figure their way out of a pair of pants.

Yeah, it looked like old Jack Miles was going to figure this one out if they were going to get any peace at all.

And speaking of "piece," Jack was on his way to interview a neat one, that little china-

doll maid of the deceased Lady Hannah^ Susie Tong.

He'd had his eye on Susie from the moment he first saw her at that first-night cocktail party where the first murder had taken place. Now it had fallen to him to question her about not only that murder^ but the murder of her employer^, Lady Hannah.

He tried her cabin firsts but there was no answer to his knock. It was still early^ so maybe she was up on Eight Deck^ or whatever they called it^ taking in the ship's exercise class. Wouldn't that be something? Out of a job and being calm enough about it - and the murders - to take an exercise class? If she was^, of course^ which he was going to check right now.

He took one of the ship's two elevators as far as it would go^ to the Boat Deck;, which everyone simply called "Seven/" and then walked up to Eight Deck^ where the casino and fitness center were.

He didn't find a class going on^, so naturally he couldn't very well question Susie's taking the damned things, but when he looked up to the very top level of the ship^ where the shuffle-boards and chaise longues werC;, he wondered if the little darling might not be sunning herself. Wouldn't that be a sight?

He climbed the steps to that top deck and saw a long figure lying on a chaise longue. Wouldn't you know? It was Susie Tong herself.

"Well, hello/" he said, approaching her. "Remember me?"

She turned her head to look at him, and he took the opportunity to look at her. Cute little body she had, with bigger breasts than one usually saw on a Chinese girl. He wasn't complaining, though, no, sir, not when she had a face to go with it. Be a hell of a thing if she turned out to be the killer.

"I'm sorry -" she said, which he took to mean that she didn't remember him.

"I'm Jack Miles, the P.I. from New York. I saw you Saturday night at the cocktail party, just before Jones bought it."

"Bought it?"

"Got bumped off, killed, died."

"Oh, that was horrible," she said, shivering deliciously in her gaily colored bathing suit.

"No more horrible than your own employer buying... I mean, getting killed."

"Please..." she said, closing her eyes. "I am very upset about that."

"I can see that," Jack said. "It's really putting a crimp in your tan."

"My tan? Oh, you think because I'm

tanning I didn't care about her? You are wrong. I am simply trying to relax. I have been very tense since that first night."

"Well, I could always help you relax," Jack offered.

"No, thank you."

She said that in the same tone of voice Trace's Japanese bimbo had used when Jack had offered to give her some lessons in investigative technique. Cold, both of them. He wondered if all Oriental women were frigid.

"Well, then, I'll just have to sit here and ask you some questions," he said, sitting in a chair next to her. The sun was already brutal and he was

sweating gallons in his white pinstriped suit - the only suit he owned.

"Questions about what."

"About the murders."

"What would I know about them?"

"Ah," Jack said, "but that's where the questions come in."

"I'm sorry," Susie said, grabbing her towel, "I have to go -"

"He put his hand on the towel, pinning it to the chair, and said, 'I'm afraid I'm going to have to insist.'"

"You're not a policeman. I don't have to talk to you."

"Honey," Jack said nastily, "as far as you're concerned right now, I'm God, There's just you and me up here, with no witnesses. Get my meaning?"

"You... you're threatening me."

"Hey, you catch on fast. You're not as dumb as some people say."

"Who said -" she began, then caught herself and looked chagrined.

"Did you know Jones, Susie - may I call you Susie?"

She ignored the second part of the question.

"I did not know him."

"But you knew Lady Hannah."

"Of course-"

"And had reason to kill her."

"What reason?"

"That's what I'm asking."

"I had no reason, and I did not kill her."

"But you found her."

"I did."

"And we only have your word that she was dead at that time."

"It's the truth!"

"What about your boyfriend?"

"What boyfriend?" she asked, her attitude guarded. So she did have someone on board she was seeing. Jack vaguely recalled some exchanged glances between her and Dan Risi

that first night. He hadn't thought anything of it at that time, but now...

"Dan Risi."

"Dan and I -" she said very quickly. Then she finished lamely, "... are friends."

"Oh, come on, Susie, don't give me that. You're a lot more than friends." They had to be, or else why would she have turned him down just moments ago?

"Very well," she said, lifting her fine little chin defiantly. "We are lovers. There. I said it. How do you like it?"

Please, he thought. Risi was as shmy an eel as Jack had ever seen. What did this fine piece of china see in him?

"Maybe you found out that Risi and Lady Hannah were seeing each other, as well?"

"That is a lie!"

"And that would be motive enough to kill her."

"I did not!"

"What about Risi?"

"What about him?"

"Maybe he killed her."

"Why would he do that?"

"You tell me why he wouldn't."

"He has no motive."

"Risi's background looks pretty shaky to me, Susie." It was just a guess, but it seemed to hit the target. Susie's tan cheeks flushed.

"Meaning what?" she asked.

"Meaning that he hasn't always been a stickler for doing things the legal way."

"You don't know Dan the way I do."

"And thank God for that."

"You are disgusting!" she said with feeling.

"I've been called worse by better^ lady. Let's stick to the matter at hand. What makes you think that Dan Risi wasn't interested in something else besides you?"

"Because I know how he feels about me. I know how we feel about each other."

"How?"

"A woman knows when a man loves her/" she said wisely - and naively^ as far as Jack was concerned. She seemed incredibly naive for a woman who had to be in her mid-thirties. Possibly she'd never had to deal with a man like Dan Risi before.

Jack looked down at the towel they were both holding on to. It would have been very easy for her to let it go and leave^ but she seemed intent on holding on to her end of it with a white-knuckled grip. Maybe she wanted to talk^ after all.

Jack released the towel and waited to see if she would leave. She didn't. She seemed confused about what to do.

He decided to stop pushing and try a different tack.

"Tell me about you and Lady Hannah, Susie."

Susie explained how her parents had immigrated to the United States from Hong Kong before she was born, and later died in 1919, when she was sixteen years of age. At that point, Susie quit school and began looking for a job.

"A maid's job was all I was suited for," she explained. "I worked in several households, usually as an upstairs maid."

Jack didn't know what that meant. Was that a lesser position than a downstairs maid? Dealing with maids and butlers and the households that employed them was far from his daily business.

Susie continued her story.

In 1928 her employers moved overseas. She went to an employment agency and was sent to the home of Mr. and Mrs. Demitrio Finestra. She started at a good salary, and eventually graduated to "personal" maid.

"A year later Mr. Finestra died in a fall from his office window."

"A fall?"

"The police called it accidental, but Lady Hannah didn't believe it."

"Did she suspect anyone?"

"Mr. Finestra had many business enemies."

Jack decided that this incident probably was not related to the murders on board. After Demitrio Finestra's death Lady Hannah moved to the Finestra villa in Cuba with Susie and her husband's secretary -now her own personal secretary - Willa Wright.

"Mr. Finestra's hotel went bankrupt and the insurance company refused to pay because he was supposedly a suicide. That didn't stop Lady Hannah^ though. She borrowed money and turned the villa into The Perfumed Garden^ a resort."

"This is getting too involved/" Jack said finally. "When did you meet Dan Risi?"

"You're not going to start on Dan again^ are you?"

"I just want to get the facts straight."

"We met a year ago;, and fell in love. It's as simple as that."

"Who told him that Lady Hannah was going to be on this cruise?"

"I did/" she replied^ a bit too forcefully. "What's wrong with that?"

"Nothing - unless he was here just to steal the Caribbean Blues."

"He's not!"

"He's here because of you."

"Is that so hard to believe?"

"For a man like Dan Risi, yes - and that has nothing to do with you. I think you're fine-looking, and any man would be proud to have you for a lover."

She seemed taken aback by his kind words. Jack himself thought that saying this might help him get to first base with her -or home plate.

"Dan said that this cruise would be the perfect chance for us to spend some time together."

"Susie, during the course of your relationship, has he asked you a lot of questions about Lady Hannah?"

She paused just long enough for him to know that she was going to lie through her teeth - and in his face!

"No."

"No?"

"That's what I said - no!"

"He's never asked you any questions about her?"

"Well... of course he has ..."

"But you just said he hadn't."

"I meant that he hadn't asked me the kind of questions you're thinking about."

"What kind are those?"

"The kind that would help him steal from her."

"So you've considered that^ too?"

"Of course not!"

"But you just said-"

"You're trying to confuse me!" she shouted.

"Maybe you're confused enough without my having anything to do with it."

She stood up then^ pulHng her towel away before he could grab it.

"I'm not confused at all;, Mr. Miles. Not at all. I'm very happy with the relationship Dan and I have. Maybe you're just jealous because you have no such relationship with anyone."

As Susie stalked away^ heading for the stairs^ Jack called out^ "Tell me about Lady Hannah's hats."

Susie turned and stared at him with a puzzled frown.

"Her hats?" she repeated.

"Yes, her hats."

"Why do you want to know about her hats?"

Jack stood up and approached her. He felt wet enough to have fallen in the ocean.

"The autopsy report says that her hatpin was tipped in curare. Was that a common practice of hers?"

"I don't know - of course it wasn't."

"Then who did it?"

"I don't know."

"P. I. Jones was killed by curare. Could Lady Hannah have killed him?"

"Why would she?"

"You lived with the woman, Susie, not me. You should know her better than anyone."

"I do - I mean, I did."

At that point three people came up to the deck, two men and a woman, all clad in bathing suits. Jack pulled Susie aside to the railing that overlooked the outdoor bar below.

"Would Lady Hannah have been capable of killing someone?"

"Yes," Susie said without hesitation.

Jack's surprise was evident on his face. He didn't think she would admit it freely.

"You're surprised."

"Yes."

"You shouldn't be. I told you that she didn't believe her husband committed suicide. If she ever found the man who killed him, she would happily kill him. "

"The 'man' who killed her husband?"

"Man, woman, person - whoever."

"So you're saying she was capable of killing Jones?"

"If he was the man who killed her husband."

"Did she think that?"

"You're confusing me again."

"Well, that makes two of us."

She frowned in annoyance.

"I simply used Jones as an example. She would only have killed him if she found out that he killed her husband, or had something to do with the death of her husband."

"But you're not saying that he did."

"How could I say such a thing? I have no idea if Lady Hannah had even met Jones before."

"I see."

"I really have to go now, Mr. Miles. Are you finished with me?"

"To meet Dan Risi?"

She didn't answer, but compressed her lips tightly together so that they formed a pale, thin line.

"All right, all right, go ahead. I'm through."

She turned and walked to the stairway, then stepped aside to let two more people ascend. When the way was clear, however, she didn't move. Jack watched her and waited. She finally turned to look at him.

"Do you know who did the killings, Mr. Miles?"

"No, I don't know."

"Do you think you know?"

"Are you asking for you yourself^ or for your boyfriend?"

Again she compressed her lips^ this time in anger^ and hurried down the steps, almost knocking over a fiftyish man with a huge pot belly hanging over his bathing suit.

"Bloody rude!" the man said angrily.

"If you're gonna say things like that about people^, Pop, spend some time in the gym/" Jack said, slapping the man's belly as he passed him. The man winced from the stinging force of the blow.

When he reached the deck below, Susie was just going through a far door, back into the bowels of the ship. He could have followed her, but he was sure she was going to see Dan Risi, and he had to question the man later on, anyway. At least this way Miles would know where to find Risi, since the only place the pair could get together was in one of their rooms.

He'd give them a chance to get comfortable.

Jack went back to the Showtime Lounge, where he would report to the other P.I.s on his conversation with Susie, and his insights -if his insights didn't go entirely over their collective heads!

date: Monday, May 18, 1938 TIME OF departure: 5:30 p.m. destination: Guadeloupe TIME OF arrival: 8:30 a.m. distance: 178 nautical miles WEATHER conditions: Partly sunny with some periods of rain.

Chapter 10

While Phil Phlem was ordering a drink from the waiter^ Chico reached over with her fork and stole the pork chop off his plate.

"NOW3 that's really disgusting," Trace said. "You ordered two for yourself^, you ate mine:, and now you snatched Phlem's meal just because you know he's too dense to notice."

"TracC:, please," Chico mumbled between mouthfuls. "You're embarrassing me." She was already casting around the table for new victims. Jack Miles saw her and snaked his arm around his plate protectively.

"Don't try it with Miles/" Trace said. "He bites. That's how he won his last ten fights."

"Pooh on him/" Chico said. "This mornings all I asked him for was his toast. His toast. Do you believe he wouldn't even give up a measly piece of toast?"

"That was after you wolfed down all my bacon/" Miles said sourly^ peering up over his elbow.

"It was the least he could do for me^ after I gave him all that valuable information from my investigation. For free."

"Hey^, Charlene Chan^ I gave you information^ toO;, remember? And mine was a lot more valuable than that ancient history crapola you brought in."

"Ancient history?" She turned to Trace. "Are you going to let him get away with that?"

"Well..." Trace waffled. "He didn't want to lose friends. Either of them."

"Really^ Trace/' Miles said^ "your girl's a looker^ but all she got out of those people was a lot of bunk about the stiff's past."

"It's not bunk!" Chico shouted. "Lady Hannah's history has got to be important to this case. Someone who knew her killed her."

"So? Anybody could've found out what you did by going to the library and reading through some old newspapers. You were at

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the scene of the crime when the body was found. A golden opportunity. And you blew it. Zero."

"Why? Because I didn't find a murder weapon?"

The ex-fighter shrugged.

"And you would have, I suppose," Chico challenged.

Miles resumed eating. "That's what private investigators are trained to do. Real investigators."

"Come on. Jack," Trace began.

Chico talked over him. "That's not fair. I did find clues."

Miles snorted.

"Many clues."

"Right. An empty envelope and a deck of fortune-telling cards."

"And blood," Chico added.

"Oooo, big clue." Miles's face hardened into a scowl. "What do you think comes out of bullet holes? Cheerios?"

Chico tossed down her napkin.

"Sorry, kid," Miles said. "But you screwed up."

Trace could see tears glistening in Chico's eyes. "Excuse me," she said quietly, "I'm not hungry anymore."

She left. Trace rose to follow her. "I think this is serious," he said.

"Must be." Miles sopped up his gravy with a piece of bread. "Got her to stop eating."

Trace found Chico on the deck. Her white dress was billowing out behind her like an angel's wings, and her head was bowed into the wind. Trace knew she was crying.

It always took him by surprise to see her defeated. Chico so rarely let down her defenses that he had grown to think of her as invulnerable. Now, though, she looked like a lost child. Trace longed to put his arms around her and comfort her, but he knew she would never permit that. Her pride was such that she would take a punch in the jaw before she would accept a shred of pity from anyone, including the man who loved her.

He sidled up next to her at the rail. "Want to fool around?"

She shook her head. Her long black hair swirled past his face. It smelled of her perfume.

"Not even from the waist up?"

She smiled despite herself, then wiped her eyes with the back of her hand. "Trace," she said shakily, "you're the best friend I ever had."

"Wait a minute. Only nine or ten hours

of heavy drinking produces statements like that. Pork chops don't cut it."

"I wanted so much for you to be proud of me/' she went on. "I wanted to conduct a great investigation."

"And you did^ Chico. Don't let Miles get under your skin. He's just sore because I wouldn't let him hit on you."

"What?" The sorrow in her eyes was instantly replaced by burning fury. "That bum? I wouldn't go out with Jack Miles if he had the last hamburger on earth."

"Take it easy. I'm just telling you how men think." Trace lit a cigarette. "Besides^ you would so go out with him for the last hamburger on earth."

"Well, maybe."

"Anyway, you did a fine job."

"You don't really think so."

"Dammit, Chico! You don't know what I think."

"I do so. I can tell by the sheepish look on your face. You looked sheepish while Miles was dumping on me. Like you were watching one of your kids running with the ball toward the wrong goalpost during the big game."

"What do my kids have to do with anything? My kids can't even play football. They haven't mastered drooling yet. When the oldest one graduates from high school

next year^ Fm going to give him a pair of training pants."

"Don't change the subject. In your hearty you agreed with Miles about my not being a real detective."

"Jesus! Chico^ you don't make anything easy;, do you?"

"All I want is the truth."

He tossed his cigarette overboard. "Okay. The truth - the naked, unvarnished truth -is that I don't care. I wish you would get that through your thick Eurasian skull. I don't give a flying finger through a rolling doughnut whether you're a private dick or public enemy number one. I love you, Chico. That's all that matters to me."

She looked up shyly at him. "You do?"

"I do," he said, and he kissed her. "Even though you are squat and fiinny-looking."

"You don't think I'm a bimbo?"

"Of course not," Trace said gently. "You're far too flat-chested to be a bimbo."

"Okay, then, tell me what was right about my investigation."

"What was right?"

"Yes. Miles could find plenty of things that were wrong. If you really meant it when you said I was okay, you ought to be able to tell me the things I did right."

Trace thought about it. "Okay. Three

things. Point one: The room where Hannah died was probably clean. It's unlikely that a murderer would drop a lot of clues in a place the size of a ship's cabin."

"There were clues^ though/" Chico reminded him.

"Yes;, I know. Many clues. An envelope. I think that's stretching things."

"It was from Boston. And the deck of Tarot cards. Death was on top. No doubt an important clue/" Chico said.

"Maybe^ maybe not/" Trace said. "Hannah may have been reading her own fortune^ for all you know. At any rate^ I think you found out as much as you could."

"Don't forget the picture of her with Batista. He probably gave her the sapphires."

"SomehoW;, I doubt that the Cuban military dictator smuggled himself aboard the Cunard Countess to do in Lady Hannah."

"Maybe he wanted the jewels back/" Chico offered.

"Why don't we just drop Batista^ okay? Point two: You were right about Hannah's past being important. There are an unusual number of people aboard this ship who knew her. I wouldn't be surprised if she was killed for something that has to do with one of them. Some old slight^ maybe "

"Ancient history/" Chico said. "That's

what Miles called it. Ancient history. A lot he knows."

Trace ignored her. "The only thing that bothers me is Jones."

"Jones?"

"Jones," Trace repeated, waving his hand in front of Chico's blank face "The P.I. who was killed on Saturday night."

"Oh, him," Chico said. "I forgot all about him. Lady Hannah's much more interesting."

Trace closed his eyes and breathed deeply. "Nevertheless," he said, "Jones is dead, too."

Chico took a lipstick out of her pocketbook and applied it perfectly without the aid of a mirror. "Hey I've got an idea. What if Jones's murder was tied in somehow with Lady Hannah's?"

"Be still, my heart," Trace said, fanning himself. "Do you really think so?"

Chico gave him a disgusted look. "Are you saying you came up with the same idea?"

"It may have crossed my mind. In primitive terms, of course. However, I give all the credit for the idea to you."

"Good," she said. "Trace, it looks like I'm going to crack this case after all."

"How's that?"

"You said it yourself. Point one: My clues were good. Point two: Jack Miles is a bum."

Trace allowed a moment for this to sink in. "I never said Miles was a bum."

"Well^ that's what it comes down to. He said I could have found out everything I learned from the scene of the crime in a bunch of old newspapers. He's a bum."

"He's not a bum/" Trace said. "And he happens to be right."

She narrowed her eyes. "You men -"

"Don't use that suffragette stuff with me. Miles was right. There must be all kinds of information on Hannah Finestra in the morgue of a newspaper office."

"Trace^ I don't want to spend a week in a newspaper morgue. I want to crack the case

now."

"Well^ if you could stop interrupting me for three seconds so I can finish point two^ I'll tell you how."

"How?"

Trace nodded toward a group of people standing at the far end of the rail.
"The woman in the white sweater. I overheard her at the cocktail party on Saturday night telling some people she was a reporter for the Boston Bugle. I think her name's Hilda Johnson."

"Did she kill Lady Hannah?"

"Dammit, Chico! / don't know. But she's

got access to the Bugle morgue. All she has to do is send a telegram to her office asking for background information on Lady Hannah, and they can send it right to the ship. If you can cajole her into doing that, you might come up with some interesting tie-ins."

"Like Jones."

"Who?"

Chico punched him. "That's perfect," she said. "You know. Lady Hannah once lived in Boston. And remember the envelope from Boston."

"Even better."

"I'll get on it right away. And I'll be a real detective this time. Trace. No girlish namby-pamby. You'll see. Anyway, you know, we all make mistakes."

"Not me," Trace said.

"No? Remember? You thought Hannah killed Jones because Jones said 'she' when he died."

"I don't remember that at all," Trace said.

"I do. And I'll remind you often." She pecked him on the cheek and started away, then turned back. "Wait a minute," she said. "What about point three?" "Point three?"

She crossed her arms impatiently. "You said there were three things that made me

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great on this case. Point one^ good clues. Point two -"

"All rights all rights I remember."

"So what was point three?"

"Point three is that we're not getting paid for this case^ so it doesn't matter if you screw up or not."

Chico's lips tightened into a thin red line. "You know^ Trace^ I hate to be the one to tell you this^ but your attitude is really unprofessional. You'd better watch it." She tossed her hair and flounced away.

Mrs. Hilda Johnson was the sort of woman other women invariably described as "lovely." Soft-spoken and charming^ she possessed an air of unaffected good breeding from her intelligent eyes to her sensible shoes.

She was even polite to Chico^ despite being accosted like a thief during an arrest.

This was part of Chico's new approach to private investigation. There was no room in this business for a scatterbrain. She would be tough. She would be hard. She was a professional. She would show Jack Miles. She would show them all.

Chico Mangini had come of age.

By the time she dragged Hilda into the lounge for a grilling^ Trace was already there.

He was standing at the bar with two women whose chest measurements quahfied them as bimbos. Chico gave him an evil look.

After several minutes^ Hilda cleared her throat. "Er... do you know that man?" she asked^ observing the ferocity of Chico's gaze.

"He's just some degenerate/" Chico said. "We'll ignore him." She continued to stare.

Hilda Johnson looked at her watch. "Well^ Miss Mangini^ Fm certainly willing to cooperate with the commissioner of the New York City Police Department;, but... by the way^ when were you appointed? I don't believe I've heard your name before."

"We're keeping it under wraps/" Chico said^ "for when I work undercover."

"I see/" Hilda said. "Are you working undercover now?"

Chico nodded in what she hoped was a brisk and authoritative manner. "I'm pretending to be a lowly private investigator^ hobnobbing with the bums and reprobates of that profession." Her eyes were still trained on Trace.

"Yes. Uh... I understand there are a number of them on board - detectives, I mean."

"They're my helpers/" Chico said. "We're here to solve Lady Hannah's murder."

Hilda looked puzzled. "But wasn't Lady

Hannah killed after we sailed? That is to say^ after you and your... er... helpers were already on board?"

Chico had to think hard. "We were afraid something like this might happen/" she said^ shaking her head solemnly. "AH I can say is^ it's a good thing I was here. There were good clues to be founds you know."

"Clues?"

"Many clues." Chico raised one eyebrow.

"Yes. Well... as I was saying..."

"And Lady Hannah's past is very important to unlocking the key to her murder."

"I'm sure it is/" Hilda said. "However..."

"That's where you come in." Chico winked at her. "You're going to help me crack this case wide open^ shweetheart."

She slammed her glass of ginger ale down onto the tabletop. Liquid splashed out of it into Hilda's eye. The woman covered her face^, as if hoping that when she took her hands away^ the obnoxious Oriental woman who insisted that she was the New York Police Commissioner would have vanished.

It didn't work. When Hilda managed to open both eyes^ Chico Mangini was still there^ doing a bad impersonation of Humphrey Bogart.

"Here's the lowdown^ babe/' she was saying. "You're a newspaper gal^ reet?"

"Reet?"

"Right?"

"Right? Oh, right."

"I need you to get the square poop on Hannah Finestra."

"The square what? Oh, yes. I mean no." Hilda shook her head in a frenzy. "No, I can't do that."

"Why not?" Chico asked out of the corner of her mouth. "Got something to hide, sugar cake?"

Two red blotches appeared on Hilda's cheeks. "No, I do not have anything to hide," she said, barely managing to contain her anger.

"Then I suggest you get on the horn, pronto."

"Miss Mangini, I said before that I was willing to cooperate, but I simply don't know anything about Lady Hannah, and I don't know how to find out. As a matter of fact, I came on this cruise hoping to interview her for a free-lance magazine article."

"But your newspaper morgue," Chico said, forgetting her phony accent.

"Believe me, I've checked that. There's been next to nothing in print about her. That's part of what made her such a

fascinating woman. All I know about her is that she went to Cuba without a dime in her pocket, and she became one of the richest women on the island. She owned a big resort, had numerous lovers, and wore a set of three perfectly matched sapphires worth millions."

Chico's face fell. "Cheez-0-Man, I knew that much," she said.

Hilda held up her hands helplessly. "I wish I could tell you more. I'm sorry. I really do have to go now." She took out her wallet. "I'll pay for our drinks," she offered graciously.

Chico's eagle eye noticed the monogram on the wallet: H.F.J. "That your wallet, doll?"

Hilda's two blotches reappeared. "Of course it's my wallet. Those are my initials." She plunked down two bills. "Good day, Miss Mangini," she said in a huff.

"Call me chief," Chico said.

When Hilda was gone, Chico went over to the bar and dispersed Trace's two companions with threats of physical violence to their persons.

"What'd you do that for?" Trace protested. "I was just explaining to them about my new invention. Listen to this. It's going to turn detective work on its ear."

"Like the bottle opener that doubles as a razor, I suppose," Chico said flatly.

"Even better than that. A microphone. A microphone that you attach to your clothes, so that you don't have to take notes all the time. Isn't that the damndest idea you ever heard? You could disguise it so that people you're talking to won't know it's a microphone."

"Disguise it as what?"

"Anything. A boutonniere. A tiepin."

"A foot-long tiepin. Cute, Trace. Very cute."

"You could put decorations on it. Paint it to look like a fish. A frog, maybe. Nobody'll know."

"What about the electrical cord?" Chico asked.

Trace examined the corners of the ceiling for a long time. "Well, I haven't really worked out the fine points yet," he said. "Just the broad outlines."

"Come with me," Chico said, prying his fingers from his glass. "I want to see your broad outlines."

"Find out anything?" Trace asked as they walked down the corridor toward their cabin. "Yeah. Hilda's middle initial is F." "Nothing gets past you, Sherlock."

"I'm a bust as a detective. Trace."

"Hey, you're not going on another insecurity jag, are you?"

She took his hand. "I've been thinking."

"Oh, God."

"About point three," she said.

"Point three?"

"We're not getting paid for this."

"Not a red cent, sweetheart," Trace said.

"So why am I knocking myself out? I mean, maybe I should let some of the other P.I.'s have a try at this case."

"Now, that's a really noble thought."

"I'm glad you think so. I could use a little relaxation. Only..."

"Only what?" Trace asked.

"Only, how will we fill up our time? There's nothing to do on this ship except drink and eat and dance and gamble and swim and get sun-tanned and shop and visit beautiful islands." She giggled.

Trace opened the door to their cabin and kissed her. "Step inside," he said. "Maybe I'll think of something."

Chapter 11

The ship had left port after sunset, and minutes later the elegant small casino had opened. When Trace arrived at eleven p.m., there were only about a dozen people there, most of them clustered around the long, ornate roulette table.

Somebody was missing a bet. Trace thought as he looked around the room. Gambling - legal, high-class gambling - could someday be a high-ticket item, with a lot of profit for the people farsighted enough to get in on the ground floor.

Right now, in the United States, gambling had been legalized only in Nevada, but the single place that specialized in it was Reno, and Reno was a grubby little roadside town, with no charm, lousy hotels, and nothing to pull tourists from the rest of the country.

But Trace had heard that some mobster - Buggy or Bugsy or something - had his eyes on starting a string of casinos in Las Vegas. Maybe that town would amount to something someday. And if anybody could pull it off. The Syndicate probably

could. Sometimes Trace thought that The Syndicate was the only group in America that really knew what the hell it was doing. Certainly^ that lunatic Roosevelt in the White House and all those cuckoo clocks he had surrounded himself with didn't know anything. Maybe that was the way to end the depression: hire organized crime and tell them to figure out a solution. It might work. Anything was better than all those Communist stunts that Roosevelt was trying.

Trace saw the man he was looking for sitting alone at a blackjack table. Blackjack was an old French gambling game^ vingt-et-un^ which was just starting to become popular around the world. The idea of the game was to get cards totaling closer to twenty-one than one's opponent's^ and Trace had grown up playing it with his grandmother using bingo markers as chips.

One of the great sad days of his life had occurred when he found out his grandmother cheated. But by the time Trace was smart enough to figure out his grandmother was a cheater he was also smart enough to have figured out that a player didn't have to cheat. Blackjack was a beatable game if the player knew what he was doing.

As he walked across the room, he thought again about that Syndicate thug, Buggy...

Buggy... Bugsy Siegel. That was it. He hoped Bugsy got Las Vegas gambling going in a hurry, because as soon as he did, Trace was moving to Las Vegas and playing blackjack for a living. Screw being a private investigator.

He slid into the seat next to Hy Court and handed a twenty-dollar bill to the dealer, who gave him back a stack of twenty one-dollar chips.

As Trace took the chips, Hy Court looked around at him.

"Hey, you're one of those private detectives, aren't you?"

Trace nodded. "Devlin Tracy," he said. "Call me Trace. You having any luck?"

The lawyer shook his head. "Nah. I was going to ask you the same thing. You find out who the mad killer is aboard this ship?"

"Not yet. But we will," Trace said. He stacked two one-dollar chips on the rectangle in front of him on the table. There was an ashtray in front of Hy Court and it was overflowing with cigarette butts. An almost empty pack of Pall Malls was on the table. The green felt was littered with ashes. A large water tumbler half filled with whisky, neat, no ice was, at his left hand.

The dealer, an elaborate tanned redhead in a black evening gown, had finished

reshuffling the single deck of cards she was using and offered them forward for Trace to cut. Trace divided the cards into two piles, nodded to the dealer

and said to Court, "They say you were an old friend of Lady Hannah's."

Even though it wasn't a question, Trace waited for an answer. Most people, he knew, got nervous unless conversation filled the air, and after only a few seconds Court replied, "Good friends with her husband, Demitrio. Haven't seen her much since his death."

"Oh, yeah. He's the guy who tried flying out the window, isn't he?"

Court nodded and drank from his tumbler of whisky. "He was wiped out in the crash, like a lot of people. I guess he just couldn't take being broke."

"You were his partner. Did you go broke, too?"

"You can be sure of it," Court said. "All of us."

"Who were the others?"

"There was Rich Ledger. He's on the ship now, too. And me. And Ernest Friendly. He was the hotel general manager. We each owned fifteen percent. Demitrio had the big share, fifty-five percent. We were all old college buddies. Boston University, you know."

The dealer had placed two cards in front of each player, one face up, the other face down. The face-up card in front of the dealer was a six.

Trace glanced at his cards. He had a ten and a jack, which totaled twenty by blackjack's rules. He told the dealer, "I'll stay with these."

Court's up-card was a seven. He peeked at the face-down card as if someone were watching, then sighed and leaned back in the chair. He had twenty dollars in the betting space in front of him. He thought for a few moments, then showed Trace the hidden card. It was an ace, which counted as one or eleven in blackjack.

"What would you do?" Court asked Trace.

"Double down and take one card," Trace said.

"What?" Court's face registered his astonishment at what he clearly thought was incredibly stupid advice.

Trace shrugged. "Do what you want, but I've got this game figured out, and the right play is to double down."

"Just once. Trace, because you look like a nice guy." He took twenty dollars in five-dollar chips and put them alongside his regular bet.

"Go ahead/" he told the dealer. "Double down. You heard him." The young dealer smiled. Obviously^ she thought^ the man called Trace knew absolutely nothing about blackjack. She dealt Hy Court another card face down^ and then turned over her own down-card. It was an ace^ which gave the dealer a total of seventeen. She was not permitted to take any more cards.

Court turned over his new card. It was a ten. The ten^, ace^ and seven gave him a total of eighteen. He was the winner.

"Yahoo!" he cried as he pushed his cards forward and the dealer started matching his chips to pay off the bet.

"Maybe you're on to somethings Trace."

"Fm a student of the game^ Mr. Court/" Trace said. "If I concentrate, I can't lose."

"How come you're not rich, then?"

"I have trouble concentrating/" Trace said. "Something to do with alcohol. Anyway, you were telling me about the partnership."

"Yeah. The hotel was doing real well and we were all making money, and then, at the end of the twenties, just about the time of the crash, things got tight. I guess Demitrio just couldn't take the thought of being real poor, so he jumped out the window. All of us were there, too. It was awful. He just said, 'I'm

not going to take this anymore,' ran to the window, and dove through it. And that was the end of him."

"You all seemed to survive all right," Trace said.

"Not that easy, young man," Court said. "Ernest Friendly had a heart attack soon after and he was laid up for years. He just died a few months ago up in Boston. And Rich Ledger and I... well, we had to scratch around for a long time making a living. There weren't any easy times. I even thought for a while about letting my wife. Sue, go back to work. Hey, how would you play this?"

Trace glanced down at the table. He had forgotten to remove his money after the last hand, so his bet was four dollars. Again, he had two face cards and he nodded to the dealer that he would stand on those. The dealer's up-card was a nine. Trace looked at Hy Court's two cards. They were both eights.

"Split them," Trace said.

"Split?"

"Split," Trace insisted.

"You heard him," Hy Court told the dealer. He reached into his pocket and pulled out a stack of five-dollar chips. He counted off forty dollars' worth and matched his original bet.

The dealer dealt one card atop each eight. Hy Court got two tens. Each hand totaled eighteen.

"I stand/" he said hurriedly.

The dealer turned over her hole card. It was a three. She drew again to her total of twelve and pulled a five. The dealer again had seventeen^ and Hy Court had won both hands. This time^ as she paid offi'^ the dealer wasn't smiling. Trace took one of Court's five-dollar chips and tipped the dealer. She resumed smiling.

"I tell you^ Trace^ maybe we should take this show on the road. I'll bet^ you play^ and we'll clean up/" Court said.

"I'll think about it," Trace said. "Is your wife with you on the cruise?"

"Sue?"

"I guess so/" Trace said. "Right name for a lawyer's wife."

"Yeah. She's around somewhere. I think she went for a walk on the deck with Rich Ledger. Two walking fools, those two. Me, I like to sit down with my smokes and my drink and my cards and enjoy life."

"Different ways to enjoy life," Trace said. "So you met with Lady Hannah the night she was killed."

Hy Court looked at Trace through

narrowed eyes. "Are you implying something?"

"Not me. I'm just wondering."

"Yeah... well, we met with Hannah. Sure we did. Rich and I went in there. I never liked that woman, and now she had this weird idea that somehow Rich and I were responsible for her husband's death."

"How'd she get that idea?" Trace asked.

"Ernest Friendly. I guess he must have gotten senile just before he died, because he wrote her some kind of letter and said that we were cheating Demitrio and he caught us and we threw him out the window. A lot of crap like that."

"And what did Lady Hannah do?" Trace asked.

"She said she was going to make us sweat. That someday she'd go to the police, but we'd never know when. That she'd just let us dangle, slowly, slowly, swinging in the wind."

"That must have upset you," Trace said.

"You can believe that. I was furious." He stopped for a moment, then chuckled. "Very clever. Trace. But no cigar. We didn't kill her. We told her where to get off, and Rich and I left. Rich went for a walk and I went to the bar. The bartender will tell you I was there until the place closed. And when was

she killed? Around midnight^ they said? I was into about my third Scotch by then." He lit a cigarette angrily.

"Anyway/" he said^ "those rumors about Demitrio's death were kicking around for a long time. The hell with them. Nobody ever believed them before^ and I don't know why anyone would believe them now. F'll tell you^ it made it damned hard for me to make a livings those rumors. The police finally called it a suicide^ but my reputation was hurt. None of the big firms would hire me. I had to go into private practice^ ambulance chasings to make a livings and one way or another^ Tm still at it."

He blew a large^ lazy cloud of smoke and coughed, the dry, raspy cough of the heavy smoker and drinker.

"Christ! Listen to me/" he said. "You'd never know I was a college swimming champ at Harvard, would you? My lungs must be filled with macadam by now." Trace pounded him on the back until the coughing jag had stopped.

"So how'd you get to come to this ship?" Trace asked.

"Rich and I got invitations from Hannah. She said she wanted to talk to us about plans for a new resort, so we jumped at the chance

to come along. We didn't know she was plotting some kind of silly revenge."

"One thing I wonder," Trace said.

"What's that?" Court asked.

"Right after Hannah's body was found, you told one of the ship's officers that you and Ledger talked in her cabin about her new resort. That was a lie, wasn't it?"

"Okay, so it was a little white lie. But you know, if I said that she was going to blackmail us or something, it would have made us look like suspects. So we lied. But we didn't kill her. She was alive - real nasty alive - when we left, and to hell with her. The only thing I'm sorry about her death is that I didn't get a chance to kill her myself. Rich Ledger, too. We're close friends, spend a lot of time together, and I know he feels the way I do. But we didn't kill her. Now, are you going to grill me all night, or are you going to make me rich by telling me how to play blackjack?"

"Probably both," Trace said as he nodded to the dealer to deal their cards.

It was well after midnight when Trace found the other private detectives sitting together at a table in a corner of the cocktail lounge. A handful of waiters was busy cleaning up

the rest of the room. Only a scattered handful of drunks was still in the place.

As he slid into a seat and picked up somebody else's drink^ Trace said^ "It's all done. You guys can stop working now. Fve got it all solved."

"Oh?" Heller remarked. "You got the killer?"

"Yeah/" Trace said. "Hy Court. That lawyer."

"Did he confess?" Dither asked.

"No. He didn't have to. I know a guilty man when I see one/" Trace said.

"You should/" Chico said. "Before you tell us how you allegedly solved two murders^ why don't you fill us in on this lawyer?"

"Sure/" Trace said. He pulled a cocktail napkin out of his pocket. "You know/" he said^ "someday^ somebody's going to invent some kind of little

recording device that you can keep notes on and stuffy so you don't always have to write on cocktail napkins."

"Why don't you go invent one?" Chico said. "It sounds like a better idea than most of your get-rich-quick schemes."

"Hey, calm down, lady. You're talking to a guy who won fifty dollars at the blackjack tables tonight. As well as solving two murders. Anyway, Hy Court. Fifty years old. Born in Boston. Father a judge, mother from

England. Harvard. Friends and partners in a hotel with Hannah's husband; Rich Ledger and Ernest Friendly. They were all together when the lady's husband^, Demitrio Finestra^ decided to fly through a window. Since then^ private practice^ a little hard times^ but still kind of lives above his means. Wife. Used to be Sue Banister. Been married thirteen years. She's from New York. Her folks owned a furniture store^ but they got killed in a car accident in Italy about eight years ago."

Trace looked up. "In case I never told any of you this before^ don't ever drive in Italy. Those Italians are crazy."

"Get on with it^ Trace/" Chico said.

"Rights right. So^ anyway^, Court is scratching out a living. His wife used to be a writer and editor^ and he thought for a while about sending her back to work^ but changed his mind. So then they get an invitation from Hannah to come on this cruise. She tells them that she wants to talk to Court and Ledger about being partners in a new place she's opening. They come and they meet with her Saturday nighty at about eleven o'clock. But it turns out that she doesn't want them to be partners at all. What happens is that she's got a letter from Ernest Friendly. He was the other partner. Just before he died^ he wrote a letter that told her

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that all three partners in the hotel had been cheating her husband^ and when he found out about it^ Rich Ledger and Hy Court threw him out the window. Finestra didn't commit suicide; he was murdered. Anyway^ Hannah told them that she knew and that she was going to make them sweat before she called the cops."

Trace looked up from the cocktail napkin^ then crushed it and put it into his pocket. "Hah? Hah?" he said triumphantly. "Is that a motive^ or is that a motive?"

Heller said thoughtfully^ "It sure as hell sounds like a motive for killing Lady Hannah. But what about my partner^ Jones? What would that have to do with killing him?"

"You people always do this/" Trace grumbled. "You always bother around with details. I tell you this guy's the killer."

"If he was^ why would he bother telling you all about this?" Andy Baltimore asked.

"Well^ he said the bartender could give him an ahbi for the time Hannah was killed. He said he was at the bar here and didn't leave until closing." Trace waved a hand derisively. "But you know... that's all hogwash. He did it."

Chico left the table.

Phil Phlem said, "I thought that Court

and Ledger said that they had discussed a new partnership with Lady Hannah."

"That's what Court said at first," Trace said. "But he finally admitted he was lying. They were afraid somebody would think they had killed her. Well, they were right. I do."

Trace finally got the waiter's attention and ordered a drink.

Heller said, "They still had no cause to kill my partner... unless they're jewel thieves or something and he got on to them, but I don't think so. I don't know." He looked through the lounge windows out at the Caribbean.

Chico came back and sat at the table again.

"Back to the drawing board. Trace," she said. "This is the same bartender. He remembered Court. He said he never left the bar Saturday night until it closed."

"Oh, that's hog bilge," Trace said. "How can he remember a thing like that? People get up and go to the bathroom. Bartenders don't remember things like that."

"This one did," Chico said. "He said that he and Court were talking about it, and Court said he never went to the bathroom while he was drinking because he had the greatest kidneys on earth. It was like a joke. Sorry, Trace. And besides, didn't you say the

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murderer was Lady Hannah because the dead man, Jones, mumbled 'she'?"

"An uncommon momentary sHp on my part," Trace said. "I've rethought it. Jones didn't say 'she'; he said 'shy' - for shyster. That means Hy Court, don't you see? And that's not all. There's lots of evidence."

"Like what?" Chico asked

"All right. A. Hy Court's a lawyer. They're all criminals, especially all those ones in Washington working for that lunatic Roosevelt. B. Court needs money and he gambles. C. He smokes far too much for any trustworthy person. D. He drinks like a fish. Case closed and proved. He did it. Hy Court is your killer." He leaned back, sipped someone else's drink, lit a stolen cigarette, and demanded, "How could anybody not suspect a man with such terrible habits?"

"You've got me. Trace," Chico said. "You truly have."

"Lucky guy," Heller said.

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date: Tuesday, May 19, 1938 TIME OF departure: 6:30 p.m. destination: St. Lucia TIME OF arrival: 8:30 a.m. distance: 133 nautical miles WEATHER CONDITIONS: A storm is brewing and the seas are choppy.

Chapter 12

Excerpt from operative's report^ case file 714^ date May 20y 1938. To the attention of George Donahuey vice-president^ Cunard Line. Reporting operative: Nathan Heller^ president^ A-1 Detective Agency, Chicago, Illinois. Written en route during Caribbean cruise aboard Cunard Countess.

Today, George, I thought maybe I had the son-of-a-bitch.

This bird Trace may seem half-witted and half soused half the time, but he also seemed half smart and half sober.

So when he said he knew who killed Jonesy^ I had to take him at least half seriouslyyy right?

Wrong, The sum and total of his theory was this (Are you ready^ George? Sitting down?): Attorney Hy Court was the killer because Trace has run into lawyers before who were killers. To this he adds that this particular lawyer drinks and smokes too much^ making him especially prone to character flaws. This view I can accept^ since Trace himself drinks like a fish and smokes like a smoke stacks to put it tritely but accurately.

Nonetheless^ I did^ as I saidy take him half seriously. In Chicago Fve had occasion to run into a disreputable lawyer now and again. That was understated sarcasm^ George - put your eyebrows down^ and while you're at it^ sit down if you haven't already. This goddamned report on this

goddamned case on this goddamned cruise is about to take a turn. A goddamned turn.

Tuesday nighty after Trace imparted his brilliant theory^ based upon nothing substantial at ally I couldn't sleep. My cabin was a cell. The ship was careening through whitecaps taller than the Trib Tower andy since I was too much the he-man to take any of those sissy seasick pillsy my stomach was careeningy toOy and so was my mind. This guy Court - he could be the killer. Trace could be right. So why waste time

with niceties? My partner was dead^ and Court was a lawyer. Rousting a lawyer wouldn't do my conscience any damage. Some threats of violence and maybe a little violence itself might get me the answers I was looking for. Why waste time trying politely to interrogate a mouthpiece who knew all the tricks of the trade?

Shaking him by the front of the shirt till all the shyster tricks were shook out of him made sense to me.

I asked around the ship - checking in the dining room^ the library^ the casino (not yet open for gamblings but in free use as a lounge)^ and finallyy in the latter^ that dishy little blonde, Willa, sitting reading an Agatha Christie, said she thought Court had gone up for a swim in the pool on Eight Deck, the top deck.

"The pool doesn't open till ten/" I said. "It's barely eight."

She just shrugged and made a pretty face.

I growled her my thanks and went on up. The wind was chilly, but the climate was otherwise hot and humid. So when a gust of wind pushed at you, you felt a chill; the rest of the time you baked. This is the last cruise I ever go on incidentally, George - I like it better in Chicago, where the weather usually stinks, but at least you know where you stand: Cold is cold, and hot is hot, and the hell with this tropical noise,

I climbed the steps to the upper deck, heading to the pool, when that massive truck of a guy, that would-be white blues singer. Scats Allegro, stepped out of the steam room. He was a block of flesh in a terry-cloth robe, body beaded, white hair damp. He grinned at me like Satchmo and rubbed his Buddha belly.

"The Scatman ain't havin' much luck losing this life preserver. Heller, my man."

"Scats," I said, "I don't like you. I didn't like you in Chicago, and I don't like you here. "

"Hey, man, what's the problem? What did the Scatman ever do to you? "

"You lifted every lick in your pathetic bag of tricks from real blues singers on the South Side."

"Heller, those cats are primitives - it's the Scatman who truly knows how to wail. "

"You're a phony and a bigot. Scats. If you'll excuse me. . ."

"Bigot? Moi? / done the black man a favor, man - / took his crude jungle boogie and gave it a real audience. . . ."

"A white audience, you mean. "

"Yeah, " Scats said, his round, pale face a ball of confusion. ' 'A in't that what I said?"

"I notice you're not sitting in with the band on the ship. . . ."

'7 don't play with those cats." "Those colored cats?" "Hey, I don't pay no attention to their color, man. Are you kidding? It's just I'm way past 'em."

"They don't have a handle on jazz and blues like the Scatman, right?"

"All root, " Scat said, jllashing his big white grin.

I just shook my head and went on past the gym to the pool. The area was empty - the lounge chairs, deck chairs, sunning themselves, metal gleaming; the bar across the way unattended. The blue-and-white mosaic of the pool glistening, wetly splashed about, though no swimmers were present. Odd. I moved closer and saw that I had been wrong.

There was a swimmer.

Only he wasn 't swimming.

"Scats!" I called out. "Haul your fat butt up here!"

His voice called out, somewhat distant. "Say what?"

I said what, again, and knelt by the pool, where a body floated, face down.

"Damn!" I said, and jumped in. (My seersucker suit was ruined by this act of bravado, George, leaving me with one suit for the rest of your damned cruise. Replacement cost will be on my expense account. No

discussion on this point or Fll sue your butt. Of course^ Fll have to use a lawyer other than Hy Court.)

Hy Court, whose body this was - and it did seem to be a body, as lifeless as a dead fish floating in a stagnant pond - would not be answering any of my questions.

"Heller, what the hell, man, what the hell..."

Scats was at the edge of the pool, leaning over, hairy hands on bare knees, eyes wide and marble-round mouth open as if he were about to start spouting one of his phony-baloney bebop riffs.

"Give me some help, you dumb lardassf

He scowled at me, but stripped out of his robe and jumped in, the water geysering as his bruiser's body dropped in. He paddled over and helped me

haul Court onto the tile near the pool. I climbed on the lawyer's back and began trying to give him some artificial respiration, his arms butterflyed out while I kept up a rhythm on his back. Scats watched with an expression of surprise and concern, then began shaking his head, "It ain't gonna do you any good, man. Cat's dead."

I turned the body over and began to shake it. "Talk, you lousy goddamned shyster! Talk!"

I don't know how long I did that, George,

/ haven't hidden that this is a personal matter. That I might not be at my most collected. My most detached.

But after a while I felt a hand on my shoulder and a sweet voice said^
"Stop. He's dead, Mr. Heller."

I glanced back and Chico was standing there, in a black swimming suit, towel over her arm, a study in grace and beauty. Me, I was just a schmuck in a wet seersucker trying to slap some truth out of a corpse.

Standing behind her in his suit, towel over one arm, cigarette in a casual hand, was a befuddled-looking Trace.

"Maybe Court isn't the killer," he said.

"I stood. "That theory," I said, "will hold
water."

And I went to get the captain.

Chapter 13

If Andy Baltimore had been expecting the morgue to be a sterile, pristine area just off the hospital, he would have been disappointed. It was a dark, gloomy, cramped room in the very bowels of the ship, at the end of a long, meaningless corridor. Andy

trudged down it^ feeling as if he were marching through the craft's tainted soul.

To get there;, Andy had to go down every step in the place and pass a half dozen doors marked "Do Not Enter," "Trivate/" and "Tor Crew Only." He also had to pass the Negroes in the galley, the Cockneys in the crew quarters, and the Chinese in the laundry. Each of them had looked up from the huge, hot, steamy machines they were manning to stare, expressionless, at the obsessive little man who strode past.

Each one of them knew Andy didn't belong down there.

Nobody stopped him.

Andy grabbed the warm metal latch of the big, thick, unmarked metal door, pushed down, and pulled. His already low-slung heart sank as he stepped inside the crypt. To his immediate right was the morgue - a single steel refrigerated tomb the size of a small submarine. There was refuse around its base. To the left were link-fence cages crammed with electrical and plumbing equipment.

Death among the toilets, was Andy's first thought. A soul-stirring, second-to-last resting place.

Andy looked sourly at the freezer door. He thought about what had led him to this

ignominious trespass. The investigation had stopped days ago as far as he was concerned. Nobody cared about the victims anymore... if they had cared at all. It had now degenerated into an infuriating exercise in maintenance. Trace was all but bragging about his deflated lawyer theory. Chico had her hands full just keeping him upright. Dither and Phlem were busy oozing smug all over their nice clean floors. Miles may have had his heart in the right place^ and certainly his fists^ but who knew where his head was?

And Andy was even unsure about Heller. How much of his crusade was in memory of his partner^ and how much sinful pride? Besides^ he was being

forced to play scout master more than Sam Spade.

As for the others ... Who wasn't lying? The idea of talking to those people any more made Andy sick. They were covering their behinds and uncovering their breasts. Better he should talk to dead people. Yeah^ let's see what the corpses had to say.

Andy was welcomed to the underworld by a blast of sickeningly stale air as he yanked open the morgue tomb. He averted his head and almost fell back as the stench of death hit him in the face. Through tearing eyes^ he

saw the furnace-sized interior crammed with macabre shapes.

For a split-second^ Andy thought he had finally gone off the edge. But as he stepped aside^ he realized that the freezer wasn't even on. Andy stumbled forward^ grabbing for the tomb's top. His fingers fell on a pile of cloth as his other hand went for the small^ screwed-on box beside the mausoleum's door.

All he had to do was touch it. The orange plug stuck in the top^ then shifted^ and the electricity surged on. Cold air^ growing frigid, immediately started pumping out of the interior's sides.

Andy leaned back against the link-fence wall, gasping and blinking. He let his hands drop to his sides^^ still holding the cloth. He looked down to see a light jacket in his grip. It was Hy Court's jacket.

Okay, fine. This gave him something to do while he waited for the bodies to ice. He did a thorough body search of the inanimate object. Andy knew immediately that no one had thought of doing even this most rudimentary example of detection. No, they were too busy talking to Hars.

There it was. Folded in the inside pocket. A one-page letter. Succinct. Simple. Suicidal.

Jan. 5, 1938

Dear Mrs. Finestra,

Although it has been many years, I'm sure that you will remember me from happier days at the Finestra Hotel. As one of your husband's partners in the hotel, I feel that I must take some of the responsibility for Demitrio's death.

Having recently learned that my next heart attack will be my last, I will instruct my sister to send you this letter after my death.

I hereby confess to the embezzlement of hotel funds, along with Hy Court and Rich Ledger. When D. Finestra confronted the three of us with his allegations, Hy Court and Rich Ledger killed him! They threw him out the office window, and proceeded to destroy all evidence of the embezzlement. Court and Ledger then told the police that Finestra was depressed over the stock market crash and committed suicide by jumping.

Although I was not directly involved in the murder, I was threatened into silence by the other partners. I know that by keeping their secret, I became an accessory

to the crime. This has weighed heavily on my conscience^ especially since insurance companies won't pay on suicides.

Now that I am dying and while I can still make things right I am putting this all down on paper. Take it to the police^ or do whatever you want with it. I shall be able to die knowing that I have made restitution for my sins.

With Deepest Regrets,

Ernest Friendly

Naked in death, vulnerable to the slings and arrows of outrageous eternity, the corpses lay atop one another as if resting on an invisible bunk bed. This was a morgue built for one that was now triple-teamed. They made a perverse Havannah Hannah sandwich: the poisoned P.I. on the bottom, dried spittle over his lower lip; Lady Finestra in the middle; and the freshly killed attorney on top.

Yes, dammit, killed. The odds that Demitrio Finestra walked out of that office window under his own power, then the Chicago P.I. coughed up his

guts. Lady Hannah was nailed to the deck, and Hy Court took the long dive of his own accord

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were astronomical. Especially in light of the letter.

Andy reached into the tomb the way he would in a stopped-up toilet. He found himself holding his breath as he fondled Hy's head. One lump or two? None. Dead end. Yeah;, but what was that? A pimple? On the back of his neck? What could the ship's doctor be thinking of? That Court was attacked by a vampire with a missing denture?

It was at times like this that he fervently wished he had a Larry and Curly. What joy to go through life with someone to slap^ slug^, and poke the eyes of. Moe and he understood each other. Spread out^ Willa Wright^ here comes Andy.

. He tried to calm down by walking as fast as he could and breathing deeply. Andy Baltimore did not hit women. That was what Tracey Tailer was for. But Tracey wasn't here^ curse the luck^ and at least some truth would have to be extracted. This thing would haunt him for the rest of his life if justice wasn't served in some fashion.

As Andy searched and searched and searched^ his anger lessened and his anguish rose. This was a plot against him. Everyone was hiding just beyond his vision^ giggling into their hands. A vision of his

haunting a ghost ship flashed through his brain.

All the old, familiar places were deserted of suspects, and he didn't want to start pounding on a passenger out of sheer frustration. So his quest continued on the very outskirts of the vessel, practically praying he'd find an innocent captive, bound and gagged in a lifeboat, whom he could rescue.

Andy stepped out onto the portside deck expecting to find it as empty as all the others. But there, all the way down by the "No Passengers Beyond This Point" sign, was Scats Allegro.

What sort of a stupid name was Scats? Looking at the hulking bonehead, Andy imagined his parents had taken one look at him in the crib and cried "Scat! Get that kid outta here!" Andy felt stupid enough without yelling that artificial moniker.

"Hey!" Andy shouted at him. "Willie boy!"

Scats, who had been staring vacantly out to sea, acted as if he was just plugged in. He started, looked around wildly, spotted Andy, and ran as fast as he could in the other direction.

"Hey!" Andy howled with delight, tearing

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after him. "Great! thank you^ thank you^ oh;, God^ Thank you ...!"

Scats raced along the narrow deck^ beneath the gigantic, hanging Hfeboats. He ignored the "No Passengers" sign, leaping over the low gate. Andy kept after him, maintaining an even pace so he wouldn't end his fun too soon. Scats was surprisingly quick for such a big man, but years of running after captive-filled trucks along Sunset Boulevard won out.

Andy caught up with him just as Scats was about to round the corner of the ship's bow. "Oh, Willie boy," Andy cried, as if he were Jack Benny calling Rochester, his hand just touching the surly singer's shoulder.

Scats grabbed a life buoy off the wall and swung it at Andy's head. Andy ducked under it and it slammed back into the wall. Andy stood, his head inside the doughnut hole. He smiled and jerked back his neck and torso. The heavy, padded life buoy was yanked out of Scat's hand as if it had been pulled by a • rope.

Ooo, Andy thought of himself. You show-off , you. He let the buoy fly back off his head, behind him, as Scats pulled back his arm for a straight-arm punch. Andy's head snapped back upright, seeing the punch coming like a Hitchcock shot.

Andy cocked his head to one side. The ham-like fist went past his ear^ just grazing the lobe.

Decisions^ decisions. So much target^ so little time. What would Miles do? Andy wondered. Shot below the belt? Shot to the solar plexus? Kick to the shin or knee? Night drop (between the legs?) Rabbit punch? The fabulous nose bone-into-the-brain maneuver with flat of hand or forehead? All of the above?

Andy dropped to his knees. Scats's gut filled his vision like a cellulite sky. Andy gave a shorty explosive punch to Scats's bulFs-eye.

Scats made the sound that made New Orleans famous and started the birth of the blues. Andy straightened^ took his arm^ and led the out-of-breath^ doubled-over man to the starboard side.

"Here/" he offered pleasantly. "Let me introduce you to the wonderful world of internal bleeding."

Scats folded over the railing and shot his lurch into the blue Caribbean.

"That was wonderful/" Andy prattled on. "I'm refreshed. I'm renewed. I'm revitalized "

"I'm retching/" Scats growled wetly^ raising his slightly greenish head. He looked

like an unripe tomato. "What did you slug me for^ man?"

"Oh, Fm sorry/" Andy apologized profusely. "Obviously you were trying to save my life. Just think, someday I might fall overboard and Fd never have to worry with that lifesaver lodged in my throat. Why, aren't you sweet? What did you run for?"

"Hey, man, I don't have to tell you anything. Fm sick and tired of you clowns giving me a hard... urk! "

Andy had stepped on the back of Scats's calf, forcing him to go down on one knee and smack his jaw on the railing.

A second later it was like it never happened. Andy was just standing there, smiling innocently, and Scats was back upright, little stars dancing before his eyes and little canaries singing in his ears. Ah, yes, Andy thought. Life as a Warner Brothers cartoon. Nothing like it.

"You're losing your accent, Willie boy," Andy warned.

Scats's eyes cleared and, sure enough, when he spoke his voice held little of the artificial gravel. "How do you know my name?" he asked tightly.

Andy was thunderstruck. "You mean that's it? Your name isn't Scats?"
Maybe a

bit of Tracey's delicate psychic ability was rubbing off.

"Middle name," the quickly recovering man said. "William Scats Allegro."

"You look like a William," Andy decided. "What sort of stupid name is Scats?"

"With a last name like Allegro, just be glad they didn't name me A Cappella."

"Well, William, Bill, Willie, Willie lad. Will honey, Billy boy. What are you running from?"

"Hey! Me, man? Nothing. You just spooked me is all." As his strength was returning, so was his totally artificial demeanor and voice. "It's just, you know, man, for the last couple of days, with all you crazies running around and all the bodies droppin', I just couldn't swing from all the stress and pressure."

Andy was dumbfounded. "I beg your pardon?"

"What, man?"

"What did you say?"

"About what, man?"

"You couldn't swing."

"No, man."

"Why not?"

"All the stress and pressure, man."

"Stress and pressure?"

Scats was looking at him as if he were

retarded. "Yeah, man, stress and pressure. What's the matter with you?"

"Oh, nothing," Andy said sweetly. "Just the stress and pressure." Andy suddenly wanted to call China on the porcelain telephone. This... this pompous, posturing bullfrog and that beautiful blond secretary... ?

"Stress and pressure" were the words Willa Wright had used. Nobody else on board had used such an awkward phrase. That was what came of rehearsing too much.

"Yeah... well, if you'll excuse me, man," Scats was saying, edging away, "I gotta go teach those darkies in the orchestra how to really feel the blues."

"You'll sing now," Andy told him. "How long have you been seeing Lady Hannah's secretary?"

Scats froze, looked at Andy, then burst out laughing. His mirth was cut off by his still-pained gut. "Argh. So you know, huh, man? How much did she tell you?"

There were a couple of ways to go with that one. Andy could lie and say she'd confessed all, but then why would Scats repeat it? Or he could lie and say that Willa had accused Scats of God knew what, but then he might not believe it, or clam up. Then there was part of the truth, where he

could say that she hadn't said enough and try to browbeat Scats for more.

Then there was the real^ practical^ mercenary truth. Honesty was the best poUcy.

"She said just enough to get her in a scowload of trouble/" Andy revealed angrily. "She knows all about Demitrio Finestra's death and isn't talking. Fine with me. Let the San Juan police get it out of her. I hear their holding cells are lovely this time of year."

Scats laughed again. He reminded Andy of all those B-movie villains who gloated over everything that was said. "Hey^ be cool^ man." Andy thought of the corpses in the freezer^ which only made him madder. "She was covering my rear^ that's all^ man/" Scats concluded.

"I'm about to tear it off and play basketball with it^ man/" Andy seethed. "What absurd^ pathetic reason do you have for withholding information and complicating things? N03 no, let me guess. You're married, right? You and Willa are married, and Lady Hannah had some sort of stupid no fraternization rule."

It was Scats's turn to be dumbfounded. "That's exactly right!" he announced, incredulously. "How did you guess?"

"There's more," Andy announced. "Any-

thing Wright knew about Lady Hannah, you knew. You knew how Mr. Finestra died, and you also knew Hy Court and Rich Ledger had a meeting with his widow the day before she was shot."

"Yeah?" Scats said, his eyes veiled. "What of it?"

"You tell me," Andy demanded. "Right

now."

Scats started to laugh. Andy took a step toward him and the singer's mirth was cut off as he cowered. "No laughing," Andy said. "You give me any more of that ho-ho-ho and I'll push your tongue down your throat."

"What do you want to know?"

"When were you born?"

"Eighteen ninety."

"What's your sign?"

"Cancer."

"What's Spanish for 'eat the door'?"

"What?"

Andy screamed incoherently.

"Coma lapuerta!" Scats yelled in fear.

"Where did you learn Spanish?" Andy asked.

"Cuba, man, Cuba. Met Hannah there. In... 1933...'34, maybe."

"First time you met Mrs. Finestra?" Andy wanted to know.

"No, man. We met for the first time in Boston during 1928, just before her husband... died." Scats found himself almost kneeling before his persecutor. He puffed himself up, bragging. "Don't tell my wife or anything, man, but me and the Mrs. Finestra had a little tryst there."

Andy's countenance was horrible to see. It was a satire of a sickly leer. "You like women, don't you. Scats?"

"Uh... yeah, man. What's wrong with that?"

"Nothing," Andy said in a singsong. "Where were you on the day Mr. Finestra died?"

"Hey, you can't pin that on me," Scats insisted. "I was in Chicago, man. I was leading the band at Big Al's Speak E-Z."

"Al Capella's place?" Andy asked incredulously, his previous mood broken.

"Yeah, that's right," Scats said hopefully.

"You weren't there in early '34, were you?"

"No, I told you, man. I was in Cuba then."

"You sure you weren't in Illinois in '34, right?"

"I swear on my honor, man. I was wailing in Havana at The Perfumed Garden club."

"You weren't in Chicago moving moon-

shine and kidnapped teen-agers across the Illinois border into Sauk St. Marie, is that correct?" Andy's eyes were shining.

"Oh, my God, no man."

"Girls who go out on dates for just a little illicit nip and the next thing they know they're chained to brass beds in Canadian brothels. You weren't singing the blues to them, were you. Scats?" Andy was all sweetness and light.

Scats was horrified. "No, no, no. Cross my heart."

Andy looked him in the eyes.

"Hope to die?"

"Hope to die, man."

Andy sighed, seemingly deflating before Scats. The singer stopped holding his breath and Andy stopped hyperventilating.

"You okay, man?" Scats inquired, even risking putting a hand on Andy's shoulder.

"Much better, thanks. Whew! That's a relief. I would have had to push your Adam's apple into your spinal column if you had been around then and there."

"Well, don't worry about that, man," Scats chuckled. Andy put up a warning finger. "Oops, sorry. No laughing. But don't worry, man. I don't like my women chained down. I like 'em walkin' and talkin' in their

high heels and tight dresses." He sighed. "Streets of Paris^ man. Streets of Paris." "Cuba in the year of 1933/" Andy said. "Or '34/" Scats added. "Ask Willa." "That's okay^" Andy said wearily. Exhaustion had come over him like a fog bank. It was all too sad^ too stupid^ too useless. People killing one another for money. What a waste. Andy couldn't wait until he got off this lurching purgatory and got back to Hollywood:, where people went nuts in the name of love. All he wanted to do now was find Heller^ give him the letter^ tell him about the needle mark on the back of Hy Court's neck^ and report this conversation verbatim.

Later^ Chico read the letter. "Well^ this backs up what Hy Court admitted to Trace about his meeting with Lady Hannah. And it explains the envelope in Hannah's room^ postmarked Boston. This was the letter inside."

"Only one problem/" Jack Miles growled.

"What's that?" Chico asked.

"It still doesn't tell us anything we didn't know. Like who the killer is; like who the jewel thief is."

Phil Phlem rose to his feet. "Well;, maybe

I'll figure it out," he said, "and save all you the trouble."

Trace hooted.

"Fat chance," Andy Baltimore said.

"We'll see," Phlem said.

Chapter 14

"You appear a most understanding man. Dr. Phlem." While dabbing the corner of one eye with a pristine hanky, the grieving widow fixed the detective with the glare roosters shot to the East while announcing the dawn on slim immediate evidence. More than to assert fact, her statement was designed to make Phlem rise to the occasion.

"Yeah, yeah," Phlem said.

Having introduced himself to Sue, Mrs. Hy Court, as "Phlem, Ph. d.," he did not correct her calling him "Doctor."

Named for an expectoration, Phlem felt entirely justified in doing what he could to bring up expectation of himself in the surmise of other people.

"Dear Hy drowned only four hours and twenty-three minutes ago," said the grieving

widow without looking at her wristwatch studded with rubies and emeralds.

Sharply, Phlem pounced on the point. "Drowned?"

Sue Court smoothed the dry handkerchief on her knee. "Hy loved the water so. Been swimming since he was a boy."

"Must have been tired, ma'am."

"In college, at Boston University, they called him 'Hy Tide.' Captain of the swimming team, you know." She looked across the Showtime Lounge aboard the Cunard Countess. "I'm so grateful dear Hy died in the element he so loved."

"Ma'am?"

"I'm delighted the dear thing drowned."

Phlem shifted a little uncomfortably in his chair. "Then I'm afraid I have bad news for you."

"Oh?" Sue Court readied her hanky.

"Your husband didn't drown."

"But he was found in the swimming pool."

"Yes, ma'am."

"Face down."

"Yes, ma'am."

"Not swimming."

"Yes, ma'am."

"Not breathing."

"Yes, ma'am."

"Inert."

Phlem felt it was time to help out. "Deader than a mackerel."

"Dr. Phlem." Sue Court fixed her dry, clear eyes on her interrogator. "All that indicates, to me, drowning."

"Curare, ma'am."

"You mean Father Blue? He's a curare, isn't he? What does he have to do with it?"

"Curare is a poison, ma'am - as I get it, featured by the Indians of South America. They dab their arrows with it when they shoot an animal, or an in-law - whatever. If their unwilling target moves and the shot proves to be just a grazing, they still have a kill." Phlem sat forward in his eagerness to bring charade to his exposition. "Soon as it hits the bloodstream..." With both hands Phlem grabbed his chest, then his throat, then his head.

"Contortions..." He twisted his body in mock agony in his chair.

"Convulsions..." Phlem proceeded to jerk his limbs and head to make convulsions real to the grieving widow. "Agony..." He rolled his eyes.

"Gagging..." Phlem tried to cough himself up. "Death..." Phlem went limp in the chair.

"Well done, Phlem!" Sue Court clapped her hands.

"Thank you, ma'am." Phlem resumed his version of the vertical.

"How talented you are!"

"Had it from the ship's doctor, ma'am. A pathologist as a boy, he ran away and joined a traveling mime company before joining the ship."

"How very interesting."

"Yes, ma'am. The doc says your husband died of curare poisoning." His contortions and convulsions in the swimming pool caused him to take aboard water and appear to have drowned."

"Hy didn't drown?"

"Oh, no, ma'am. He suffered."

"Typical of Hy. Think he was doing one thing when all the time he was actually doing something else."

"Never heard of curare, ma'am?"

Although Sue Court fit easily into the category of 'nice folks' in Philip d'Artagnan Phlem's view, and therefore generally would have been marked

for ruination, Phlem's viciousness toward his fellowman in this instance was tempered by a separate ambition.

It was Wednesday.

Phlem had been aboard the Cunard Countess since Saturday.

He had drunk his rye.

He had eaten his food.

He had detected the defects of as many

nice folks as time had allowed^ and reported them to whoever would listen.

But in all that time no opportunity had presented itself for Phlem to express physically his contempt for women by abusing one in bed.

He missed that.

When the convention of private investigators traveling aboard the Cunard Countess had raised the question as to who was going to impose upon the recent widow's grief to play the four z^'s and one hy Phlem leaped at the chance.

Not only was Sue Court a widow^ but Phlem^, needless to report^ had already detected (and reported^ widely) what could be described as a moral defect in her way of life. As part of the subjugation Phlem considered seduction^ he was eager to spring his knowledge on her.

- Her moral defect boded well for Phlem's ambitions.

He had no intention of alienating the grieving widow totally until he had gotten her clothes off.

Curare," she said blankly. Curare."

Oh, yes." A tiny wrinkle appeared between her eyebrows. "Isn't that the stuff I use to remove nail polish?"

"Curare, ma'am?"

"I think that's the name of it." More assertively, she said, "Surely everyone travels with curare, Dr. Phlem."

"You must be mistaken, ma'am."

"Oh, no. I'm seldom mistaken about words. I used to be literary," she said, as one might admit once having had two heads. "I have my degree in English, from Boston University." Again Sue Court's smile sought understanding from Phlem. "In the Western Hemisphere, one does want one's degree in English from a Boston university, doesn't one?"

Phlem hadn't learned his language by degrees.

He'd got it with Original Sin.

"Before marrying Hy," Sue Court continued, "I was an editor at The Ladies' Home Companion. I was in charge of rejections." Sue smiled at the blank hanky on her lap. "Oh, no, don't be impressed. It was an easy job, really. It allowed me to do my nails all week. Then, between three-thirty and four-thirty, Fridays, I simply stuck little notes to all the manuscripts that had been sent in. The notes said, 'Regrettably, your manuscript does not fit into our publishing needs at present. Thank you for thinking of The Ladies' Home Companion.' The mail boy did

the real work. He had to carry them downstairs and Hck the envelopes,"

Phihp d'Artagnan Phlem forced his mind back above the waist.

"In fact, it was at a reunion of Boston University alumnae that I met Hy, in 1923. He'd gone on to Harvard Law School. We were married in 1925. Dear Hy." The widow sighed. "Such a man. He didn't want me to work, of course. Thought it might reflect on his abilities as a breadwinner. I've kept up my hterary interests, of course. I write short stories. Send them out to magazines. No, nothing published yet. Somehow, my short stories don't seem to fit anyone's present publishing needs. But I'm certain I'll satisfy a need, someday."

Quickly, Phlem crossed his legs.

"Hy, of course, was a very good provider. He and some classmates invested in a hotel, and did quite well with it. Of course, it went

smash in 1929 Desperate, having tried

to make an honest living, Hy then had to turn to the law "

"Who were your husband's partners in the hotel, ma'am?"

"You see, that's the sort of thing I don't know. Hy was so very protective of me. If ever I asked a question about business, he'd

say, 'Don't worry your pretty little head, sweetie. Leave the worry to Hy,'"

"You didn't know any of them?"

"Well, Rich Ledger..."

"I was about to bring his name up."

"Rich did my husband's accounting. He'd come to the house, work with Hy "

"Yes?"

"I'd ask him things "

"So?"

"He'd answer. You see, unlike Hy, Rich discovered a genuine respect for my intelligence. When Hy began traveling so much -"

"Traveling? Where?"

"I never knew, really. On business. Wherever men travel on business."

"What kind of business?"

"He never said. Anyway, Rich would continue his visits to the house even when Hy wasn't there. To seek my advice."

"Is that what you call it?"

"Call what?"

"Hanky-panky."

"What which?"

"Hanky-panky, Mrs. Court. You're so good at English. Didn't Boston University teach you hanky-panky?"

"Of course."

"You and Rich Ledger were lovers."

"Whatever makes you say such a thing?"

"Your husband out of town a lot. His accountant visiting you all the time your husband was gone. Mrs. Court, your husband's accountant did a number on you."

"How do you figure that?"

Phlem initiated his subjugation. "I've seen you two by the pool. Neckin' like whoopin'

cranes."

"You must be confusing me with -"

"This morning at four o'clock, I saw Ledger come out of your stateroom."

"He had come to discuss some business with my husband."

"Your husband has spent every night aboard this ship in the gambling casino. And other places. Dessert till dawn."

"Rich has been an especially good friend, this past year and a half. I've found him a great comfort."

"Look, lady, I didn't get no particular degree in readin' and writin' like you did, but I know what screwin' around means."

"A carpentry term, isn't it?"

"You and Ledger have been screwin' around, behind your husband's back."

"What an indecent expression. Really, Dr. Phlem, your imagery -"

"I don't mind."

"You don't mind what?"

"Any port in a storm."

Sue Court looked through a porthole. "What storm?"

"I mean, I don't mind if I do."

"Do what, Dr. Phlem?"

"I mean, as long as you're giving it out."

"Dr. Phlem!"

"Listen, lady, don't come all over virtuous with me. I can nail you one of two ways. Take your choice."

"You have nothing on me."

"Oh yeah?"

"Oh yeah!"

"You and your husband's accountant. Rich Ledger, have been playin' fiddle-faddle for years. You don't call that a motive for murder?"

"You mean, you think one of us... ?"

"The deceased married you, deprived you of your career, put you on a shelf like a laundered dress shirt."

"He was my husband. I was his wife."

"Wife? Ha! You spent your time between the covers with your husband's bookkeeper! The time came to bump your husband off with nail polish!"

"You think you're fingering me!"

"Not like I'm going to, lady."

"This smacks of blackmail. I don't care

what happens to me, I'll not give in to your disgusting -"

"You care what happens to Rich Ledger?"

"Of course I care about what happens to Mr. Ledger."

"I've got you two lined up for conspiracy."

"That's rich!"

"Your husband had a five-hundred-thousand-dollar life insurance policy. Double indemnity. Isn't that true?"

"I've told you - my husband kept me in the dark about his business affairs."

"Yeah, but Ledger knew about them. Maybe he even arranged the policy on your husband's life. You're in this together."

Sue Court made herself more comfortable in her chair. "What's your point, Dr. Phlem?"

"That's what I want to show you."

"Are you saying that if I don't abide by your obscene wishes, you intend to make trouble for Mr. Ledger and me?"

"You got it, babe."

"You can't be serious."

"Why not?"

"My husband chilling in the ship's freezer -"

"So? I'm not a home breaker."

"You're a private investigator."

"Just trying to get to the bottom of this affair, ma'am."

"If you had any real suspicion, or evidence that Rich Ledger and I had anything to do with my husband's death, you'd be duty-bound to report it."

"Duty shmooty. Ph. d. Phlem first; justice second. That's my motto."

"And how do you connect us to the death of P.I. Jones? He was poisoned, too, wasn't he?"

"Practice, ma'am, practice. You and Ledger were just practicing."

"And Lady Hannah? Why would we have shot Lady Hannah?"

"Oldest gag in the book. You kill several people, make the crimes look related, when your real purpose is to kill only one. In this case, the only one you and Ledger really wanted dead was your husband, Hy Court."

Sue Court's eyes narrowed. "You don't believe any of this."

Phlem smiled broadly. "No, ma'am, I don't."

"You just want to get me in bed with you."

"There you go."

"If I don't do as you say, you will make a lot of trouble for us... having seen Rich leaving my stateroom and all."

"A lot of trouble."

"Dr. Phlem, you are the most repulsive man I've ever encountered."

"Likely so, ma'am. What's a repulsive man to do?"

"You make murder occur as an excellent idea."

"You slay me."

"I just might."

"What will it be, ma'am?" Phlem leaned forward. He put his hand on her knee. He looked her square in the eye. "Exposure? Or, exposure?"

She brushed his hand off. "If it's the last thing I do, I'll see you in court."

"Uh-uh, ma'am." Phlem put his hand back on her knee. "You'll see me in Mrs. Court."

For a long moment. Sue Court studied Phlem's eyes. "If I do as you demand, won't I be admitting guilt?"

Phlem shrugged. "Who cares? Maybe you and Ledger actually did commit all these murders. If you bumped off Jones, fine with me. One less competitor in the field. Who cares who killed Lady Hannah from Havana? Who cares who killed Hy Court? As long as I get mine."

Studying Phlem's liquid orbs. Sue Court

thought long and hard. "I have a dentist appointment next week."

"Oh?"

"Being delayed by the police in Puerto Rico would be a dreadful inconvenience."

"Yes, ma'am."

"Bad enough I'm going to have to lay out a Court."

"There's time for everything, ma'am."

Sue Court sat straight. "AH right, Dr. Phlem. I accept your proposition."

"I thought you would."

"Meet me tonight. Eleven-thirty."

"Where?"

"Beside the swimming pool."

Philip d'Artagnan Phlem was pleased to report to his colleagues that he had interrogated Sue Court extensively, and had found no reason to consider her a suspect of murder or murders.

He so reported well before eleven-thirty that night.

Chapter 15

The French were insufferable little pigs, but they did have a knack for the correct phrase, Leshe Dither thought. And the phrase he had in mind now was *Cherchez la femme*.

"Find the woman."

So when he had heard that bad American excuse for a bad American private detective - what was his name, Catarrh... no, Phlem, that was it - when he had heard him talk the previous evening about the possibility of Hy Court's wife. Sue, having an affair with Rich Ledger, Dither thought that the case was nearing its conclusion.

As he had expected, the Americans had done nothing but bustle about and learn nothing. But this business of Ledger and Mrs. Court being lovers - now, this could mean something to the trained intelligent operative.

Suppose they had killed the private detective because he had found out something about them, perhaps that they were the jewel thieves. Suppose they had killed Lady Hannah because she had surprised them

trying to steal her jewels^ the Caribbean Blues. And suppose they had killed Court to collect on his five-hundred-thousand-dollar insurance policy and to clear the way for them to take their romance public.

It all seemed highly logical to Leslie Dither and he was going to ask Rich Ledger about it.

He asked him about it at the bar on the back observation deck^ where he found the balding husky accountant.

"That is quite simply the stupidest theory I ever heard/" Ledger told Dither.

"I would have expected nothing less from you in the way of protestation/" Dither said. "It is rare that a murderer will simply own up to his crime. Or crimes^ as in this case."

"I really think you need psychiatric help/" Ledger said. "Is there a psychiatrist aboard the ship?"

"I don't believe in that Viennese mumbo jumbo/" Dither said. "Why don't you just confess to your crimes? It will make your head free and bring you great inner peace."

"I'll do it if you'll confess to your raving lunacy/" Ledger said.

"Now, now, old chap. I really hadn't wanted this to degenerate into a name-calling contest."

"Then stop calling me and Sue murderers/" Ledger snapped.

"How about lovers? Would you accept that label?"

Ledger turned and took a long swallow from the drink in front of him before answering.

"Sure/" he said. "No secret about that anymore^ not with old Hy dead now. Sure^ Sue and I were lovers. And are lovers. But we would have taken our passion secretly to the grave rather than do anything to hurt Hy. He was my friend^ you know."

"You have a curious way of dealing with friendship/" Dither said.

"I don't think I want to talk to you anymore/" Ledger said.

"I don't think you understand what's exactly at stake here/" Dither said. Before Ledger could speak^^ Dither started to count off on his fingers. "First of all^ there is a posse of American lunatic detectives running around^ grilling everybody. Second^ for some reason^ the steamship line thinks that this is acceptable behavior. Thirds you can be very sure that when this ship returns to port^ the police are going to get a full report on Mr. Friendly's letter claiming that you murdered - with your good friend^ Mr. Court - Lady Hannah's husband. Now^, I and I alone can

help you. Because of my international reputation as an investigator, I and I alone can prevent this snarling pack of jackals from bringing you down. Now I think it is in your best interests to speak to me."

Ledger considered that while finishing his drink and signaling to the bartender for another.

"All right," he growled finally. "I'll tell you anything."

"Okay, as you Yanks say. Did you kill Lady Hannah's husband?"

"No."

"Why did Ernest Friendly say you did?"

"The ravings of a dying man," Ledger said. "Hy and I killed nobody. Demitrio jumped because the hotel was losing money and he couldn't face the shame of being a failure."

"When did you start sleeping with Mrs. Court?"

"Eighteen months ago or so. Hy was out of town at a convention and I looked in on Sue to see how she was. She told me how her hfe had been wasted because Hy would not let her continue to be a writer. She was unhappy about it and couldn't tell Hy. So she told me. I comforted her and one thing led to another. Then we decided not to spend

so much time together because neither of us wanted to hurt Hy's feehegs."

"Did you kill Hy Court?"

"If I was worried about hurting his feelings, would I kill him? You ask stupid questions for a detective," Ledger said.

"You might think them stupid," Dither said. "But there is method to everything I do. Time will prove me right."

"If you're counting on time proving that Sue or I had anything to do with killing anybody, you're going to have to wait till the next millennium."

"We'll see. The night Lady Hannah died. It was midnight. Where were you?"

"Sue and I were out here, sitting near the swimming pool."

"Planning, no doubt, what to do with her inconvenient husband?" Dither asked.

"Wrong again. We were just talking about how sad things were sometimes and they never worked out. Why hadn't I met her before Hy? Maybe we would have been married and led a happy life instead of sneaking around. Stuff like that."

"Sounds very maudlin to me," Dither said.

"But it doesn't sound homicidal, does it?"

"I admit that it doesn't. When did you

know that Hy Court had a half-million-dollar insurance policy on his life?"

"The day he applied for it. He borrowed money from me for the first premium. That was maybe ten years ago. If I wanted to kill him for the insurance, I would have done it before this."

"Why did Lady Hannah invite you on this ship to meet her?"

"I'm sure you know by now. We thought - Hy and me - that she wanted to talk about opening a new resort. Instead, she wanted to blame us for her husband's death. All because of that stupid letter from Ernest Friendly. We told her where to get off. We left. Hy went drinking. I went to find Sue and tell her what happened. That was that. I don't know anything more."

"You handled all the finances of the hotel?" Dither asked.

"Yes."

"Didn't you know the hotel was in trouble?"

Ledger hesitated. "Yes. I knew. But you couldn't tell Demitrio bad news. He only wanted to hear good news."

Maybe some small dose of bad news, administered early enough, might have prevented him from jumping out a window."

"Maybe," Ledger said. "We'll never

know^ will we? Don't forget;, he was my friend^ too."

"Who do you think killed the people on this ship?" Dither asked.

"Talk to Hilda Johnson/" Ledger said.

"Why?"

"Because all Hannah's talk about us killing her husband gave Ernest Friendly - Hilda's brother - a bad heart. I think she might have killed Hannah for revenge."

"Then why would she have had anything to do with Friendly's letter accusing you of murder?"

"I don't know. Maybe it was her way of clearing her brother's reputation. I don't know. Ask her." He finished the new drink in one long swallow^ borrowed Dither's fountain pen to sign the cheeky and said^ "I have to go now."

"I'd suggest that you don't leave the jurisdiction/" Dither said ominously.

"How am I going to leave the ship on the high seas?" Ledger questioned.
"You truly are an idiot."

Dither dutifully reported this conversation to all the other private detectives later that evening. None of them seemed interested. Too bad for them^ Dither thought. When he solved the crimes^ they would be sorry.

And he would solve the crimes. Of that he was sure.

All he needed was a good suspect, hopefully not an Englishman.

Chico had walked out onto the deck. Nate Heller noticed a slump to her shoulders and followed her outside.

"What's the matter?" he asked.

She raised her face to him. Her cheeks were tear-stained. "I'm a flop at this business," she said. "I talked to Hilda Johnson and never found out she was Ernest Friendly's sister. I saw the middle initial F on her monogram and never put it together. I'm worthless."

Heller put a consoling arm around her shoulder. "No, you're not. You're just young. And there's an easy cure for it."

"Yeah? What's that?" Chico asked.

"Just hang around. You'll get older. We all do."

They stood side by side, looking out into the night-darkened waters of the Caribbean.

"Yeah," Chico said not convincingly. "I'm just not much help in finding the murderer of your partner. I'm sorry, Nate."

Don't worry about it," Heller said. We'll get him. I know it. We'll get him."

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date: Wednesday, May 20, 1938

TIME OF departure: 4:00 p.m.

destination: Antigua

time of arrival: 8:30 a.m.

distance: 201 nautical miles

WEATHER CONDITIONS: Rain and rough seas.

Chapter 16

"No, I don't want lunch. I don't want anything," Trace snarled as he slid into his seat with the other private detectives and 11 slammed his glass of gin-on-the-rocks down onto the dining table.

"You're in a fine mood," Chico said. "What's the matter with you?"

Trace used his napkin to wipe up the drops of liquor that had spilled from his glass.

"You know," he said, "someday somebody's going to invent a clear liquor that doesn't taste like juniper berries. I hate the taste of juniper berries. Who the hell ever

heard of eating a juniper berry? Why should I have to drink one?"

"Why not drink Scotch, then?" Phlem asked.

"Because when I spill it on my clothes, it stains them and you can always tell I've been drinking. I need a clear liquor. I just want one that doesn't taste like juniper."

Dither said, "They have one. I've tasted it."

"Yeah? Where?" Trace asked suspiciously.

"In Russia," Dither said. "They make it out of potatoes. It's called vodka."

Trace snorted in derision. "Forget it," he said. "Nobody's ever going to drink some Communist rotgut made out of potatoes. If you're all smart, none of you will buy vodka stock."

"If you're finished with your lecture, are you going to tell us why you're so cranky?" Chico asked.

"Sure. I'll tell you. I was just with that phony fortune teller, Deja Bleu. And I thought I had the whole thing solved, but it didn't work out."

"Why not?"

"You know. Her folks were missionaries named Blue like the color, not that phony French spelling. And that Reverend Peter

Blue - his folks were missionaries, too, and so I thought him and this woman were secretly related. But it didn't turn out that way. They're not related."

"Trace," Andy Baltimore said, "do you mind if I ask you a question?"

"Go ahead."

"Suppose they were related. What importance is that?"

"I don't know all the fine details," Trace said. "What I know is that if they were related and they didn't bother to tell anybody about it, then it must be

important, and so they're hars, and if they lie, they probably killed everybody. It's obvious, isn't it?"

Chico looked at the rest of the table and held up her hands. "Don't argue with him, folks. This is what he calls being logical. Trace, what happened with Deja Bleu?"

"Her name used to be Deena Blue and she grew up in Cuba. She's been reading palms and Tarot cards and stuff like that since she was about seventeen. She just up and walked away from her missionary folks. Then about five years ago, Hannah came to the hotel where this woman was working, had her read Tarot cards or something, and they became friends. So she offered Deja Bleu a job at The Perfumed Garden. She gave her the new name and bought her clothes to look the part.

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But not those silly hats. Deja said she wouldn't wear any silly hats with big hatpins."

Trace looked around the table for sympathetic eyes, but everyone was busy eating, looking down at their plates. He decided to wait until somebody was paying attention to him. He sipped his drink.

Finally, Heller looked up and said, "So? Get on with it. What happened with her?"

"Well, there's Deja at The Perfumed Garden, having a good time, being Hannah's friend and blah-blah-blah and like that. They were real good friends. Real good. Did you know that Hannah left Deja Bleu a hundred thousand in her will to set up some kind of psychic research center in Cuba?"

"Sounds like a motive to me," Jack Miles said.

"Well, maybe," Trace said. "But they were real friends, from all I can figure out. I don't think she is lying. She said Lady Hannah was a terrific person.

Bad temper, don't get on her wrong side, and she carried a grudge, but if you were her friend, you were her friend."

"So? Any ideas? Does she have a suspect in mind?" Dither asked.

"Yeah. But I don't believe it," Trace said.

"Who's she suspect?" Chico asked.

"She thinks that Scats Allegro did it."

"But you don't buy it. Why?" Chico asked.

"Cause I know about things like this," Trace said. "It turns out that when Allegro came to the island in '35 to work for Hannah, Deja Bleu fell in love with him. But all he had eyes for was Willa Wright. So she's just saying that Scats did it because... well, you know... hell, fury, woman scorned - that stuff."

"They found those Tarot cards next to Hannah. Were they Deja's?"

"Yeah," Trace said. "She said she left there just before the cocktail party. Ignore them. She's just sore because the Lovers card didn't have anything to do with her and Scats. Three years and she is still carrying a torch for that guy."

He's probably got rhythm," Chico said. All musicians got rhythm."

Maybe," Trace said. "But he's not beating on her drum. She's carrying a grudge. She told me that he was in some kind of trouble with the law in Chicago. She overheard him and Hannah talking about some gangster named Big Al Capella."

"I told you that, " Baltimore said huffily.

"Yeah. I know. But I wasn't listening," Trace said.

"She doesn't seem to have a kind word to say for anybody?" Phlem asked Trace.

"Susie Tong. She thinks Susie is real sweet/" Trace grumbled. "Everybody around here is real sweet. Fm going to waste this whole cruise looking for a damned murderer."

"Where was Deja Bleu when Hannah died?" Chico asked.

"After dinner she stopped in Hannah's cabin^ but Hannah told her she had a meeting at eleven o'clock^ so she kind of chased Deja. Then around eleven forty-five or SO5 she heard a noise in Hannah's cabin. Deja's got the cabin next door. So she went over and pounded on the door^ but didn't get an answer^ so she figured Hannah was taking a bath. I guess her psychic powers weren't working then. So she went back to her own cabin to go to bed and didn't know anything until she heard Susie screaming in the morning that Hannah was dead."

"Did Hannah tell her who the eleven o'clock appointment was with?" Chico asked Trace.

"N03" Trace shrugged. "But we know it was with Hy Court and Rich Ledger."

"Who knows?" Chico said. "Maybe Hannah had two appointments."

"I'm annoyed/" Trace snarled as he drank

his gin. "I thought Deja Bleu might be the killer because of what Jones said when he died."

"What?" Heller asked. "'She' for Hannah? Or 'shy' for shyster? What's that got to do with Deja Bleu?"

"I thought he might have said 'shay,' like in 'shaman'... a witch doctor or fortune teller."

Heller groaned. "Jones never said 'shaman,'" he said.

"Don't confuse me," Trace said. "I'm confused enough already. I want to go home. I don't want to be here anymore. Do you realize that while we're cruising around the Caribbean, that lunatic Roosevelt is ravishing America? I want to go home."

Heller looked up slowly from the other side of the table. His face bore a quizzical expression.

"I think pretty soon. Trace," he said. "I think we'll all be done pretty soon."

"I'll believe it when I see it," Trace said.

"Stop complaining and drink your juniper," Chico said.

"Believe it," Heller said softly.

Chapter 17

Thinking back to yesterday was a problem, especially considering the amount of time Jack Miles had spent in the casino bar. He knew that he had wanted to question Dan Risi yesterday, but he couldn't for the life of him remember why he had not.

That had to be done now, then.

Chances were good that Susie was sunning herself on the upper deck again. He'd give her time to finish and then go to meet Dan Risi, as she had done yesterday. He'd kill time waiting for her over a cup of coffee at the Starlight Cafe, on Five Deck.

Over his second cup Jack decided that he might know who killed P. I. Jones, but he was still stumped on Lady Hannah's murder. He was pretty sure they were killed by two different people, though, because of the two different M.O.'s. Whoever had shot Lady Hannah might have tipped her hatpin in curare to implicate her in Jones's murder, but he doubted it. He didn't think her killer had that much imagination. He'd turn out

to be a slug-in-the-chest man, and not a crafty poisoner.

Checking his watch, he decided that Susie had had ample time to sun herself and would now be in the throes of passion in either her stateroom or Risi's.

He decided to try her room first, on Four Deck, but as he entered the hallway he saw Dan Risi come out of her room. He ducked back out of sight, waiting for Risi to come to him.

As the man turned the corner into the "shopping arcade," Jack stepped into his path, startling him.

"Jesus Christ, man! Give a fella a warning."

"I'd like to talk to you, Risi."

The man's eyes narrowed as he studied Jack. Physically, both men were similar, average height, stockily built - both dark-haired and sporting facial hair. Jack a moustache, Risi a full beard and moustache. Not many people knew that Jack Miles's father's name was Milano, which Jack changed when he went into the ring.

Jack Miles knew a slimy dago when he saw one.

"You're Miles, the P.I. from New York."

"That's right."

"The one who's been bothering Susie."

"I don't know about bothering^" Jack said. "I was asking her some questions."

"She told me."

"Good. Then you know what I'm going to ask you."

"You're not asking me any things, Miles^ and you're not bothering her anymore^ either."

"Come on^ Risi, don't play hard with me^ you haven't got the right equipment. You don't give a rat's tail for that girl."

"Believe me^, Miles/' Risi said^ jabbing Jack's chest with his forefinger^ "I can get harder than you've ever seen."

"Not likely."

Risi grinned and said^ "Try me."

"Here?"

"Anywhere?"

At that moment Jack thought he better understood Andy Baltimore. He would have liked nothing better than to bust Risi in the chops. In fact he might be able to do that and still question him.

"The fitness center on Eight Deck/' he said.

"Perfect. When?"

"Right now."

They walked to the elevators together^ entered;, and stood at opposite ends^ eyeing each other like two fighting cocks about to

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be released. When they reached Seven Deck - marked "BR" on the elevator button for some reason - they got out and walked up the next level side by side, without exchanging so much as a word or a glance.

The fitness center was a small room equipped with some weights, a heavy bag and appropriate gloves, and a steam room. There were also some mats on the floor, placed there to guard against injuries.

Risi entered ahead of Jack.

Jack was saying "What do you want to -" when Risi spun on him and threw a sucker punch.

Just as Jack had suspected he would.

Since retiring from the ring. Jack had been in a number of scrapes, and every time it came to this, he felt reborn. Maybe he more than understood Andy Baltimore's urge to bust somebody, because he'd thoroughly enjoyed doing just that when he was in the ring.

And he enjoyed it now.

He stepped aside and allowed the punch to whistle by his ear, then stepped in and hit Risi with a right hook to the body. The man gasped and started to turn around, away from the direction of the blow, beginning to sink onto one knee. One thing Jack had been known for in the ring was his ability as a

finisher. Whenever he got somebody in trouble^ he knew just how to finish him. Unfortunately^ he was usually the one in trouble.

This time^ however^ he was in control and he knew how he wanted to finish Risi. He also knew that the man was in fairly good shape^ and had - after all - asked for this.

As Risi was sagging^ Jack hit him in the right kidney with a wicked rights and the man just screamed and crumpled to the mat.

From behind him Jack heard the door to the center opening. He turned and saw Andy Baltimore entering. Baltimore stopped and stared down at Risi^ who was writhing in agony on the mat.

The look on Baltimore's face was a difficult one to interpret. He was sort of glassy-eyed^ his mouth open^ wearing the same expression as the perverts in Times Square peep shows.

Finally^ the man spoke.

"I missed it! I missed it!" he bellowed^ and Jack half expected him to stomp his foot. "I could have done somethings I could have held him;, or hit him -
" Suddenly^ with a hopeful look in his big;, moist^ puppy-dog eyes^ Baltimore said^ "Can I hit him? Please?"

Jack looked down at Risi^ who was now

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making vague, choking sounds, and said, "Andy, I know just how to hit him and just where, because I'm a pro."

"Whaddaya mean? I'm a pro," Baltimore said beUigerently.

"Andy, you'd probably kill him."

"I wouldn't -"

"Or paralyze him."

"Well, yeah -"

"And I need to have him talking."

"Well..." Baltimore said, almost kicking at the floor with his toe. "Okay."

"You can help me pick him up, if you like."

"Okay."

Together they lifted Risi and supported him between them.

"Can you tell me what you did?" Baltimore asked Jack. "Exactly?"

With both of them craning their necks forward so they could see Risi, Jack described the two-punch combination that effected the TKO.

"Ooh." Baltimore looked as if someone had just stepped on his foot. "A kidney punch. That's cruel."

"I couldn't help it, Andy," Jack said. "It was just hanging there."

"Ooh," Baltimore said again, "a hanger."

Risi stirred between them^ getting his feet beneath him.

"Tve got him, Andy."

"Sure you don't need some help interrogating him?"

Jack had a vision of laying Risi out on a rack.

"Vm not going to interrogate him, Andy. I'm going to question him."

Baltimore looked sheepish. "Okay," he said, releasing Risi reluctantly, "he's all yours."

"I appreciate your help, Andy." I didn't do anything." I know, and I appreciate it." Sure, Jack," Baltimore said, "anytime."

As Baltimore left. Jack had the uncomfortable feeling that he had made a new friend.

"Okay, pal, let's find a place for you to sit down."

Jack half dragged and half supported Risi to the stack of mats and sat down on them.

"How do you feel?"

"Get lost," Risi said, leaning forward and rubbing his kidney.

"Hey, friend, you're the one who tried to sucker-punch me, remember?"

"You were a professional boxer," Risi reasoned. "I needed some kind of an edge."

"An edge is something I don't usually leave lying around."

Risi took a deep breath, let it out easily and continued to rub his sore kidney.

"I've got some questions for you now, Danny boy, and my advice to you is to answer them."

"I'm not answering anything."

"I could always call my friend Andy back to help me out."

"Okay, okay, so ask," Risi muttered.

"I made a visit to the radio room and checked you out with some friends in New York. You don't have a very good reputation, Dan."

"So? A lot of businessmen don't play fair. That's how you get ahead in the business world."

"Not only in the business world," Jack said, "but in the underworld, as well."

Risi straightened up, then immediately i winced at the pain in his kidney. I
"What the hell do you mean, underworld? I'm no gangster."

"But you don't always play on the up and ,1 up, either." "Do you?"

Jack was sorry to admit that Risi had a point.

"Keyhole peepers aren't the most reputable of characters in my book."

That was going too far.

"Watch the name-calling, bub," Miles said, prodding Risi's shoulder with stiffened fingers.

"Okay, okay, don't get testy."

Jack almost said, "Testy is my middle name," but it sounded foolish even to him. This character was bringing out the worst in him.

"Getting back to your reputation, a guy with your background doesn't strike me as the kind of guy who would spend money on a cruise just to be near a babe, no matter how exotic she looked."

Risi snorted and said, "Exotic," further illustrating Jack's point.

"You've dealt in hot jewelry before," Jack said. "All you wanted from Susie Tong was the lowdown on Lady Hannah. Admit it."

Risi sulked.

"Kidney's are funny things, Danny," Jack said. "They don't react well to repeating poundings." Jesus! He was starting to sound like a bouncer.

"Okay, so I wanted the jewels. That doesn't mean I didn't enjoy spending some time with Susie. She's real good in the sack, you know."

Jack rapped his knuckles across the bridge of Risi's nose and said, "You are definitely a gentleman."

"Hey!" Risi said, rubbing his nose, then wincing and rubbing his kidney.

"If this doesn't start to go a little more smoothly, you're going to be a mass of bruises and aches."

"What do you want?"

"I want a killer."

"Well, it's not me!"

"Who is it, then?"

"I don't know."

"Then allow me to tell you why I think it might be you."

Risi started to object, but Jack raised his hand, the way one might do to deter a small child, and Risi subsided.

"You've been sniffing after Susie until you could find a way to get close to Lady Hannah through her. When you heard about the cruise ship, you knew that you'd be able to think of a way to get what you wanted. And you finally did." Jack leaned in close to Risi to bring his next word home and said, "Murder!"

"That's ridiculous!"

"Come on, Risi. This whole thing is y ridiculous. Help me end it so that the rest of

us can enjoy what's left of the cruise. Confess."

"I can't confess, because I didn't do it."

"You stole the jewels, though, didn't you?"

"No." His reply was petulant.

"You know where they are."

Risi shook his head and repeated, "No."

"Yes, you know where they are because you stole them."

"You can't prove that," Risi said boldly.

"Sure I can."

Looking surprised - or alarmed - Risi asked, "How?"

"Come on, let's go." Jack grabbed Risi by the arm and yanked him to his feet.

"Where?"

"To your room. We're going to have us a look-see."

"You can't do that."

"Why not?"

"You don't have a search warrant."

Jack grinned at Risi and said, "Remember me? The disreputable keyhole peeper?"

Risi unlocked the door to his cabin and Jack pushed him inside ahead of him.

"Do you have a gun here?" he asked Risi.

"What would I be doing with a gun? I hate the damned things."

The funny thing was that Jack believed Risi. His distaste for guns seemed genuine^ and since Lady Hannah was shot^ that meant Jack didn't believe Risi was the killer. Still, if Risi had managed to liberate the jewels from Lady Hannah's cabin, that meant he had visited the murder scene just before, or just after, the actual murder. He must have seen something, but Jack knew that before he'd be able to get any kind of an admission from the man he'd have to find him with the jewels and use them as leverage against him.

"Vm going to look around," Jack said. "Sit on the bed."

There were two beds in the room so Risi said, "Which one?"

Jack put his hand on Risi's chest and pushed him down on one of the beds.

"Sit," he said. "Stay."

Jack began to search the room with one eye on Risi, but he was distressed to see that the man had somehow regained his composure. In fact, he looked downright smug. The jewels were there, and Risi didn't think Jack could find them!

Forty minutes later Jack had searched the entire cabin - all eighty square feet of it -and, to Dan Risi's everlasting pleasure, had come up empty.

Jack looked at Risi, who placidly stared

back^ and said^ "They're here. I know they're here."

"You're way off base."

Off base? What if the jewels weren't here? What if Risi had taken them and put them in one of the ship's safety deposit boxes that were made available to passengers?

That meant what Jack should be looking for was a key.

"Empty your pockets/" Jack said to Risi.

"Why?" Risi sneered. "Are you going to steal my money?"

"Empty them^ on the bed."

Risi did so without risings just leaning one way and emptying a pockety then the other to do the same.

"Back pockets?" Jack asked.

"There's nothing there."

"Turn them out."

Risi did so, pulling the insides of his back pockets out.

"The others, too."

Risi inverted all his pockets, saying, "Satisfied?"

"I'll let you know."

Jack studied the contents of Risi's pockets, which were unremarkable and contained only one key, and that was his room key.

Once again. Jack went through the room, looking in drawers, under drawers, beneath

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mattresses, lifting the desk to look under the legs, checking the seams of the curtains, inspecting the life jackets, going through Risi's suitcase, suits, and shoes.

He turned and looked at Risi. The man seemed somewhat less sure of himself, but if there was a key he was probably still fairly certain Jack couldn't find it.

Jack went into the bathroom, ran his fingers underneath the counter, looked at the bottom of the garbage pail, inside the shower, the commode, the sink. He checked to see if Risi had tied a piece of string to the key and lowered it down the drain.

No sale!

On the countertop he went through Risi's toiletry articles. Cologne bottles, after-shave, shaving equipment. He squeezed out the toothpaste tube - out of spite, really, because there was no way the key could have been in there.

Finally, he opened the two red soap holders. Both had perfect bars of soap inside. In the garbage pail he had found a third red holder, empty, and there was a bar of soap in the shower.

And then he remembered the fourth one. He went outside, opened the desk drawer, and saw the fourth red soap holder. What

was it doing in the drawer;, and out of the bathroom?

He picked it up and opened it. Even stranger^ this bar had obviously been used^ since the smooth surface was smeared.

He turned around and faced Risi^ who was suddenly engrossed in the cabin's ceiling.

Jack took the used soap bar out of the holder^ dropped it to the floor^ and ground his heel into it. He bent over^ separated the piece, and picked up the key that had been secreted inside.

"Well/" he said, holding the key in plain sight for Risi to see, "what have we here?"

Later, after he retrieved the jewels from the safety deposit box. Jack took a totally demoralized Dan Risi to Nate Heller. It was Heller's partner who had been killed - most likely by the same person who had killed Lady Hannah - which meant it was for Heller to question Risi about who he saw coming out of Lady Hannah's room just before he went in, found her dead, and stole the jewels.

There were, after all, certain codes to this business.

date: Thursday, May 21, 1938 TIME OF departure: 6:00 p.m.

DESTINATION: Charlotte Amalie, St. Thomas TIME OF arrival: 10:00

a.m. distance: 201 nautical miles WEATHER CONDITIONS: Overcast sky with some rain in the afternoon.

Chapter 18

Excerpt from operative's report^ case file 714^ date May 22^ 1938. To the attention of George Donahue^ vice-president^ Cunard Line. Reporting operative: Nathan Heller^ president^ A-1 Detective Agency^ Chicago^ Illinois. Written en route during Caribbean cruise aboard Cunard Countess.

This will be my final report^ George. The details follow.

Last night the ex-pug^ MileSy recovered your goddamned jewels. So you and the line can rest easy on that score. The import-export

"president" (never get too impressed with that title^ George - Fm the president of A-1^ remember) turned out to be my jewel thief. My jewel thief, however, did not turn out to be the

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He did claim to have seen the murderer leave Lady Hannah's room. My first reaction was that Dan Risi really was the killer and was desperately trying to cast the blame off on someone else - a couple of someone elses, actually.

But what he said, and who he 'd seen, made a certain amount of sense. It clicked with what the other detectives on board had discovered, and with some information that finally reached me via the radio room; some background info on a certain passenger aboard the Cunard Countess.

My immediate instinct was to confront the guilty son-of-a-bitch. But my second thought was: What if Risi was lying? What if one of these other detectives - some of whom were less than masters of deduction, George, let's face it - had left something out when they reported back to me, or failed to interrogate the suspects properly, effectively. . . ?

So I spent the rest of the day one on one with each detective, going over in detail what they had found; I spoke to several of the suspects on several muddy points, as well.

And by midnight I had put all the pieces together.

There was no reason to act like Charlie Chan and gather all the suspects. I knew who had done it. And despite anything I might have said I couldn't have done it without the other ops on board. Well^ I could have done without that bumbler TracCy but never mind. His lovely associate more than made up for him.

I suppose you 'd like to know about who did it and what I did about that "who" righty George? Well I spent a long week on the tuby suffering through an investigation that made my head and heart hurt and sea sickness is in there somewherey toOy so Fm going to make you wait.

It's time for a formal report - it's time to lay it out in front of you all that which my associates and I assembled.

HerCy GeorgCy is the story behind the Case of the Caribbean Blues.

Jonesy was killed with curarCy a pinprick found on his neck. Lady Hannah was the second to buy the farm - shot in the chesty at close rangCy in her cabiny with a .38. All of which made it seem likely the murderer was somebody she knew - somebody she willingly invited into her cabin. A pillow was used as a makeshift silencer - powder burns and bloodstains were found on the pillowcase. Traces of curare were found on the hatpin in Lady Hannah's

hat^ and the Caribbean Blues had taken a walk.

We picked up several key clues in Lady Hannah's room.

There was an empty envelope^ postmarked Boston^ addressed to Lady Hannah. It came from her deceased husband's ex-partnery Ernest Friendly. This same letter turned up later^ George^ as you know - but Vm getting ahead of myself.

The second clue was left by Lady Hannah herself - your classic "dying clue." In the few moments before she was shuffled unwillingly off this mortal coil^ Lady Hannah fanned out the Tarot deck. She put the Death card on top of the deck and drew the Lovers card forward.

There were cigarette butts in the ashtray -Hy Court's; and a cigar as well - Rich Ledger's. Clues^ or red herrings^ left by the murderer? Chico missed them but I found them in the wastebasket. Someone must have dumped the ashtray after they left.

Hy Court courted death next^ embracing it in the cool blue water of the pool topside, Wednesday. At first, we all figured he'd drowned. Then the autopsy report came in. Court died from curare poisoning, and (again) a pinprick was found on his neck - this time in back, hidden in his hairline.

The missing-persons op, Baltimore, found

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Ernest Friendly's letter among Court's effects in the ship's morgue. Friendly wrote that he was dying after suffering two massive heart attacks^ and had instructed his sister to send the letter. In it was a complete confession of the embezzlement of hotel funds^ and a detailed account of Finestra's death.

Did Hy Court murder Lady Hannah to keep her quiet about her husband's murder? Or is that just what the real killer wanted us to think? And if Court did kill Lady Hannah^ who killed Court? His death had been staged to look like a drowning but it was murder by the same curare-tainted hand. . . .

Soy George^ I reviewed the suspects. Which is to say^ anybody on the ship who knew Lady Hannah or had a motive for murder. The two most likely: Hy Court and Rich Ledger. They^ along with Ernest Friendly^ had been partners of Hannah's deceased husband^ Demitrio Finestra^ in the Finestra Hotel. According to Friendly's letter^ Court and Ledger were responsible for Finestra's death.

Finestra^ who did almost nothing around the hotel reaped the greatest rewards. The partners gradually became bitter^ resentful^ and in an unspoken agreement the three began embezzling funds. By the end of 1929 and the crashy Finestra had lost everything and began to look more closely at the hotel which had also

been losing money. He ordered a complete audit and soon learned that company funds had been embezzled.

Finestra called a conference^ stated his allegations^ and threatened to prosecute all three. Finestra promised to destroy their careers and have them sent up the river. . . .

The partners panicked - Ernest had an on-the-spot nervous breakdown^ while Court and Ledger backed Finestra toward the window and threw him out. From the top floor of the hotel.

As for Willa^ she was out to lunch at the time - but then that dizzy dame is frequently "out to lunch." Once Finestra had taken his high dive into the empty pool that was the street below^ Court and Ledger had to think and think quickly. They destroyed all evidence of embezzlement, and told the police that Finestra was depressed over the stock market crash and had committed suicide. Ernest Friendly wasn't directly involved in the murder, but was intimidated into silence by the other two.

To make matters even cuter. Court's wife, Sue, was having an affair with Ledger. And Sue's hubby, Hy, had a double indemnity policy for half a mil, with Sue as the sole heir. How's that for a murder motive, George?

After Finestra's death in '29, Hannah packed up and moved to her husband's villa in Cuba. Secretary to Finestra before his death,

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willowy Willa Wright accompanied Hannah to Havana and lent her five grand in return for ten percent of the action. With what remained of her late husband's doughy and what she borrowed from Willa^ Hannah opened The Perfumed Garden. She was a shrewd businesswoman and soon attracted a high-hat clientele. The Perfumed Garden became the hot spot in Havana^ catering to the chic international set. But if anything happened to Lady Hannah^ Willa would inherit everything. . . .

The famous African explorer I. B. Hunter began taking vacations in Cuba in the early thirties. He went to the best resort on the island - you got ity George: Hannah's Perfumed Garden. He and Lady Hannah spent a lot of time together during one of his first stays there, and it was rumored they were an item - though she never admitted it. The truth is, Hunter was wild about her, and even asked for her hand, and the rest of her as well. For a while he held Lady Hannah's heart, but then she met that banana-republic politician Batista. Batista was rich and powerful and, obviously, could do a lot for her. So Lady Hannah gave Hunter his walking papers - though they had a "bloody" row before Hunter stormed out.

Still, Hunter just didn't seem to have a strong enough motive for killing Lady Hannah. Too many years under the bridge.

On the other handy Hunter was in desperate need of some ready cash. Maybe he asked Lady Hannah for the dough and got turned down. . . or did he kill Hannah and take the jewels instead?

About five years ago^ Lady Hannah added Deena Blue^ a so-called "psychic/" to her entourage. She hired Deena to work at The Perfumed Garden^ reading palms and Tarot cards. Lady Hannah changed Deena's name to Madame Deja Bleu and bought her some duds to suit the part. In her willy Lady Hannah left one hundred grand to set up a "psychic research center" in Cuba. Deja^ thoughy never really believed that she d see the doughy since healthy Hannah would no doubt be around for a good long time. Having seen into the future in this manner^ maybe the Tarot turner decided to change her destiny - and Hannah's - by hastening the inheritance. . . .

Reverend Peter Blue (no relation) has his own honey motive. He wanted the rocksy considered them a "national treasure" that ought to be returned to Siam. He'd demanded that Lady Hannah do sOy but she'd just laughed at him. Would hCy a man of the clothy kill to retrieve those stones?

But the stones didn't really have anything to do with the murder. Despite their colory the

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Caribbean Blues were the biggest red herring of 'em all.

The sky was dark and overcast^ as starless as a movie from Monogram. Tonight even the breeze was muggy. Few people^ even honey-moonerSy found anything to stand on deck and contemplate; only the inky water^ with its rolling whitecaps^ offered anyone anything to lean on a rail and ponder. Up on Eight Deck, the pool area was empty, the bar closed; the sky was spitting, the sea was choppy, and these upper decks I had to myself.

With one exception.

The top deck, the sun deck, up a short flight of steps from the pool area, was the site of a tearful rendezvous between two lovers.

One might even say "the" lovers.

"Just like the Tarot card, huh, kids?" I asked cheerfully.

The ship groaned, metal whining, as the Cunard Countess took a wave, and Scats Allegro, in his pretentious cape and Zootish tux, was holding a trembling young woman in his arms. She was a beautiful blonde in a classy, clingy black gown. Creamy breasts were spilling out a little, but the edge was off her beauty; her makeup was running. Part of it was the mist. Part of it wasn't.

"What do you want. Heller?" Scats asked.

He was sneering^ but his voice was strangely tentative - even afraid.

Willa just looked at me^ eyes as wet as the night.

"Big party in the Showtime Lounge^" I said. "Big'band music, though not up to your level, of course, Scats. Hate to see you sweethearts miss out on it."

"We'd like a little privacy," Willa managed pleadingly.

"Best place for privacy is the ship's morgue," I said, "though I understand it's getting a little crowded. "

Willa winced at that, and Scats looked at me with hard, narrow eyes, the sneer turning even uglier.

I moved closer to them. The deck was filled with row upon row of deck chairs; in the background loomed the massive white mast, flags flapping, a string of white lights above us casting a soft-focus glow on the little scene. I couldn't tell if it was romantic or sinister. Maybe both.

They stood near the rail, near the shuffleboard area. "Keep your distance, man," Scats said. The fierceness of his expression wasn't matched by his

voice, somehow. As gruff as it usually sounded, there was a tremor undermining it tonight. Good.

"We've been having a little convention this

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weekly ScatSy" I said. "Some of my op pals and me. And we got a little bored - nothing to do but try and solve your occasional murder. And maybe nail your occasional murderer."

'7 ain't your man^ Heller."

"You sure aren't^ but you are the murderer^ all right. ""

"Like the man says - prove it."

I edged closer. My jacket was unbuttoned. Nine-millimeter under my left arm. Scats wasn't armed - that I could see. But he was a tricky bastardy and graceful for a big man.

"You met Hannah in Boston in '28, " / told him. "Spent a wild weekend together, then went your separate ways. ""

"She was a married lady, man. It was the right thing to do. ""

"You can always be counted on for that, can't you, Scats.^ But a few years later, after her husband's death, you got back in touch. . . in Cuba. For old times' sake she gave you a job - as bandleader and singer with the hotel band. And when Hannah made it clear her hots for you had cooled, you made a move on little Willa here, and who could blame you? You were secretly married - and knew very well that Willa was Lady Hannah's heir. . . ."

"How often have I gotta play you the same tune, man? Like I said - prove it. It's all talk, man, all talk. . . ."

"Maybe Willa is more interested in what I have to say^ 'V said with a benign smile.

The girl shivered and clung to the big man. But she said nothing.

I said^ "When Ernest Friendly's letter arrived, you steamed it open, Willa, before you delivered it to Hannah - and you showed it to the Scatman. Were you aware of what you were aiding and abetting, honey? That your big teddy bear here had just seen the perfect opportunity to get rich quick? That he figured Hannah was planning revenge of some sort on her husband's murderers, and all he had to do was make sure that she got caught? He could even provide the corpses, if need be - the Scatman always could improvise. And the upshot of it all? You'd inherit, honey. Everything Hannah owned would belong to you. And you belong to The Scatman. "

She pulled away from Scats and sat on the edge of a deck chair; she began to weep into her hands. I felt sorry for her, a little. A little.

Scats stood there, cape flapping in the misty night breeze, and he grinned his ersatz Satchmo grin; but the confidence was something phony he was wearing, like the cape.

"You got nothin', man, nothin' but wind and air and a little rain. "

"I got plenty. I got witnesses and I got hard physical evidence just waiting for the onshore

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labsy andy most important, I got you. You, who took along a Hannah-like hatpin - tipped in curare - in case Hannah's revenge was limited to legal means; if Hannah intended turning Court and Ledger over to the cops, instead of pursuing personal vengeance, you'd have to either kill the partners and frame Hannah, or vice versa. Vice versa would get you your precious inheritance faster."

"Shut up/" Scats said. His voice was no longer growly, pseudo-colored; it was distinctly white, and high-pitched, and unmistakably frightened.

"Then at that opening-night cocktail party, you spotted Jonesy. You knew he wasn't a ship's officer. You knew he was a cop. Maybe you knew he was private, maybe not, but more important, you knew he had been a cop back in '34 in Chicago. "

"So what?" he said. He seemed to be shivering. Not entirely from the cold, either.

"You told Baltimore that you went to Cuba in the early thirties. That you hadn't been back in Chicago since. I remembered you from there, but my memory wasn't exact. . . . I would've guessed you were around till at least '34. . . and you were. You likened a babe in a skimpy outfit to those you saw at the Streets of Paris - which meant nothing to Baltimore, other than maybe you were talking about the real streets of Paris.

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But you weren't; you were referring to Sally Rand's old showcase^ the Streets of Paris, at the Century of Progress Exhibition, the Chicago World's Fair - in 1934. The very year, I've been told, via radio, that you were wanted for questioning in a murder. The murder of an undercover cop investigating narcotics traffic among musicians."

"Questioning ain't no big deal, " Scats said.

Willa's weeping, soft though it was, could be made out over the wind.

"You were a prime suspect, pal. Because of the undercover aspect of the investigation, it got no play in the press. And I wasn't a cop, then - / went private in '32. Jonesy, though, was a cop in '34. And he worked that case. You see, Jonesy didn't die saying 'she'; he died saying 'Chi -'for Chicago."

Scats swallowed thickly.

"You saw your whole future collapsing when you saw Jonesy at that party - and you didn't need Tarot cards to predict it. But you had the hatpin at the

ready, for Hannah, or Court and Ledger. . . Frankly, I don't know which plan you intended to follow. I just know you abandoned it; you improvised again, you rascal, you - you told Willa to douse the lights, maybe without even telling her why, and my partner was dead. Jonesy was dead. Your doing, you lowlife bastard. . ."

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"If you think Fm gonna cracky" Scats saidy his voice still white and afraid^ "you're wrong. I know you're bluffing. I know you don't really have anything to go on. . . just air. . . just theories. . . unreliable witnesses. . ."

"You and willing Willa went to Hannah's cabin that night - around eleven-thirty. Hannah had a meeting with Ledger and Courts a confrontation^ one would suppose. Anyway Willa here kept watch in the hall while you knocked on the door - and your ex-lover let you in her cabin. Why shouldn't she? She didn't know you were there to kill her - until she saw the gun in your hand. No curare for death this time: It had to look like the work of Court and/or Ledger. You grabbed a pillow for a silencery and then Hannah was on her way to heaven or helly depending. You went out in the hally to get Wilhy during which timCy the few seconds she had lefty Hannah must have arranged her 'dying clue' - quickly pulling appropriate cards from the Tarot deck on the dresser nearby. . . implicating 'The Lovers' in her'Death.'"

"That's the lamest riff I ever heard playedy" Scats saidy lapsing into his phony patois.

"I don't know how willing Willa was to play alongy " I said as her sobbing jumped in volumCy "but she helped 'set the scene': One of Rich

Ledger's cigars and a couple of Hy Court's cigarette butts were dropped in the garbage pail^ the Friendly letter was taken from its envelope. . . . Of course^ if Court and Ledger had really killed her^ they would have taken the envelope^ too - but you wanted them implicated^ so you left it."

'7. . . l-liked Hannah^" Willa said. '7 wouldn't hurt anybody."

"Noy but Scats here sure as hell would. And you helped him search the cabin for the jewels^ didn't you, Willa? They weren't the object of the killing, but taking them might help throw suspicion elsewhere. After all, you didn't need to steal them - you would have inherited them."

She swallowed and cried into her lace hanky.

"Your search was interrupted, though, by a knock on the door. . . Deja Bleu had stopped by, and left when her knock drew no response. . . but this was enough to spook you. You felt you could return later, after the ship was sleeping, to search for the jewels. Then you took a walk on the deck - and Scats, no doubt, took that opportunity to toss the murder gun overboard."

Scats edged away from me, his back to the railing, I edged closer.

"What you two didn't know was that the jewel thief aboard - one Dan Risi - saw you

leave. He was keeping an eye on Hannah's stateroom^ waiting for her to take a late-night stroll she had mentioned to her maid, Susie Tong - whom Risi was romancing for info. Anyway Risi noted your hasty exit, used a passkey to slip into the stateroom, and found the body. He also found the jewels - that is, the key to the jewels. Without touching anything else, Risi slipped out as quietly as he came."

'7 say the jewel thief killed her," Scats said, some confidence climbing back into his grin. "After all, the cat admits he was in that room, don't he?"

"He do. Scats, my man. He do. But he sure wasn 't the one who swam up behind Hy Court in the pool down there, stabbing him in the back of the neck with another curare-tipped object, leaving the Friendly letter among Court's effects, ducking into the steam room to give himself a damp alibi. You hoped - stupidly, vainly - that this death would be written off as a drowning, and the murders written off as the work of the drowned man. The only one you fooled was Trace, and that's no great feat. "

"A lot of people on this bucket coulda killed Court, " Scats said, his voice sounding whiter and whiter.

"Not really. Only a few people knew of the contents of Friendly's letter, and only the members of Hannah's household knew of

Hannah's penchant for hatpins. That eliminated a lot of suspects, Scats. But not Willa -and noty through her, you. Besides, I began to get suspicious of you when you reacted with concern when Court was killed. It wasn't in character, 'man.' You hated Court and advertised the fact."

"You're wrong about one thing, Heller," Scats said.

"Such as?"

"I didn't toss the gun overboard," he said, and his hand came out from under the flowing cape and the gun roared, blocking out the sound of waves and the ship's engines and even Willa's sobbing-turned-tO'shrieking as I dove for the deck and slid down the shuffleboard alley, yanking my own gun from under my arm, sliding on my stomach as shots ate up the wood around me.

My gun was in my hand and I was twisting around, but a shot caught my wrist, cut a red groove in the flesh, and my fingers wouldn 't listen to me; they just popped right open and my gun tumbled from my grasp.

Then he was looming over me, a dark, massive figure with a Cheshire-white grin in it somewhere, and the glint of gun metal in one hand.

"No more!" someone screamed.

Not me.

Certainly not Scats.

Willa.

She rode his back^ riding him like a demented child playing piggyback with an unwilling and confused daddy^ one hand looped around his neck, a fist pommeling the side of his face, and he raised his gun in hand just long enough for me to live awhile, and my hands searched for my gun in the near darkness, didn 't find it, but the fingers that went scrambling over the damp

deck found something round and hard - the shuffleboard puck! - and I hurled it like a discus at him.

It caught him in the stomach and he folded in two like a deck chair. She tumbled off and landed unceremoniously on her sweet confused butt, and I got up on my feet and charged him. Somebody was screaming again.

Me.

I grabbed his hand, the one with the gun, and dragged him, all four thousand pounds of him, to the nearby rail and slammed that wrist into the metal, and slammed it again, and the gun fell from his splayed fingers.

But he had recovered from the pain and surprise and was now enraged; his hands went for my throat and somehow my back was to the rail and he was bending over it. I slammed my fists into his side but he didn't seem to feel it; it was like pounding a punching bag in a gym

but the response was even less^ and the rounds crimson^ enraged face bearing down on me might scare me to death before my back was broken on the railing.

Then I got my knee where it counts^ and his grasp on my throat popped open and so did his eyes and his mouthy and I got out from between him and the rail and then I did somethings George^ that makes me look a little bad. But you must understand the extremity of the situation. Self-defense it surely was. No court in any land will convict me.

I pushed him over the side.

His scream was shrill and somehow as feminine as Willa'Sy which was simultaneous with his and formed an eerie harmony. He bounced off a lifeboat on the way down, turning his scream into a whimper of pain^ and then^ tangled in his cape^ he went in the drink. A little white cap of his creation followed.

Willa was looking over the side; I hung on to her^ afraid she would follow her lover overboard. Oddly^ she wasn 't crying now. She was silent.

Stunned into a mute beauty. Nor was she angry with me. Later^ perhaps. Now^ just numb.

The deck began to fill with passengers. The gunfire had been heard by someone^ it would seem. Among them were my fellow investi-

gators: Jack Miles^ Andy Baltimore^ Phil Phleniy Leslie Dither^ Trace, and Chico.

I told them Scats had gone over the side.

Trace, who didn 't seem to give a damn, stood with a drink in one hand and, lucky stiff, Chico in the other. Her lovely eyes were filled with compassion, even for the likes of Scats.

"He might still be out there!" she said. "We should throw in a life preserver, lower a boat, something. ., ."

"No need," I said. "Bastard sank like a stone."

date: Friday^ May 22^ 1938 TIME OF departure: Midnight destination: San Juan, Puerto Rico TIME OF arrival: 8:30 a.m. distance: 72 nautical miles WEATHER CONDITIONS: Bright sky and plenty of sunshine.

Epilogue

The Countess has reached her final des-tination^ the port of San Juan^ and the cruise is over. The intricate ice sculptures which had drawn appreciative applause at the gala midnight buffet are meltings drop by drop. Cosmetics and toilet articles and jewelry are being hastily tossed into monogrammed carrying cases. The rest of the handsome matched luggage is being whisked ashore.

Hurried farewells are the order of the day. Shipboard friendships end in a flurry of goodbyes as addresses and phone numbers are exchanged. Most of these will be discarded in the coming weeks. The atmosphere of artificial shipboard intimacy evaporates when the passengers return to the outside world of family and familiar companions.

The three bodies will be removed from the freezer-morgue and discreetly wheeled ashore^ well out of sight of the departing guests. The handcuffed and manacled notorious jewel thief^ the murderous accountant^ and the murderer's accomplice

wife will be turned over to the custody of the San Juan police.

The other principals in the Case of the Caribbean Blues will assess their own lives. Some, like the detectives and the journalist, will have a sense of a mission completed. Others will have to find new employers, new patrons, new well-heeled lovers.

But for now the tale has been told. The last guests have disembarked. The Cunard Countess is being scrubbed and vacuumed and freshened for new arrivals. It is their turn to sail this evening through the lovely cerulean waters. Bon Voyage to them. Their trip will be pleasant and untroubled.

Our voyage is over. May your journey home be safe. Until we meet again, hail and farewell.

Postscript

The United States Private Eye Association was formed before the Cunard Countess returned to port in San Juan.

Philip d'Artagnan Phlem was elected the first president.

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Before the year was out, he had stolen the dues money from the other members, and the association never met again.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS*

^Members of the Mystery Writers of America.

MARY HIGGINS CLARK

Mary Higgins Clark was born in New York and is the 1987 President of the Mystery Writers of America. She has written six best-selling suspense novels and claims that when she isn't writing she feels as though she's playing hookey. Her great pleasure is the fact that many young people write to tell her that they began to enjoy reading after they "had to do a book report and your books were on the list and I read one and now I read lots of other books." Her fans also keep her humble. A recent letter from a 13-year-old said^ "I like your books so much^ I don't even mind the boring parts."

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MOLLY COCHRAN

In addition to co-authoring Grandmaster and High Priest, Molly Cochran has written seventeen other novels and nonfiction books^ including the best-selling Dressing Thin. Born in Tokyo^ she is a graduate of the University of Pittsburgh and has studied at the Sorbonne. Ms. Cochran and her husband^ Warren Murphy ^ live on a mountain in Pennsylvania with their son^ Devin.

MAX ALLAN COLLINS

Max Allan Collins is the author of the critically acclaimed historical novel True Detective (introducing Chicago private detective Nathan Heller), which won the Private Eye Writers of America's Shamus Award for Best Hardcover Novel in 1984. Its sequel, True Crime, was nominated for the same award in 1985; a third Nathan Heller novel. The Million-Dollar Wound (1986), was similarly acclaimed, with a fourth. Neon Mirage, due from St. Martin's Press in January, 1988. His writing credits include: three other suspense series, Nolan, Quarry, and Mallory; his latest book, The Dark City, a novel about real-life "Untouchable" Eliot Ness, which initiates yet another series (for Bantam Books). He is also the co-author of a Mystery Writers of America award-winning critical study of Mickey Spillane (One Lonely Knight, with James L. Traylor). Collins has been the writer of the

celebrated Dick Tracy comic strip since its creator^ Chester Goulds retired in 1977. With cartoonist Terry Beatty^, he created comicbook detectives

Ms. Tree and Mike Mist;, as well as the recent DC mini-series "Wild Dog.-

In his "spare time" he performs with a 1960s-style rock band. He lives in Muscatine^ Iowa^ with his wife^ Barb^ and their four-year-old son^ Nathan. Of late^ Barb has taken over the writing chores on the Crimestopper's Textbook feature in Dick Tracy and the Mike Mist minute mystery feature in the monthly Ms. Tree comic book.

GREGORY MCDONALD

Author of eighteen books^ seventeen of which have been fiction^ fifteen international best-sellerS;, twelve mysteries (the universally popular nine Fletch and three Flynn novels)^ twice winner of the Edgar Allan Poe Award (19753 1977)^ Mr. Mcdonald is past president of the Mystery Writers of America. The Paramount-Universal film Running Scared^ based on his 1964 novels starring Gayle Hunnicutt and Robert Powell;, directed by David Hemmings^ was released worldwide (except in the United States^ where it has never been released)^ in 1972. The Universal film Fletch, starring Chevy ChasC;, directed by Michael Ritchie^ was released in 1985. A second Chase-Ritchie film in a Fletch series is to go before the cameras in 1988. In 1973 Mr. Mcdonald left The Boston Globe as Arts and Humanities editor (chief of critics) and critic-at-large columnist. The Education of Gregory Mcdonald (Warner Books^ 1985) is compiled mostly of close-up sketches of

happenings and personalities (John Wayne, Abbie Hoffman, Krishnamurti, Louise Nevelson, Joyce Grenfell, Joan Baez, Gloria Swanson, Jack Kerouac, etc.) Mr. Mcdonald wrote during his seven years at The Globe. Other Gregory Mcdonald titles are: Safekeeping, Who Took Toby Rinaldi?, Love Among the Mashed Potatoes (Dear M.E.). His most recent novel is A World Too Wide. In 1987, his mystery/comedy/drama, Bulls-Eye, was produced at the Cox and Curry Theater, Giles County, Tennessee. Gregory Mcdonald graduated from Harvard College in 1958. He married Susan Aiken in 1963. The Mcdonalds have two sons, Christopher Gregory and Douglas Gregory. Although they still maintain a home in Massachusetts, the Mcdonalds consider their homeplace to be in Giles County, Tennessee.

RICHARD S. MEYERS

Richard Meyers has worked in every communications medium except radio. He co-wrote one film^ served as special media consultant for the 1986 version of "The Twilight Zone" television show^ then wrote and directed four made-for-videotape features in Los Angeles and Hong Kong. Although best known for his column in the Armchair Detective magazine and his Edgar Award-nominated TV Detectives nonfiction book^ he has also served as contributing editor for three film magazines^ and is author of infamous volumes concerning exploitation and Kung Fu movies. Under his own name and several otherS;, he has written many popular science fiction^ police^ and espionage thrillers - all for Warner Books. His recent and upcoming work includes The Kohga Ritual^ The Zanjanko Secret^ and Death on the Air: The TV Mystery.

WARREN MURPHY

Warren Murphy is the author of more than eighty novels, including the Edgar Award-winning Trace detective series, and the long-lived Destroyer adventure series, which was the basis for the motion picture Remo Williams: The Adventure Begins. He also wrote The Red Moon, selected by the West Coast Review of Books as Best Adventure Novel of 1984, and The Ceiling of Hell, winner of the Private Eye Writers of America's Shamus Award. Grandmaster, the first of Murphy's collaborative works with Molly Cochran, was an immediate best seller and earned the authors both the Mystery Writers of America's Edgar Award and the 1985 Fiction Writer's Award.

BILL AND KAREN PALMER

Bill and Karen Palmer are the owners of Bogie's, the only mystery-oriented restaurant and bar in the world. Murder/dinner parties had their New York debut here, and the monthly events feature participatory whodunits in which everyone can become a detective.

After being involved with mystery weekends for over ten years, the Palmers created "Bogie's Murderous Mystery Tours" in January 1984. They have since perpetrated many murders in domestic and exotic locales. Members of the Mystery Writers of America, the Private Eye Writers of America, and

the Crime Writers Association, Karen and Bill write, direct, and produce their analytical, play-fair whodunits.

The Palmers have appeared on TV on "Hour Magazine," "Daytime," the Channel 2 News, and twice with Joe Franklin on WOR. Their mystery weekend, "Murder at the Grand," was televised on WKYC TV.

They have been interviewed on radio on the "Voice of America," Canada's "Basic Black Show", WBAI, the "Patricia McCann Show" on WMCA, the "Warren Pierce Show" in Detroit, and the "Mystery Maize" on WNYE. They were among the winners of Showtime's contest "Murder in Space," and gave a talk on solving mystery puzzles and games at the January 1985 Mohonk Mystery Weekend. Bill has co-authored a radio mystery show which was played in Germany, Switzerland, and on England's BBC.

Both Bill and Karen hold black belts in Kokushiryu Goshinho Jujitsu and have been teaching for over thirteen years. Bill's self-defense class was listed in New York Magazine as one of the ten best in New York City. They currently teach at the West Side YMCA.

Bill, a fourth-degree black belt, holds the highest rank awarded in his style, and is the sole recipient of the "Renshi" teaching certificate. Both have also studied judo, aikido, and karate. They have co-authored a book entitled Martial Arts Movies: From Bruce Lee to the Ninjas, published by Citadel Press, and are currently working on their second book. They are film reviewers for the cable TV show, "Martial Art Forms," as well

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as for Martial Arts Movie Associates fanzine, and the forthcoming book TV Key.

Karen is a licensed psychotherapist/hypnotherapist, in private practice in New York City, and is listed in "Who's Who of American Women." She is a teacher of self-hypnosis, past life regression, and psychic development.

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ROBERT J. RANDISI

Robert J. Randisi is a well-known and respected private eye "activist" who has devoted much time and energy to promoting the Private Eye genre. To this end, some of his major accomplishments have been:

1. The founding, in January 1982, of the Private Eye Writers of America, a writers' organization that was fast in gaining the respect of the industry. He has served as vice-president of PWA, and has been editor of its newsletter, "Reflections in a Private Eye," since the organization's inception, and is now the permanent executive director;
2. He has created the Shamus Award, which is presented each year by PWA to the best in Private Eye fiction;
3. He has instituted the annual PWA Anthology, the first of which was *The Eyes Have It* - for which he was the editor - published in December 1984, by The Mysterious Press - in trade and limited editions - to much critical acclaim. Stories

from the collection have won both Edgar and Shamus Awards. The second^ *Mean Streets*, was published by The Mysterious Press in October 1986;, and garnered an Edgar nomination. The thirds, *The Shamus Game*, will be published by The Mysterious Press in 1988.

He is also the co-publisher and co-editor of *Mystery Scene* magazine.

In addition^ Mr. Randisi is the author of six private eye novels of his own: *The Disappearance of Penny* (Charter Books^ 1980)³ which features Private Eye Henry Po; and the "Miles Jacoby" series^ *Eye in the Ring* (Avon^ 1982)^ *The Steinway Collection* (Avon, 1983), and *Full Contact* (St. Martin's Press, 1984), a series that has received praise from the likes of Elmore Leonard and Harlan Ellison (a new Jacoby novel, *Separate Cases*, is forthcoming from Walker & Co.); and *No Exit from Brooklyn* (St. Martin's

Press), which introduces Brooklyn-based P.I. Nick Delvecchio, and has already been praised by the likes of Dean R. Koontz, Charles Willeford, and John Lutz.

His novel *The Steinway Collection* received a PWA Shamus Award plaque naming it as one of the five Best Paperback Private Eye Novels of 1983.

Full Contact was nominated for the

Shamus Award for Best Hardcover Private Eye Novel of 1984.

His short story "The Snaphaunce" was nominated for a Shamus Award as Best P.I. Short Story of 1985.

Mr. Randisi has also written novels in the Western, Espionage, and Men's Adventure genres.

Bob Randisi is thirty-five, and lives in Brooklyn, New York, with his wife, Anna, and their sons, Christopher and Matthew.

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